Isimo

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Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Category:
M/M

Fandom:
崩坏：星穹铁道 | Honkai: Star Rail (Video Game)

Relationship:
Mydei/Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail)

Characters:
Mydei (Honkai: Star Rail), Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail), Aglaea (Honkai: Star Rail), Anaxa (Honkai: Star Rail), Hyacine (Honkai: Star Rail), Castorice (Honkai: Star Rail), Tribios (Honkai: Star Rail)

Additional Tags:
Rivals to Lovers, Love Confessions, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Phainon is Down Bad (Honkai: Star Rail), Mydei is Down Bad (Honkai: Star Rail), Feelings Realization, Denial of Feelings, Mydei fell first and Phainon fell 2 stories, writing hate mails as a love language, the worldbuilding in this is so bad I am so sorry, no hypothetical carrier pigeons were harmed in the making of this, we hate caenis agenda 2025, Temporary Character Death, Minor Violence, Insecure Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail), Not Beta Read

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Isimo

by that_one_sleep_paralysis_demon

Summary

"Phainon, we need to address the terms of endearment being used for a man that you claim is your rival. More importantly, the nature of your messages."

"Castorice, I swear it isn't as bad as it looks"

"You called Mydei the light of your life and then proceeded to threaten to run him over."

"I have no defense"

Phainon, top recruit at CHRYSOS, finds his carefully constructed image faltering with the new recruit Mydeimos' arrival. It's hate at first sight— Mydei won't stop getting on his nerves and threatening his position. But as things start to go horribly wrong, he finds himself drawn closer to the unwelcome disturbance in his life that is Mydei.

Notes

Hi! I'm back after quite a while bc studies have been kicking my ass. This fic took way too long because of how many times I gave up on it because I hated it. BUT I did pull through in the end. Tbh this fic isn't that great, but it was fun to write. The title and chapter titles are based off the song Isimo by Bleachers (give it a listen, it's really good!)

Cw: This fic will have depictions of death, grief and (kinda) gory stuff, which is why I rated it Mature.

Without further ado, here is my second offering to the Phaidei council

Enjoy!

Edit 1: this fic has been translated to Russian!! It's at https://ficbook.net/readfic/0199b577-2535-750d-9147-5a53fdf78fff
I would like to thank Bobrulit for translating this fic, it means so much to me<333

Edit 2: GUYS THERES FANART. THERE. IS. FANART. (it's by LowPolyRen, check it out over here:)
https://bsky.app/profile/lowpolyren.bsky.social/post/3m3iknnie6k2g
THE EFFORT PUT INTO THE DESIGN IS INSANE I LOVE IT SO MUCH LOOK AT IT ITS BEAUTIFUL TYSM<3333

Edit 3: LowPolyRen THANK YOU SO SO MUCH FOR YET ANOTHER BANGER FANART YOU ARE SUCH AN AMAZING ARTIST<3333
https://bsky.app/profile/lowpolyren.bsky.social/post/3m3yjuxdh422a
Also yep the outfit design is 100% canon

Chapter 1: Yeah, you're just like the rain, carrying everyone's shame

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

If being adored was a drug, Phainon had no regrets getting high off it.

It gave him purpose. It made him feel the most like himself because he could be anything in anyone's mind. He played a hundred different roles in a hundred different minds; for admiration is constructing an image of someone from nothing but their shadow. There was no need to know the person behind the sunny smile and sky blue eyes since his admirers knew him as whoever they wanted him to be.

The distance was perfect, so why did he feel like a little kid sitting alone on the swings— watching everyone else laugh and play without him?

No. not this again, get a grip. You are not some poor soul forced into a life of suffering through this role. You chose it. You will bear it— just like how you shall bear the hopes of the organisation.

Perhaps the only two people close enough to him to be considered friends were Castorice and Hyacine—both of whose seats were empty when he entered the mostly vacant meeting room. He supposed Castorice had overslept again after staying up all night writing or drawing. Hyacine was probably called to the med bay— too nice to refuse treating yet another

patient. Or she was helping out as Prof A's teaching assistant. It was also on him for arriving far too early.

Phainon was a recruit at the CHRYSOS organisation, an institute dedicated to training exceptional individuals to fight against Black Tide creatures. The program involved everything from sending the recruits on missions for experience to in class lectures and physical training.

Okhema was the last civilisation that remained. Nobody was allowed outside and the only outsiders allowed were refugees. Outside the safe haven of Okhema, the Black Tide monsters lurked, ending civilisations. One of them was his hometown of Aedes Elysiae.

Frankly, it was too small to be considered a town— but as a child, it was his whole world.

He was picked up by Aglaea when he was about seventeen— or maybe sixteen. He doesn't remember when. His memories from that particular period of his life were sparse and littered with things he'd rather not look back on.

This was his final year in the training program before he graduated and went out into the world as a real agent. And he would pass with flying colours— Phainon would make sure of it.

Earlier, Professor Anaxa had informed the class that there would be a new recruit joining them. For someone to join the program this late, they would

have to be incredibly talented or incredibly stupid. Phainon bet on the latter, for no one in their right mind would possibly think they could keep up with the rest of the class— all of whom had been training for years.

There sat another person in the meeting room, a few rows of chairs in front of Phainon. The stranger had blonde hair dyed red at the ends. It reminded Phainon of fire, captivating but too intimidating to approach. From behind, it looked as though he was wearing a black leather jacket and had a bit of his hair in a braid that fell onto his right shoulder. Phainon didn't remember seeing such a unique silhouette around the facility before, so he knew this must be the new recruit Prof A. mentioned.

Phainon brushed off invisible specks of dust from his shirt and straightened his outfit. His entire wardrobe was curated by Aglaea to shield innocent bystander's eyes from his atrocious fashion sense— he didn't think his sense of fashion was *that* bad, but he acquiesced in her command anyways. With a confident stride, he headed to the row the new guy was seated at.

He didn't think he'd ever seen someone look so striking before. His hair from up close looked like a lion's mane and his eyes were a striking gold. Everything about the man seemed.. gilded.

It certainly didn't help that he was intimidatingly attractive.

Phainon walked over to the pretty strawberry blonde haired guy and gave him a light, easy smile. Most people would smile back, but this stranger gave no acknowledgement of his presence. Tough audience, but Phainon had full confidence in winning this person over.

"So, are you new here?"

"Yes."

Well, this guy was rather curt. No matter, this did not faze him in the slightest.

"Well, pleasure to meet you! My name's Phainon"

"I don't have time for pleasantries. I'm here to graduate from this training program and top the rankings."

How presumptuous.

"I'm afraid you have your work cut out for you"

"Why so?"

"Because the undisputed top ranker is standing right in front of you." Phainon said in the most amiable voice he could muster without it sounding

like he was planning murder. The new guy was getting on his nerves. The blonde scoffed and stood up, his eyes level with Phainon's.

Damn, the guy was tall and built as hell—

Phainon's brain cut him off from that train of thought as quickly as it could.

"What, so you think I can't beat you?"

"I think you'll find that incredibly difficult, Not saying that you can't, but for now, keep dreaming big."

"Is that a challenge?"

Something wild flashed in the blonde's eyes, daring Phainon to fight back.

Phainon returned the glare with a brilliant smile and poison coated by a sugary voice as he replied,"Would you like it to be?"

"Don't beg me to reconsider once I've begun the fight."

"As if I would. Unless, of course, you back down because you're too scared."

The stranger's fist was the first to fly, going straight for Phainon's jaw. Phainon dodged it and tried to land a kick on the other guy's side. The effortless way in which the stranger blocked the kick and struck a blow on Phainon's shoulder sent Phainon's mind reeling and he was pretty sure it wasn't because of the punch.

This guy could actually keep up with Phainon. Worst of all, it felt like he had an equal chance of winning. He was strong— stronger than anybody Phainon had ever come across. Blows were traded— some landed and some deflected. Phainon's ribcage throbbed, but he didn't care.

That was the most alive Phainon had felt in years.

In their scuffle, they had tumbled to the front of the meeting room, which was where Professor Anaxa found them.

"No fighting in the meeting room." A stern voice cut through the air, making Phainon and the blonde stranger pause. The stranger reluctantly let go of the collar of Phainon's shirt and Phainon

Well, there went Phainon's dignity.

It sure was nice while it lasted.

"I'm sorry, Professor Anaxa" Phainon gritted out, cringing at his feeble attempt to salvage his pride. At least nobody else in the facility was present to see the fight.

Anaxa sighed heavily and Phainon realised he hit a nerve with that apology. It was probably because he called him Professor Anaxa instead of Professor Anaxagoras. Anaxa— no— Anaxagoras was surprisingly touchy when it came to his name.

"Phainon, Mydeimos— you two are adults. This is not a place where you can brawl like children. Do you understand?"

"Yes, I understand. Although, I'd prefer you call me Mydei." The annoying guy— *what's his name? Mydeimos?* —answered.

Mydeimos… now where had he heard that name before?

Wait.

As if on cue, Phainon's brain supplied year old memories of him watching the news where they reported the death of Castrum Kremnos' dictator. *Killed by his son Mydeimos*— the reporter had said— *it seems the bloodline's legacy of patricide continues.* Mydeimos had chosen to abdicate

the role of the next dictator and left the citizens of Kremnos under the protection of Okhema's government.

The very same Mydeimos was glaring daggers into Phainon's skull, like he was itching to get one last punch in.

Phainon, you fool— of course he'd be capable of joining the training program this late. He's just that powerful and experienced. He led an army, you nitwit.

Phainon wondered if he had enough time to make a run for it and jump into oncoming traffic.

Anaxa cleared his throat and looked expectantly at Phainon, like he was supposed to say something. Phainon took a second to pray to every Titan out there to save him from this situation before mumbling his apologies.

"I too understand. This will not happen again."

Anaxa did not look mollified by his apologies. "Phainon, I expect you to share the coursework covered so far in this term and accompany Mydei in getting settled."

This day could not get any worse. Mydeimos looked just as horrified, an even deeper scowl etching itself into his features. It would do him some

good to smile more— maybe then the guy would look a lot more approachable and a lot less like he was saying *'I want to kill you where you stand and quite possibly harvest your organs'*.

Professor Anaxa sent them back to their seats as the rest of the recruits started to file in. Phainon trudged back to his seat and flopped onto the chair. Bad move, because he was pretty sure he bruised his tailbone on the hard metal. Darn the facility for its uncomfortable furniture. But as the greetings began, he plastered on his default charm.

"Morning, Phainon!"

"Good morning, Danae!"

"How's it going, Phainon?"

"It's going great, Cyrones!"

There. This was easy. This was familiar.

A soft voice sounded from behind him.

"Hey, Phainon."

"Ah, Cas! So you didn't oversleep after all"

Castorice cracked a small smile "Apparently not"

"Say, who's that new student over there?" Hyacine asked, placing her bag decorated with a multitude of charms and pins on the floor and taking her seat. A pair of bows tied her hair up into its signature ponytails.

"That's Mydeimos." Phainon said, trying his best to hide his contempt for the guy.

"No way— you mean *that* Mydeimos?"

"Yes, *that* Mydeimos."

"Interesting. I heard he's quite skilled in hand to hand combat. His fighting style must be like yours then" Castorice mused

Phainon internally grimaced. Indeed, Mydeimos' fighting style was like his — but he seemed to focus more on strength than speed, unlike Phainon. That meant his punches and kicks *hurt*, as evidenced by the throbbing pain on his body.

Phainon gave a weak laugh "I'm supposed to 'show him around' and share the course material with him"

Castorice's mouth formed an 'o' shape and Hyacine nodded solemnly

"Yeah, good luck with that."

I'll need the luck, Phainon thought to himself after the lecture was over. The walk to Mydeimos' seat felt like a walk to the gallows. He could see it in his mind's eye— a man marching over to the guillotine that he was inevitably sentenced to.

"Hey, Mydeimos?"

"I prefer to be called Mydei."

"Right, right. Uh… I'll need your number"

Mydei raised an eyebrow, looked up from his phone and deadpanned "Don't you think it's a bit too early for that?"

Phainon blushed, his smile faltering.

"I didn't mean *that.* I need some sort of contact information so I can reach you."

"I'll give you my email address."

"Cool!"

Phainon hoped his grin didn't look as painful as it felt.

Mydei scoffed, but wrote down his email address on a sheet of paper. His handwriting was just as neat and as put together as he was.

Phainon was irrationally jealous of how self assured Mydei seemed. Mydei didn't look like he had ever felt anxious of what other people thought of him and wonder if he was even worthy of their praise. He clearly never practised smiling in the mirror until his cheeks hurt and he had perfected a winning smile. He never had to wear the perfect smile and say the perfect things and wonder if the real him even existed anymore.

Lucky bastard.

Professor Anaxa was waiting for Phainon outside the door. He corrected the eye patch over his eye before affixing Phainon with a stern glare with his good eye.

"Phainon, you should know that I do not take kindly to violence within the facility. This may not be a proper educational institute, but fighting a fellow recruit is unacceptable. You are incredibly lucky that you're getting only a warning and that nobody else was there to report this incident. I let Mydei off since he's new, but you should really know better."

Phainon flinched slightly, regretting how defensive he got. "I'm sorry—wait, why is Mydei getting let off? Isn't equality what you stand for? Why isn't he getting reprimanded too?"

"Mydei has his reasons for joining this late and I highly doubt that he's familiar with Okhema's customs."

"But how—"

"*Phainon.* I recall giving you multiple pardons when you first joined the facility. Is it not equality if Mydei gets the same treatment?"

Phainon sucked in a breath, wincing as he remembered his past self's stand-offishness and difficulty in adjusting.

Great. Now Phainon's embarrassed himself in front of Professor Anaxa for the second time in under an hour.

Anaxa sighed "I hope you understand now. Since you came here from Aedes Elysiae, you know what it's like to be new. I expect you to try to get along with Mydei, even if guiding him around is too difficult a task for you." He turned around after he took a few steps away "Don't forget to share the lecture notes with Mydei. I can count on you to do that, yes?"

"Yes" Phainon replied.

The sting of embarrassment would not leave him even as the day progressed. It felt like he was swallowing something bitter over and over again. His stomach curdled every time he recollected the time he lost his composure.

On the topic of doing things he regretted, Phainon also regretted claiming to be the top ranker in the facility. Sure, he was the best at fighting and excelled in debates, but there truly wasn't much else to him. For all he cared, he was top ranker only in name and popularity.

He did consider, at some point, sending a message to Castorice and Hyacine about his current predicament, but didn't follow through with it. Castorice was busy in the labs and Hyacine was working in the med bay or assisting Professor Anaxa and Phainon wasn't sure if they'd want to hear him be pathetic.

Flopping onto his bed after a day made excruciating, Phainon wanted nothing more than to collapse and go to sleep.

However, he still had to send a certain blonde haired man the lecture notes of the past few weeks. He drafted a message and hit send.

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>10:15 PM
to Mydei ▼

Here are the notes for the lectures. No need to thank me.

Attachment

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>10:20 PM
to me ▼

Who said I wanted to thank you? Your ego doesn't need any more inflation.

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>10:22 PM
to Mydei ▼

And who said I wanted to send these to you? I should have given you a concussion earlier so you wouldn't have to nag me like this.

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>10:23 PM
to me ▼

How bold of you to assume I would let you land a hit like that on me. So far, I have deduced that you:

- *have a massive ego*
- *think the world revolves around you*
- *pretend that you're everyone's friend*

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>10:25 PM
to Mydei ▼

I'm honored that you've been observing me so closely. Pray tell, what purpose do these inaccurate observations have?

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>10:25 PM
to me ▼

Don't flatter yourself, asshole.

Never mind, he wasn't so sleepy anymore.

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"And that's why I have a bruise on my left shoulder." Phainon recounted to a very unimpressed Hyacine who had to treat his wounds after a full day of them getting too painful to ignore.

"You should've come for treatment yesterday, Phainon" Hyacine reprimanded like a disappointed parent. Phainon tried to not look too upset

about being scolded— even if he hated it when people were disappointed in him.

"I know"

"Although I must say, I have never seen you despise someone as much as you do Mydei, let alone hate anyone at all."

"*Look at him*, Hyacine. *He's the problem*."

"So you're intimidated by him? Threatened by his presence? Is it like some wild animal adjacent thing in which you get possessive over your territory and position—"

"—NO! No— he gets on my nerves is all."

"Uh huh." Hyacine hummed, regarding Phainon with a bemused glance. Phainon couldn't believe he was being compared to a wild animal. Sure, humans were just evolved wild animals with a consciousness, but that didn't stop him from feeling insulted.

Hyacine packed up the gauze and ointment "All done! You can go now. For the love of Kephale, don't ignore your wounds next time." She shuffled over to the counter and began organising the tools there and continued "You should have told me about the whole Mydei situation sooner."

Phainon smiled and gingerly prodded his dressed wounds.

"Sure, I'll do that next time."

He could tell Hyacine didn't believe his words. He didn't either.

He definitely regretted having to limp around the rest of the day, brushing off others' concerns for his health. He was fine, just a bit banged up. Mydei was nowhere to be seen. A petty part of Phainon hoped he was just as wounded as he was.

That evening, he got a call from Castorice.

"Phainon?"

"Yeah, hi! What's up?"

"I heard from Cinny you got into a fight with Mydei."

"Yeah."

"When were you going to tell us? Had you not chosen to get treatment, would we have never found out?" She asked, reproachful

"I swear, I would've told you—"

"—You wouldn't have—"

"Sorry."

Castorice sighed heavily. Great. Now he's disappointed three people and it was all because of Mydei's arrival.

"Look, we care. We want to be there if you need help. If that includes help at beating him in the next ranked mission, so be it"

"Seriously?"

"Yes."

Phainon wanted to believe her, he truly did. But would Castorice still choose to help Phainon if she knew what he'd done and who he'd been?

Would she still spend long nights talking to him and Hyacine about her latest creation? Would she still see him as a friend she could tell anything and everything to?

Phainon really, *really* didn't want to know the answer to that question, so he laughed lightly and said, "Thanks, I'll keep that in mind."

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Castorice stayed true to her word, handing Phainon a few vials of poisons that she said would immobilise the Black Tide creatures.

She was lucky— she didn't have to undergo training meant for fighting in the front lines. She preferred experimenting with poisons and working in the lab. Professor Anaxa had discovered Castorice's natural talent a few years ago and immediately sent in an appeal to have her work in the labs.

Castorice loved working in the labs. For as long as Phainon had known her, she'd always been withdrawn— so her expressing a love for something was incredibly rare. He was glad she found something that resonated with her.

There was this shine that some people seemed to have when they were truly passionate about something. When they find that piece of themself, it would carve itself into their soul, wire their brains permanently. It would live longer then they, outlasting death— forever immortalised under their name.

That wholeness was something Phainon would never get to feel, but he felt close to it when he won.

So he'd have to get the highest ranking in the mission because winning would restore his dignity.

Maybe he'd jinxed it because there was no way this was happening.

Phainon was to be paired with Mydei. His phone screen seemed to mock him as he read the assignment partner list sent by Tribios over and over again. The poisons Castorice had provided him with felt redundant.

There was no way in Amphoreus' twelve titans that this was real. He tried to convince himself that it was all an oddly realistic fever dream. Or better yet, have hidden cameras pop out of the walls and have someone yell 'gotcha!' because this was some elaborate prank.

Unfortunately, Phainon was not high off his rocker or being played a fool.

Mydei walked into the briefing room at that exact time, his eyes burning holes into his phone. Overall, Mydei looked just as displeased to be paired up with him as Phainon was. Displeased may have been under exaggerating the murderous looks being thrown his way. Phainon would like to hold onto his organs, thank you very much.

"I'm not any happier about this than you are." Phainon sniffed.

"Evidently." Mydei retorted before sitting on the chair next to Phainon.

The room fell silent as Tribios, a mentor at CHRYSOS, entered. She would be the one conducting the briefing for the mission.

Phainon shot up and stumbled slightly as he made his way over to her "Miss Tribios— is there any chance we can change our partners for this mission?"

"Why? Is there a problem with being partnered up with Mydei?"

Yes, Phainon's brain screamed, *there is a very big, Mydei- sized problem.*

But the others in the room were looking at him curiously and he knew that one wrong word could send his reputation straight to the gallows. So he sucked it up and shook his head, feigning innocence "No, no not all. I'm sorry for disturbing you."

He fled back to his seat in the most dignified manner possible, considering the eyes trained on him.

"No luck in getting rid of me, huh?" Mydei asked, looking at Phainon through the corner of his eye.

Phainon was too peeved to respond.

Mydei— 1 , Phainon— 0

Mydei sat in silence through the rest of the briefing and remained stone faced as they geared up for their mission in the locker room. Phainon tried to focus on pulling his shirt over his head, but his gaze was drawn to Mydei as he pulled off his turtleneck.

Oh titans, his body was ridiculous.

Red tattoos that resembled fire curled around his body. His muscles looked even better than they did with his shirt on—

Nope— not going there— Phainon's brain interrupted his train of thought and he wrenched his eyes away from Mydei. He busied himself with packing his bag and weapons. It was always a struggle to put on his gear— but any distraction was a welcome one.

If Phainon noticed Mydei's eyes scrutinising his own body, he made no remark.

For once, Phainon decided to forgo small talk and keep his mouth shut as they walked out the doors of the CHRYSOS facility. The sun beat down on them relentlessly and the city hummed with life beyond them. Skyscrapers lined the view, cars zooming past. Each time he saw the city, it felt like the first time he had set foot in Okhema.

As Phainon fumbled around his pocket for his identity card to board the subway, Mydei held up a hand.

"My bike." Mydei said, although it sounded more like a demand than an offer.

Talk about picking your poison.

He was essentially trading being gawked at with being in close proximity with Mydei. To be fair, public transport would too crowded with all the people swarming to talk to him and take pictures— such was the price of fame.

Phainon rarely ever went to the garage provided by the facility, given that he didn't have a vehicle to call his own. Mydei's bike was a sleek black motorbike whose brand a plebeian such as Phainon could not recognise. Mydei tossed a helmet at Phainon, not caring if he got socked in the face.

That was probably reason number nine hundred and ninety nine for why Phainon hated Mydei.

Phainon cursed under his breath, dreading the ride. He should have just taken public transport.

It wasn't long before they were zipping through the streets of Okhema at breakneck speeds.

"If you wanted to break my ribcage, you have a hundred more efficient means to do so. I don't see why you're so fixated on this one" Mydei said dryly

"Shut. Up." Phainon gritted out, not caring that his grip around Mydei's waist was suffocating. The wind howled against his ears as they broke the speed limit, multiple laws and basic road safety rules.

"You're just afraid."

"Of dying? Well, I'm sorry I want to live!" Phainon yelled, flinching every time they went over a speed breaker. Nothing seemed to faze Mydei, not even the very real threat of death, apparently.

Mydei scoffed derisively.

The bike screeched as Mydei pulled up to the walls that enclosed Okhema city. The two hour subway transit was shortened to a mere thirty minutes. Thirty minutes of suffering on Phainon's end, but thirty minutes all the same. Phainon stumbled off the bike and never had he loved the ground as much as he did in that moment.

Phainon took out a hilt that expanded and transformed into his pride and joy — the sword Dawnmaker. Mydei just stood there, unimpressed.

"You gonna go in and fight with your bare fists?" Phainon asked, bemused. Most recruits used weapons of some sort, so someone going in with nothing but their bare fists sounded like a death sentence to Phainon. However, Mydei himself was the walking definition of a death sentence.

Mydei frowned "Yes."

"Good luck with that"

Mydei turned on his heel, only to vault over the wall. Phainon gaped— that was been a twenty foot wall at the very least, and Mydei effortlessly scaled it.

Show off. Especially when there was a perfectly functional gate to use. Phainon chose to use the gate like a woefully normal person to find Mydei already locked in battle with Black Tide creatures.

Turned out, he did fight with his fists after all. And Phainon would be damned if he said the way Mydei fought wasn't impressive. Mydei moved with a ferocity and grace that was unparalleled. Seeing him fight— actually fight and not wrestle— was a surreal experience. Mydei was essentially a blur of gold and red, with his battle armor glinting under the sun. He was the very embodiment of fire— unpredictable and mesmerising.

But Phainon wasn't going to fall behind so easily. He still had Castorice's poisons on hand and this might be his chance to win against Mydei, even if it was a small win. He lunged at the first prowling Black Tide creature he laid his eyes on and sliced through it cleanly. Its eyes flashed with an undecipherable emotion before it crumpled to the ground.

Wait.

Eyes?

Black Tide creatures weren't supposed to have eyes. They were the Black Tide clothed in armor. Phainon was hallucinating this. He had to be. The ride must have messed up his sense of cognition or something.

Phainon had to prove to himself that he was better than Mydei, not see things that weren't even real. He forced his legs to move.

As Phainon hacked and slashed his way through the Black Tide creatures, Mydei seemed to have taken notice. Now, his eyes were on Phainon too, just like everyone else's eyes always were. Perfect.

"Can't let you take all the credit now, can I?" Phainon said, flashing a charming grin Mydei's way, giving Dawnmaker a quick wipe to rid it of the blood. The poison was doing wonders, stunning the Black Tide creatures before Phainon cut through them.

He made a mental note to thank Castorice for her help.

"Tch. HKS."

"Hai— what?"

"HKS. It's an insult."

"I'll make sure you eat your words the second I defeat all the creatures here — HKS and all." Phainon retorted

"How bold."Mydei scoffed, "I'll take you up on that. If I defeat more of these creatures, I win." he added, kicking down a Black Tide creature and crushing its armor. A loud crunch reverberated through the air. It sounded a lot like a skull being crushed— a thought Phainon would rather not dwell on.

"It's on, showoff."

Much to Phainon's chagrin, Mydei happened to be the best partner he's ever had for a mission. At some point, they ended up fighting to cover each other's backs . It felt like a dance— a well rehearsed, fluid one. Phainon had never felt that powerful before.

Kephale, save him.

Mydei dropped the final Black Tide creature at Phainon's feet and announced "Thirty."

"Ugh— don't go dropping these things in front of me— I'll trip. You'll be the first suspect."

"I don't care if you trip and fall. Fall into a ditch for all I care— then I won't have to listen to your incessant chatter"

"Shut up." Phainon bit back and did a quick mental calculation of the number of creatures he felled "Thirty. Know what? I'll beat you next time and then you'll see."

Well, there goes another shred of his pride. He couldn't defeat Mydei. Again.

Mydei shot him a judgemental glare as he reported the success of the mission to Aglaea, the head of operations. He ran a hand through his blonde hair, which shone in the light. It was annoying how his hair looked perfect even after a fight while Phainon's looked like a rat's nest.

"Let's head back." Mydei said, breaking the silence

"I'll take the subway, thank you very much."

"Don't you think Aglaea would notice if only one of us got back?"

Damn it all, Mydei had a point.

Phainon braced himself for the horrors of Mydei's bike.

He hated the feeling of zipping through the streets, hanging on for dear life and praying to make it back in one piece.

"Couldn't— you— go—" Phainon heaved, trying to still his racing heart after Mydei parked in the CHRYSOS facility's basement "—A bit—

slower?"

Mydei shook his head "That's not an option."

"Well, you should certainly make it one!"

Mydei ignored him, walking leisurely towards the lift. Phainon wanted to strangle him then and there. Reputation be damned. Swallowing back words he yearned to throw at Mydei, Phainon followed him to Aglaea's office. It looked like they were the first group to arrive back at the institute.

Aglaea's office was adorned by bookshelves. Soft jazz music played on the antique gramophone. Her office smelled like flowers, even though there were no blooming flowers to be seen. Aglaea looked up from behind her mahogany table and set her pen down.

"Good job on the mission." She said approvingly. Praise was as rare as diamonds from her "I'll have to pair you two up more often."

No. Anything but that. Phainon wanted to protest, but one look into her pale green eyes and he knew it was better to not argue.

Mydei, however, spoke up. "Miss, I believe one mission was more than sufficient" His voice was strangely polished and formal with Aglaea and

Anaxa. It was like the only person on earth he deemed unworthy of such courtesy was Phainon.

"Hm? Well, it sure would be a shame if such a duo were to never form again. Such efficiency is rare"

Aglaea had identified them as a good team and she was, under no circumstances, going to let such an opportunity go by. That much was clear to Phainon.

"Alright." Mydei responded, also having realised that arguing was futile. It was strange, seeing such a stubborn person bend so easily. Then again, it was Aglaea and her words were more often than not, final.

Aglaea sat back down on her chair and picked up her pen, resuming her work. The first time Phainon saw Aglaea, he was reminded of one of those dolls Cyrene used to play with when she was a child; her face ethereal, but eyes hollow.

"Brilliant. Now I have to see you more often" Mydei hissed as soon as they set foot into the hall.

"What? You're acting like you're the victim here. If anyone's the victim, it's me!" Phainon exclaimed, incredulous.

"HKS, stay out of my sight. That's all."

"As if I wanted to exist within your proximity."

Mydei snorted "And yet, I find myself bumping into you far too often."

Phainon shoved the locker room door open with more force than he should've used and made a beeline for his locker. He peeled off his armor and let the metal clang to the floor, not caring if it made some other poor soul who happened to be there at the same time jump.

"Any louder and you'll wake up the dead, HKS." Mydei remarked, stretching like a cat.

"Well, maybe that's just what I'm going for."

Phainon was still fuming as he changed into his normal clothes, while pointedly turned away from Mydei. He gathered his things and plastered on his signature smile as he walked by his fellow recruits. Some asked him how his mission went and others admired him for who he was. The golden boy, whose smile rivaled the sunshine. The perfect person to shoulder the hopes of the CHRYSOS organisation and eliminate the Black Tide for good. The Deliverer, the faculty called him when they thought he wasn't listening. A role he had no choice but to take— a role that would take sacrifices aplenty. He would bleed for the sake of everyone else.

Phainon was on a pedestal he'd worked so hard to get on and now he no longer felt the rush of victory or recognition.

He didn't feel like he deserved to be there at all.

No, Phainon was not going to drown in his feelings. Not today— or ever. It was to nobody's fault but his own that he absorbed other people's emotions like a sponge and gave back only what they wanted to see. It was his own fault that he craved to be loved, so he wore a hundred different faces. Maybe that's why it was so hard for him to get along with Mydei. Mydei was nothing if not his honest, brutal self. Phainon didn't know if he had it in him to be who he really was—or if his true self hadn't suffocated and died already.

Mydei.

In the span of about 60 hours, that stuck up brute had knocked down the careful house of cards Phainon had constructed for himself.

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>2:40PM
to Mydei ▼

Dear Mydei,

This is to let you know that I despise the arrangement planned out for us. Kindly maintain your distance from me.

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>3:00PM
to me ▼

HKS,

Stay out of my way and I'll stay out of yours.

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>3:01PM
to Mydei ▼

Dear Mydei,

I don't need to be told twice to avoid you, you brash showoff.

Thank you,

Phainon

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>3:10PM
to me ▼

Dear HKS,

I would like to preface this by saying that I have never despised a person as much as I do you. How you manage to make my contempt for you grow with each interaction is astounding.

Best regards,

Mydei

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>3:12PM
to Mydei ▼

Dear Mydei,

Likewise. I do think it would do you some good to shut up and smile more, though.

Thanking you,

Phainon

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Seeing the eyes on that Black Tide creature must've messed something in his head up. Phainon must've burnt the image of the eyes deep into his mind with a hot iron because it just wouldn't leave him. When he stared out of the window during his classes, he'd sometimes see that haunting glare staring back at him. He'd see it in his nightmares, mixed with scenes from the past he's not even sure happened any more.

Phainon didn't tell anyone or make a big deal out of it. He just dealt with it the way he dealt with every other problem in his life— he repressed it until it no longer existed.

Mydei, however, was a problem he couldn't ignore.

Over the next few weeks, he kept running into Mydei on a daily basis, sometimes almost two times a day. The amount of Mydei exposure was concerning, frankly. Each interaction they had was no better than the last. More disconcertingly, Mydei seemed to be excelling at training— as per the

leader board chart shown at the end of each week. Phainon hated feeling like he was standing on a trapdoor that could give way any second. His position was faltering and he was afraid that he could lose it entirely.

That must have been the reason for his emails lording his 'wins' over Mydei — chasing after the victory rush he felt when he did better than Mydei in an eval. In his emails, he could be as petty as he wanted.

But in real life, Phainon had to pretend like he didn't actually hate Mydei for the sake of his image. He was sure he'd cramped several facial muscles from the sheer amount of smiling he had to do. Mydei didn't have to pretend — he had the type of intimidating resting face that made him look like he was seconds away from committing arson.

Mydei had also, unfortunately, picked up on calling Phainon 'Deliverer'

Unlike everyone else, Mydei meant it as a point of ridicule. Ridiculous that Phainon was expected to swoop in and 'save' everyone and 'deliver' justice.

"Deliverer, huh?"

"Shut up."

"What're you doing— delivering joy?"

"—Shut the actual hell up—"

"— No, because that nickname's incredibly cliche."

"I didn't choose that nickname."

"But you didn't stop them from using it."

Phainon found himself running into Mydei at a vending machine, his perfectly fine Tuesday destroyed. Well, Professor Anaxa had destroyed it before Mydei could by announcing a written test, but that's besides the point.

Mydei was hunched over the machine, tapping the side of the machine as he waited. He retrieved a packet of pomogranate milk from the machine and stood up.

Phainon snorted. Pomegranate milk was the least popular product sold in the facility's vending machines and here this oddball was, actually buying it.

"Buying pomegranate milk, huh? Don't tell me there's nothing else in the vending machine." Phainon remarked, leaning against the wall and tilting his head to the side. After weeks of observation, Phainon found the best

way to get under Mydei's skin was to prod at him and act as annoying as he could. Frankly, Phainon had no idea why he cared so much about getting under Mydei's skin specifically. Perhaps it was because Mydei was the perfect distraction from the strange eyes.

"It's an acquired taste" Mydei replied peevishly.

On second thought, maybe it was because of his reactions

Phainon laughed lightly,"Your acquired taste is strange."

"You're even stranger. Smile any wider and you'll be stuck wearing that weird smile for the rest of your life."

"Hey! Why do you even care?" Phainon exclaimed, suddenly feeling very self conscious about his smile.

"I don't, but it sure is strange talking to a walking mannequin."

A mannequin? Really?

"…I hate you."

"Looks like we agree on something , Deliverer." Mydei snarked before taking a sip of his pomegranate milk and striding away.

Phainon cast a sidelong glance at the vending machine and his curiosity got the better of him. He crouched, slotted in a coin and pressed the button for a pomegranate milk. After checking to make sure nobody was walking nearby, he took a sip.

It wasn't as bad as he thought it was.

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When he read Mydei's nightly text, he nearly threw his phone across the room.

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>10:50PM
to me▼

Dearest Deliverer,

This is to inform you that you are the biggest pain in the ass that has ever existed.

Best regards, Mydei.

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>10:51PM
to Mydei ▼

Dear Mydei,

Why thank you, you hard headed bastard. I shall frame your insult on my wall and admire it every morning, evening and night

With love, Phainon.

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>10:55PM
to me ▼

Deliverer,

If you're so obsessed with me, why don't you frame a picture of my face and stare it at every morning, evening and night?

Best regards, Mydei

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>10:58PM
to Mydei ▼

The light of my life Mydei,

Oh, yes, I already have. I've even stuck a few pins in your face as I eagerly await your downfall.

P.s. Watch both sides of the road as you cross

Yours truly, Phainon

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Phainon brandished his phone at Castorice as if to prove a point, his soggy excuse for a sandwich lying forgotten on a plate.

"See what I mean? He's annoying."

"Phainon, we need to address the terms of endearment being used for a man that you claim is your rival. More importantly, the nature of your messages."

"Castorice, I swear it isn't as bad as it looks"

"You called Mydei the light of your life and then proceeded to threaten to run him over."

"I have no defense"

"This is insane. What even is this? Some sort of intimidation tactic mixed with flirting?"

Phainon choked on air

"It's *hatred*, Cas. I'm just trying to be nice about it"

Castorice's face scrunched up as though she was studying a very strange specimen.

"If you say so"

Phainon scarfed down his sandwich, not caring if it was soggy or bland.

"Something's been bothering you since you came back from that mission and I know it isn't Mydei." Castorice said after a brief period of silence.

Phainon swallowed his sandwich

"No, there's nothing wrong"

"Phainon, I haven't known you for three years to not realise that something's bothering you."

As Phainon thought back to those bloodshot eyes, his hands felt numb and his throat constricted. He couldn't tell Castorice, for why would anyone believe in what was most likely a delusion?

Phainon casually waved his hand, dismissing her suspicions,"Castorice, I can assure you that I probably just look tired from today's training and lectures."

Castorice frowned and shook her head in defeat. "You will tell me if something's wrong, won't you?"

"Yeah"

Castorice seemed mollified by his reassurance and stood up, brushing her white lab coat "It's about time we head back to the building. Good luck for Professor Anaxa's test."

Test?

Oh.

Phainon was screwed. In his haze of hate mails to Mydei and eyes burned into the back of his mind— he'd forgotten about the written test. While most of the institute's assessments were physical, they did have a few written tests. This was one of them.

Phainon could imagine his hard earned first rank crumbling before his eyes. Mydei would overtake him and he wasn't sure if he could face the world again. He was losing his balance.

"Phainon? You coming in?" Castorice asked, watching Phainon space out in front of the classroom door.

Phainon gave a garbled reply, incomprehensible to even his own brain.

The rest was a fever dream for him. Later on, all he remembered from the test was obscure formulae and some calculations. He stared blankly at the paper, wracking his brain to *think*. His hands felt clammy and he could hear his heartbeat thud violently. The ticking of the clock prompted him to glance up every five seconds, willing the time to stop. He was going to fail and he would disappoint everyone. They would whisper silently as they read out the rankings and point out Phainon's drop in performance.

People would approach him, act concerned and ask *'what happened to you?'*

Phainon felt like he might cry right in the middle of the lecture hall.

His hands shook as he feverishly wrote down answers he prayed were right. He should've just gone to a normal college and lived an average life. Not this place, where he was expected to be the best. Not this place, where he had to deal with his crippling insecurities, academics and physical training all at once.

He felt like a cosmic joke as he walked out after the worst one hour of his life. Bile rose up in his throat as he heard the other recruits discussing the paper. They would look to him for the answers soon enough, so Phainon left their vicinity. He didn't bother waiting for Castorice since she probably went back to the lab.

The rest of the day had this surrealness to everything he did— like he was recovering from a fever. His body didn't feel like his own as he practised with Dawnmaker and nodded at the instructor's praise.

When he got back to his dorm, he felt less like he was in one of those low resolution cat memes Castorice liked to watch. He expected the haphazardly strewn about clothes to greet him as soon as he entered.

He did not, however, expect his dorm room to be flooded.

Oh, for Kephale's sake

Water gushed out of a broken pipe in the roof, pooling onto the floor. Phainon spent too long gaping at the wreck to realise the water had seeped into his shoes and socks. He winced at the feeling and nearly jumped when he heard another trainee's voice come from behind him.

Couldn't he have a minute of peace to grieve his room?

"Whoa, I think that's pretty bad"

Phainon bit back the urge to say '*you think? Look at it!'*

He had a reputation to maintain, even in his moments of crisis. He was not going to panic or act like anything was wrong. He forced a smile and laughed sheepishly, scratching the back of his head.

"Yeah, it is"

"Good luck, my guy. You'll need it" The recruit offered some sympathy before walking away.

Good luck, my foot.

Phainon cursed to himself as he waded through the water to salvage his belongings. He tried to shield himself from the spray of water as he walked past the pipe. Some clothes were dry and he could just wash and dry the others. He grimaced as he picked up a book, its pages soggy and beyond redemption. Phainon was a resourceful person— but even this would be too difficult to restore.

He heard a creak and snapped his head up to look at the ceiling. The roof was caving in too.

What the hell did he do to deserve this?

Phainon stuffed everything he could into an old, battered suitcase and made his way over to Aglaea's office. He could hear her speaking to someone—her words sharp and cutting.

"The Council of Elders are attempting to make reforms on the policies of the CHRYSOS organisation. A little birdie told me that they may shut this program down." Phainon knew that voice. It was Cipher — a recruit who chose to leave the program to work as a spy for CHRYSOS.

The Council of Elders was a political party that competed for Okhema's government. As far as Phainon knew, they'd existed for years on end but had never won a single election.

"Okhema will fall if we do not have the appropriate defense against the Black Tide. They surely know that. As for what we do: we fight back. It will take a while, but I'm positive we can hold our place." Aglaea replied.

"…Aglaea?"

"Yes, Cipher?"

"What if we lose the case this time around? What if the Council of Elders finds some way to take down CHRYSOS?"

"They won't." Aglaea's voice was sure and steady.

He knocked on her door once, and then twice.

"Yes?" Her voice echoed from inside the room.

"Aglaea, my dorm room's flooded." Phainon was too done with it all to care that he sounded like a child.

Aglaea opened the door, dressed in a clean cut, crisply ironed suit. Why she wore suits even at night, Phainon did not know. But her sense of fashion was immaculate— sometimes, Phainon wondered why she didn't just become a designer. She took off her reading glasses and peered up at him.

"How bad is the damage?" She asked gently.

"Everything's soaked." Phainon complained "My devices were unharmed because I carry them with me in my bag— but everything else is drenched. My books and bed and clothes and well— you get the idea."

"I'll arrange for a new place for you to stay at. Hold on, just wait outside on that bench."

Phainon was decidedly pissed as he sat outside Aglaea's office, waiting for her to make arrangements. He felt sixteen or seventeen again, hesitantly sitting in front of Aglaea's office on the very same spot. Soon to be her first student, he was still new to Okhema— unfamiliar with the big city and everyone in it.

"I found a place for you to stay until we can fully repair your dorm room." Aglaea announced, stepping out of her office, lease in hand. Best not to question her ways— finding Phainon a new roommate and house in under an hour.

Phainon gathered the suitcase and nodded "Thank you, Aglaea. I mean it."

Aglaea regarded him for a second before nodding "I'm sure you'll like the new accommodations."

He missed the plotting gleam in her eyes and Anaxa still on call with her.

"Come, I'll take you there." Aglaea said, walking Phainon to her car.

They pulled up to a huge apartment complex in the undoubtedly rich part of the city. Phainon felt like a speck of dust compared to the grandeur of the apartment. His origins as a country boy gave him even more reasons to feel unworthy for breathing the same air.

He got into the reception, trailing after Aglaea like a lost puppy. Which— to be fair— he did feel while lost in the opulence. Hell, there were even those grand chandeliers that cost an arm and a leg adorning the raised ceiling.

He watched as Aglaea pressed the lift button for the thirteenth floor and tried to not look as out of place as he felt in that glass elevator. Some part of him felt like a fish at the butcher shop back home, filleted and out on display behind the glass.

He didn't know what he was expecting as the doors opened and he stepped out, but certainly not this.

Not *him.*

Mydei gaped at Phainon as their eyes locked. He sputtered and whipped his head around to face Aglaea.

"*What*? Him? Miss, with all due respect, I agreed to accommodate a recruit whose dorm room flooded. *Not this moron.*"

"But you signed the agreement"

Mydei went silent, as if to regret all the choices he made that led him up to this moment.

Phainon was considering moving onto the streets. He'd helped on the fields under the burning sun and slept under the stars when he was a kid. He'd manage.

"Aglaea, take me back. Please. I— I'll find somewhere else to go."

"To one of your friends' places? You should've thought of that before the documents were signed."

"Uh—"

Phainon hadn't considered asking Castorice or Hyacine for help— he knew they were kind enough to lend a hand. But it felt so *wrong* to ask someone for a favour when he couldn't give anything back.

Mydei watched him with a bemused expression— or at least, that's what Phainon could infer. It was funny how Mydei was basically a different species altogether in his head. There was everyone else— predictable or too distant to reach and then there was Mydei.

He wasn't sure how to feel about that.

"So I'll have to stand this HKS for how long, exactly?"

"A month or two" Aglaea finished.

Mydei deflated at that and rubbed a hand over his face. Phainon wanted the floor to engulf him. The darkness didn't sound like bad company, any company was better than Mydei's company.

"Good luck settling in, Phainon." Aglaea said as the elevator doors closed behind her. Phainon had a feeling he was being abandoned— thrown to the wolves, perhaps.

Mydei cleared his throat and said, "Deliverer, stop looking like a kicked puppy and follow me. Don't touch anything in my house save for the room."

"Like I'd want to lay a hand on something you've come in contact with."

"Do you really want me to evict you before you've even stepped in?"

Phainon hated that he was even surprised at the sheer size of Mydei's apartment.

It was ostentatious, frankly— the high ceilings and lavish furniture. And yet, Mydei looked like he belonged there— in the midst of luxury. Perhaps in his past life, Mydei would've made a fine ruler. He could see in his mind's eye— Mydei, sitting atop a throne, adorned with gold. Mydei was the kind of person poets, artists and sculptors would create illustrious works about, immortalising him.

"Done gawking?" Mydei asked, flinging a door— presumably the door of Phainon's new room— open.

Phainon realised his lips were parted in shock and hastily closed his mouth before weakly saying"... You're loaded as hell."

Mydei didn't seem to be very happy about it, though. He shrugged and impatiently tapped his foot on the ground like he wanted to escape this situation as quickly as he could. "Are you going to enter the room or not?"

"Wha— huh— right. The room." Phainon muttered before picking up his suitcase with one hand and lugging it into the room.

He barely had any time to process what his room looked like before his stomach grumbled violently.

Shit.

He'd been meaning to eat a pack of chips or whatever snack he had in his dorm, but after everything that happened, the thought of hunger wasn't a priority.

"Wait here."Mydei disappeared down the hallway and returned with a reheated meal. In a bowl was the nicest looking fried rice Phainon had ever laid eyes on. "Well? Are you going to eat it or not?"

"Oh."

Phainon felt like he might burst into tears for the second time that day.

He swallowed the bubble of emotions rising up his throat and took the meal. He was not going to cry in front of his rival, no, not today— or ever. It tasted even better than it looked. He didn't even care that he was awkwardly standing at the doorway of his new room in a house that would still be more expensive than if Phainon sold all his organs.

"Thanks" was Phainon's garbled reply as he devoured the rice. Mydei nodded curtly and took the bowl, scraped clean, before walking away.

Phainon turned around and admired his new room, still unable to process that this was his reality now. It was so much larger than any room he ever

had— be it in the facility or Aedes Elysiae. He unpacked his suitcase and arranged his belongings in the closet provided to him.

After he was done organising, he took a step back and tried to not feel embarrassed at how all his clothes took up a mere fraction of the closet. It was like they were saying to him— *look at you, so small and insignificant*.

Not this again—

To distract himself, Phainon opened up the email chain and looked over the last few mails— sent yesterday.

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>9:30PM
to me▼

My one and only HKS,

Your eyes shine like the daytime sky— bright and unpleasant. Your face has a unique, punchable quality to it.

Forever hating you,

Mydei

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>9:40PM
to Mydei▼

My love Mydei,

To compare you to dust on the bottom of my sole would be such an insult to the dust. I adore making you mad so that one day, I can be free of you. I hope you dream of me every night and I hope those dreams are nightmares.

Yours adoringly,

Phainon

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>9:43PM
to me▼

Light of my life, star in my sky, Deliverer,

To dream of your would be like committing a felony against my own sanity. Don't worry, you'll be free of me once the final year is over. I will no longer have to tolerate your annoying emails and insults.

Your one and only hater,

Mydei

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>9:44PM
to Mydei▼

The yin to my yang(except you're all evil),

You do seem to have warmed up to me quite a bit, Mydei. Don't tell me, you actually enjoy writing such beautiful emails to me? Any more and you'll be sending romantic letters via carrier pigeons to my room. Of course, I'd return them to you with packages of explosives. (the birds shall not be harmed, don't worry)

Your other half,

Phainon

Phainon decided that he ought to thank Mydei for the meal earlier. Maybe, just maybe, living with Mydei for the next few months wasn't going to be so bad.

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>11:20PM
to Mydei ▼

Mydei,

The meal earlier wasn't bad. Thanks.

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>11:30PM
to me ▼

Deliverer,

What do you mean by 'wasn't bad'? If you wanted fancy dining, you were better off eating outside.

On one hand, Phainon didn't mean to come off as rude— he just knew that Mydei wasn't one to be swayed by honeyed words, so he didn't know how else to thank him. On the other hand, Mydei was a jerk.

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>11:31PM
to Mydei ▼

My dear sweet Mydei,

Why would I ever dream of eating anything but your expert cooking? I would like to withdraw my thanks.

Yours always and forever,

Phainon

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>11:33PM
to me▼

HKS,

For the record, I made dinner for the recruit whose dorm room flooded. Not you. If it was you, I wouldn't have put in so much effort. Let it be known that I dream of throttling you in your sleep.

With great care and affection,

Mydei

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>11:34PM
to Mydei▼

To my one and only Mydei,

So you do dream of me, after all. Tell me, do I look hot when you push me down and wrap your hands around my neck?

Yours lovingly,

Phainon

Chapter End Notes

Slaps roof of fic and that's chapter one of five done! Four to go and I'm still writing them with no clear end in sight.

Posting gives me so much anxiety so this took me days of steeling my nerves before pressing post (cries) but heyyy guess who's finally done it.

This fic will follow a schedule of a new chapter every week(at least, I'll try to keep a consistent upload schedule of once a week)

See you guys next week!

Chapter 2: A childhood you'll always mourn

Chapter Notes

> As promised, I got the second chapter out within a week and I have two things to say:
>
> First: I LOVE YALLS COMMENTS SO MUCH THEY HAVE A SPECIAL PLACE IN MY HEART<33333
>
> Second: I would like to thank everyone for taking the time to read this fic (ﾟ^ᗜ^ﾟ)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

That night, Phainon dreamed of a past long gone.

Phainon sat on a branch of the oak tree in the fields of Aedes Elysiae. The wind chimes strung on the tree by him and his friends clinked along to the breeze. The sky was a molten yellow, streaked with hues of fiery red. The sun steadily sank below the horizon, going to sleep for yet another night.

"Phainon! Come on, Ma's calling us for dinner!" A sweet voice called him.

The pink haired girl, Cyrene, waved at Phainon, beckoning him over. Phainon started climbing down the huge tree and stalked through the wheat fields. The season to harvest the wheat was drawing near, which meant sometimes helping his parents under the stars. After he approached Cyrene, she gave him a once over and dusted leaves out of his overalls and hair.

Cyrene plucked one last leaf from his hair and announced,"There, you're presentable now." Phainon giggled as she pinched his cheeks and took his sister's hand as she led him inside.

His parents' muffled voices could be heard from the kitchen

"The black tide's breaching civilisations. The village head's contacted the Holy City. They told us to lay low and stay in Aedes Elysiae. They said it wasn't a threat and we would be safe. Are we, though?"

"I heard about a Black Tide monster in the forests nearby. Should we consider leaving? "

"And leave our livelihood and where our children will grow up? We won't have any money to settle and I doubt any city would be willing to take us in."

"But—"

"Mom!" Cyrene called.

"Cyrene! Did you get Phainon to come inside?" His mother said.

"Yes, Ma! I'm back! Hi Pa!" Phainon exclaimed, hopping around on one foot as he tugged his boot off his right foot.

"Hello to you too." His father walked over to him and ruffled his hair. Laughing heartily, he headed over to the dining table."Come on, get over here."

"He's gonna get to the table once he gets his shoes off" Cyrene said, jogging away from him as he struggled to get his boots off.

"Hey! Don't leave me!"

His cozy little home faded into a pinprick of light as Cyrene kept running from him. Phainon stumbled after her, trying to catch up. But she kept moving farther away from him and no matter how hard he tried, he couldn't catch her. Tears streamed down his cheeks as he sobbed, his footsteps growing sluggish before he crumpled to the ground. It felt like he was sinking in quicksand, his limbs no different from metal.

Black crystals consumed what little light the place had as the unmistakable stench of blood permeated his nostrils. Phainon tried to close his eyes, only to have them forced open to face a different scene.

The streets of Styxia— the abandoned metropolis — was the first thing he saw as his eyes adjusted to the light of the broken neon signs littered around. The smell of smog mixed in with the stench of blood. Loud sirens

blared in the distance. There was nary a soul in sight, all of the other refugees or scavengers who had chanced upon the ruins.

Nobody questioned why there was a thirteen year old with dusty white hair and skin that clung too tight to his bones walking among them. They didn't look him in the eye or approach him, for kindness was a resource not many could spare. He spent those years killing Black Tide monsters and scavenging for survival, when he should've lived out his teenage years as a normal person.

He looked down at his bloodied hands, stained with the corrosion of the Black Tide as he stood over a pile of corpses. It wasn't an uncommon sight to see a desecrated corpse lying on the ground. Phainon tried not to think that that corpse once had dreams, wishes and a life. They were once someone's family, friend, lover. It felt so strange to have one's life there one minute and then taken the next, like all they had experienced in their life was irrelevant.

He slumped against a wall, holding back more tears from falling.

One of the corpses looked up at him— a pair of bloodshot eyes making contact with his as the world crumbled all over again.

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Phainon woke up with a start, staring at the ceiling like it held all the answers.

He now knew where he'd seen those bloodshot eyes before. The Black Tide creature in that mission with Mydei had the very same eyes. That thing looked too *human* for him to ignore.

He felt sick to his stomach.

Without thinking, he called Aglaea. His hands were shaking as she picked up.

"Hello?" Her voice sounded from the other line.

"That monster— all the Black Tide monsters— what are they? Why did one of them have *eyes*?"

"Phainon, we have never heard of a Black Tide creature that could have eyes."

"Then what did I see? Aglaea— what did I witness?"

"… I think this is a case of a mutated Black Tide monster. I've seen a few of them before. You've learned about them in the training program, I believe. Mutations usually come in the form of extra limbs and powers. Although, eyes must be another unique variety."

Phainon felt stupid, like he was a child seeking reassurance. "Really?"

"Yes. Really. I'll look into it further, though."

"Oh."

"…Do you need a break? Take rest over the weekend and I'll arrange a break from Monday. "

"No. I— I'm fine. I just had a dream. It's nothing, really. I'm sorry for bothering you."

"Phainon—"

He cut the call, unable to bear the shame that welled up in his gut. He'd let the pressure get to him and he'd lost it. He usually kept these paranoid breaks in character to himself, forcing himself to relive those moments until he either no longer felt them anymore or they consumed him entirely.

His throat constricted, and he felt himself physically recoil as the embarrassment hit him waves. He'd gotten ahead of himself and let his paranoia win. Maybe it was because it was his first time actually seeing one of these mutations.

He was losing his grip.

Phainon got out of bed with great difficulty and got himself ready before heading out of the room to get himself something to eat. It was already midday and he'd slept through the morning.

Mydei was already at the stove, making some fancy vegetable dish Phainon couldn't recognise.

Phainon veered around and tried to retreat, but Mydei's voice cut through the air.

"Sit. Lunch is almost ready."

Huh? Mydei— making lunch for him? Was this a part of his dream— maybe he never did call Aglaea and freak out. He pinched his arm, just to make sure. Nope, definitely not dreaming. Mydei must've gone insane, then.

"You made food for me?" Phainon asked, bewildered

Mydei's expression made it look like Phainon was the one out of his mind.

"Yes, is that so hard to believe?"

"Of course it is! You hate me!"

Mydei inhaled sharply and turned around. "Think of this however you want to, then."

Phainon moved toward the table apprehensively, "Is it part of the agreement Aglaea had you sign?"

There was a long pause before Mydei nodded— too late to actually mean it.

Lunch was a silent affair. The food wasn't as good as it was the previous night— or maybe it was and Phainon was just starving last night. His sense of taste wasn't the best. Mydei occasionally glances at him curiously, like he was expecting some sort of reaction from Phainon. Whatever it was that Mydei wanted, Phainon was not going to give it to him.

Phainon got up first, wordlessly picking up the empty cutlery and cleaning them.

"You look exhausted." Mydei commented, leaning against the kitchen island, holding a glass of water.

Phainon almost dropped the fork he was wiping. "Huh?"

He seemed to be scrutinising Phainon, his eyebrows furrowed, like he was trying to figure something out."Like someone's put you through hell and back."

"How very nice of you to comment on my bed head."

"You bed head's even worse than your face, but that's not what I'm talking about. Your smile is even more forced than normal and the bags under your eyes are concerning."

"Astute observation, my dear Mydei." Phainon scoffed.

Mydei rolled his eyes and walked to the couch, muttering what must be Kremnoan curses under his breath.

Phainon should've gone back to his room and done something else, rather than continue this conversation— but something in him wanted to stay. So,

he said the first thing that came to his mind to give him an excuse to stick around.

Phainon fidgeted awkwardly with the hem of his sweatshirt, speaking with the sunniest voice he could muster up."Hey— do you go to the gym in this apartment? The facility is kinda far away and I don't want to make that trip other than for lessons and training. Like, I can afford transport to the center, but only for a round trip if you get what I mean. Also, I don't have much on me to afford a gym membership right now—"

Mydei looked up from his phone, placing it back down on the couch.

"Your point being?"

"Stop cutting me off, I was getting to that." Phainon frowned, all pretenses of joy dropping "You're so impatient."

"HKS. If you want me to bring you along as a guest, just say so."

"Uh, can you do that?"

"Yes."

Well, that was easy.

Phainon really didn't want to be alone, so he flopped down on the couch next to Mydei. Mydei didn't react, so Phainon took it as an okay. This temporary truce felt peaceful. Neither spoke or moved from the couch.

Phainon's phone buzzed, and the gag notification sound Hyacine and Castorice had set for him played on full blast. Right there. In front of Mydei.

Phainon clamped a hand over his phone's speaker, but the damage was already done. Mydei looked up, startled by the volume. He could feel Mydei's eyes trailing after his retreating figure.

Phainon slammed the door behind him the moment he entered his room. He slumped to the floor, his back against the door.

Messages from Castorice and Hyacine flooded his phone.

Castorice ʕ ͡ ͜ ͡ ʔ

Phainon, I heard that your dorm flooded???

⋆｡˚ ☁ Hyacine⋆｡˚ ☁

WJAT PHAINON WHAT

Phainon ⋆✳˚

Guys, guys, calm down

⋆˚ ☁ Hyacine⋆˚ ☁

Explanation.

Castorice ʕ ̯ ू ू ʔ

Now.

Phainon ⋆✳˚

Okay look I got back to my dorm after a rlly long day and the roof was like caving in and water was everywhere. I went to Aglaea and she got me a new place to stay. Dw everythings fine, if anything, Mydei's place is much nicer than my dorm

⋆˚ ☁ Hyacine⋆˚ ☁

YOU'RE STAYING WITH WHO??

Castorice ʕ ̯ ू ू ʔ

There is so much to address here but I'll stick to the last part: YOURE STAYING WITH MYDEI????? Holy mother of Titans, you're living with MYDEI??

Phainon ⋆☀。

Yep, my rival Mydei.

Castorice ʕ̯•͡ˑ•ʔ̯

Oh my god. This is just like the plot of my favourite TV show.

Phainon ⋆☀。

I beg your pardon? What is going on here?

⋆。˚ ☁ Hyacine⋆。˚ ☁

Don't stress yourself out. It's nothing. Also, just asking, do you still hate Mydei

Phainon ⋆☀。

Yes, but why do you ask?

Guys?

???

Hello??

No response. First, they embarrass him in front of Mydei and now nobody's responding to him. This day was turning out to be a disaster.

A sharp knock on his door felt like a bucket of ice— cold water. "Deliverer, get ready. I'll sign you up for the gym."

Phainon, still recovering form the shock, hollered, "Alright, coming!"

"You better be, or I'll leave you to find the place by yourself."

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Mydei was not a petty person. He respected worthy opponents and accepted his losses with dignity— not that he ever lost.

Phainon, however, made him the pettiest man in all of Amphoreus.

At first, he didn't think much of the white haired man he saw in the distance the first day he set foot into CHRYSOS. Sure, his hair colour was unique and he had this magnetic charm to him that made everyone around him vy

for his attention, but he looked like nothing more than a vapid pretty boy. His presence felt like a wisp of air, easily dissipated and dampened.

Mydei had no plans on interacting with any one when at the facility— he just wanted to graduate and get out of there. When the white haired man approached him, Mydei had no interest in small talk. When Phainon, the man with eyes so blue you'd think they glowed at night spoke in that condescending tone with the most unfriendly 'friendly' smile he had ever seen, all Mydei wanted to do was beat that shit eating grin out of his face. Maybe he was still on edge after the events that predated his arrival, but his self control snapped.

As it turned out, Phainon was a hurricane— a torrent of determination and unchecked rage. Back in Kremnos, there was nary a person who could put up a good fight against him, but here this man was, dodging with an uncanny efficiency. He was light on his feet and one of the best fighters Mydei had ever fought with.

Something about the way his smile never truly reached his eyes or his overcompensating tendencies got on Mydei's nerves.

Mydei avoided Phainon as much as he could and yet, he kept falling back into orbit with him. Which was completely out of character for him, because Mydei was rational and should know better.

Said rationality was balled up, crushed and thrown out of the window when he was around Phainon.

He wrote and responded to the hate mail chain on the daily— like he was a kid, still nursing his wounds over a petty fight. Frankly, Mydei was too consumed by his dislike for Phainon to care that the mails sounded progressively less like fighting.

Sometimes, Mydei went as far as to consider Phainon a friend. That thought was instantly stomped on, but it still lingered every time Phainon bragged about his newest 'win'. Their current tally was Mydei—7, Phainon—6. Pathetic that he kept count, really. Years of fighting in a war made him wary of having someone at his back. As frustrating as it was, Phainon was probably the only person he'd trust at his back.

And if he noticed the red that underlined Phainon's eyes or the blank, calculating expression he took on when fighting, Mydei made no such comment.

At this very moment, Phainon's expression was awestruck as he gaped at the lounge entrance to the apartment's gym like it was surreal to him. The facility's gym was no joke either, but Phainon seemed enamored with this one. Some guests were eyeing them warily, although Mydei wasn't sure if it was directed at him or to Phainon. Mydei felt embarrassed at having to chaperone the human equivalent of a Samoyed.

"You're acting like a child, Deliverer." Mydei hissed, trying to distance himself from Phainon by walking a few paces too fast.

"Sue me. Look, there's a ridiculously fancy ceiling decoration, It looks so futuristic." Phainon replied, staring up at the ceiling, starstruck.

"I believe that's called a light."

"Shut up." Phainon's lips pulled into a scowl. Mydei found himself vaguely wondering what they would feel like. "Let me have some much needed whimsy. Not like you'd know what that feels like."

"Whimsy or public nuisance number one? Because you seem to be toeing that line."

Phainon opened his mouth to respond, but they were already at the front desk. Mydei handed his membership card to the lady at the front desk.

"I'm so sorry, but we only offer visitor's passes to our residents' partners." She said after checking Mydei's membership card.

"*What?"* Mydei asked, disbelieving.

"Oh, that's no problem for us, is it honeycakes?" Phainon smiled sweetly, leaning towards Mydei and wrapping his arm around Mydei's waist.

Mydei froze.

Phainon's hand was on his waist.

Also, honeycakes? really?

He had no idea why the touch felt so natural or why he was blushing, but that was something he was going to dissect later. Mydei cleared his throat and discreetly pinched Phainon's arm as revenge. Mydei watched Phainon struggle to maintain his infuriating smile, taking satisfaction in the slight wince in his expression and sharp breath he took.

"Yes, darling." Mydei grit out in the least murderous voice possible.

Phainon was so dead when they got out of this situation.

The lady seemed to buy their act, turning the registration screen towards them "My mistake, gentlemen, enjoy the amenities."

"Thank you!" Phainon smiled the smile that made half the recruits in the facility swoon.

The second they were out of earshot of the lady, Mydei shoved Phainon off him and shot him a glare that said *you're done.*

"Don't look at me like that. Mydei, I swear I did it so that I could get in and that was the only viable solution." Phainon rambled, trying to diffuse the situation.

To be fair, Mydei would have done the same thing. Something in him didn't feel like beating up Phainon today— maybe it was because of how Phainon had just begun to look cheerful again. Perhaps he still felt guilty for purposefully giving Phainon burnt and over seasoned lunch— which the guy didn't even seem to register.

So, he took a deep breath and counted to ten, before saying, "A warning would have been preferable."

"Yeah. Got it. I don't know how else to tell you this, but we might have to pretend to be dating so that they don't revoke my visitor's pass."

Oh to blazes with it. He wanted to punch Phainon into tomorrow.

"Phainon, *what the hell*." Mydei slowly turned around to face him.

Phainon threw both hands in the air, and replied, indignant,"Well, I warned you now!"

Breathe, Mydei, breathe. Do not let this brainless, infuriating little shit get to you.

"Oh come on, Mydei. Just play along for a while. I don't want to be dating you any more than you do."

That stung.

"We're at the gym anyways, so let's box."

"Huh— wait— don't walk away—" Phainon exclaimed, running after Mydei "— where did that even come from?"

"So you're chickening out?"

"I don't chicken out of things."

"Prove it."

That's how Mydei and Phainon ended up wheezing on the floor of the gym. The room felt stiflingly warm after their boxing match. It must've gone on for way too long, because Mydei hadn't felt this exhausted in a while.

"Wanna go somewhere?" Phainon asked, sitting upright and taking off his gloves.

"Yeah, sure." Mydei grunted, pushing himself up as well.

Mydei pretended to not notice the people staring at Phainon as he wiped the sweat off his face and neck. Either Phainon was completely oblivious to the stares he got or he just didn't care.

Not that Mydei cared, of course.

Phainon looked at him expectantly once they emerged from the gym. His head tilted to the side and his piercing blue eyes met Mydei's.

"What?" Mydei asked as they entered the elevator.

"Are we taking the death bike again?"

Right. Mydei had driven like a madman on purpose back then, just so he could enact a petty form of revenge on Phainon.

"Yes. I don't see why you expected anything different."

Phainon deflated at that. Had Mydei been a weaker man, he would have laughed at Phainon's ridiculous disappointed expression. They walked through the basement to get to Mydei's bike.

"The death bike" Phainon repeated, staring the bike down.

Mydei handed a helmet to Phainon. "It's really not that bad, get over yourself."

"You're the one making me a victim."

Mydei fastened his own helmet and started the bike "Get on" He called out.

Phainon took a deep breath and hopped on, wrapping his arms around Mydei's waist. It took every nerve in Mydei's body to force him to not jolt at the contact. It was just his brain messing with him because of what happened earlier.

Nothing else.

It was ten minutes into the ride when Mydei realised he had no idea where they planned to go. This wasn't like him. He usually knew what to do and where to go— because he was expected to be a reliable figure. He was the

son of Kremnos' leader, Gorgo. People used to look up to him and rely on him.

"Deliverer! Where are we even going to go?" Mydei yelled over the thrashing wind.

Phainon shouted back, "What?"

"Where. Are. We. Even. Going?" Mydei must've strained his vocal cords shouting that loud.

Phainon went silent for a minute.

"There!" Phainon exclaimed, one hand leaving Mydei's waist to point at a cafe up ahead.

Mydei pulled over and looked up at the sign. It read 'Chimera Cafe'. Not bad— Mydei quite liked the little critters. Next to him, Phainon shook his head after pulling off his helmet. He ran a hand through his white hair that shimmered under the sunset. Sky blue eyes fixed on Mydei's for a brief second before they fixated on the cafe's door. Mydei clenched his fist, his fingernails digging into his skin as he strode past Phainon and into the cafe.

"So have you been here before?" Mydei asked, watching as Phainon sprinted to the first Chimera that entered his line of sight.

"Yep. Cas brought me here a couple times." Phainon explained, crouching down to pet the Chimera. He hung his head in defeat when the Chimera decided it had enough pets and wriggled away. Phainon stood up. "I'll go order something— you're good with anything, right?"

Mydei gave a weak nod, but his mind had latched onto a single word Phainon said : Cas. That must mean Castorice— the one who makes poisons in the lab. Phainon seemed to be close enough to Castorice to call her Cas and go to cafes with her. Mydei had no reason to feel so irrationally jealous of a girl he only knew by name.

A nudge at his calf snapped Mydei out of his thoughts and he looked down to see a little white and grey Chimera with blue eyes blinked up at him. He kneeled down to pet it, which it seemed to love, purring and flopping on its back so he could scratch its stomach. Those blue eyes had not a single thought behind them, Mydei concluded after the Chimera rolled on the floor and collided with the wall. The Chimera blinked once or twice and then rolled over, only to hit the wall again. Mydei chortled. That Chimera reminded him of a certain blue eyed, white haired person.

He picked the critter up, absentmindedly petting it. He walked to a window seat at the cafe and soon enough, multiple Chimeras began to surround him. Soon enough, he was surrounded by a legion of little critters vying for his attention. He did his best to ignore the feeling of eyes burning into the back of his head— they had probably recognised the infamous Mydeimos.

Phainon had returned from the counter and gaped at the sight and muttered "Cute"

It wasn't clear wether he was referring to Mydei or to the Chimeras. Mydei chose to interpret it as the Chimeras.

"It's like you have your own little army of Chimeras." Phainon added, taking the seat opposite Mydei.

"Chimeras can't form an army, Deliverer."

"But what if we took in a bunch of them and trained them to fight?"

"That would be idiotic. Chimeras are helpers, not fighters."

"Okay, okay— but your Kremnoan legion or whatever it is you're called can raise them and train them in the ways of fighting. Trust me, this is an investment that'll sell big."

Mydei stiffened at the mention of his father's troops. He had erased the name from his memory the best he could— trying to forget the senseless bloodshed they reveled in. His mother had raised him to protect the lives of the innocent, not slaughter for glory.

"It's called the Kremnoan Detachment. I was never part of the Legion." Mydei said tightly.

Phainon seemed to have picked up on Mydei's change in demeanor. He immediately began to backtrack.

"I'm sorry— the news talked about the Kremoan Legion and you doing the whole killing-your- father-and-entrusting-Kremnos-to-the-government thing so I thought it was interconnected. It's also been over a year and my memory isn't the best."

"Say, what did the Okhema news describe me as?"

"Uh.. You sure you want to know?"

"Yes."

"The patricidal heir to Kremnos. A brute who finds glory in bloodshed. That's a few I remember."

The casual way in which Phainon listed off these attributes was impressive.

Despite the fact that Phainon knew Mydei's origins, he didn't seem to see him any differently. Or hate him any differently.

Although, Mydei wasn't sure if whatever was going on counted as hate any more.

"No wonder they treat me like I'm infected with some virus."

Phainon's brows furrowed.

"Is that why there are so many eyes on us right now?"

Mydei huffed out a derisive laugh "Why else?"

"Usually, there are eyes on me wherever I go because of the whole Deliverer thing so I thought they were looking at me. After all, attention is attention, be it negative or positive. It stings just the same."

"Hm" Mydei gave the most thoughtful response of his life while petting the Chimera on his lap, watching Phainon stand up to get their order.

"It's quite fascinating how you're so beloved by the Chimeras, though. You seem to like them too." Phainon remarked, returning to the table carrying a neon plastic tray of food.

Mydei shrugged "I do like Chimeras. They're cute."

"You never struck me as the type who liked cute things, but I stand corrected. In hindsight, it suits you." Phainon took a sip of his coffee— or rather, milk with a drop of coffee somewhere in there.

"Suits me? The hell you mean by that?" Mydei asked, reaching for the tray. On it was a familiar drink— pomegranate flavoured milk.

Phainon remembered. That fact should *not* have made Mydei feel so light— headed.

"I mean— the whole 'likes pink drinks and cute critters thing' works for you." Phainon explained, moving his hands about animatedly.

Mydei pursed his lips, trying to dampen the warmth that bubbled up in his heart.

"Mister Phainon?" A quiet voice asked. A little girl stood by the table, clutching a piece of paper.

Phainon beamed at the girl "Yep, that would be me!"

"I made this for you." She handed him the piece of paper.

"Aw, thank you, little one. I'll treasure this— wait— should I frame your amazing sketch?"

The girl nodded rapidly "Yes, um, I just wanted to say— thank you for protecting Okhema!"

Phainon's expression softened, a rare tenderness in his eyes "I'm honored to protect you." It sounded like he meant every word.

The girl sprinted back to her mother, clinging onto her mother's handbag. She timidly waved goodbye, which Phainon returned.

"Did you see that? I got the best present in all of Amphoreus— look!" Phainon said to Mydei, shoving the drawing in his face.

"Ah, yes, white paper. Because that's all I can see."

"Oh, let me just—" Phainon moved the paper back, waiting for Mydei's approval.

"Very nice. You had better not lose it."

"They love me" Phainon held the drawing up, admiring it.

"Attention seeker."

"No regrets."

Mydei sighed, but didn't retort.

The eyes that bore into the back of his head mattered even less. Phainon's attention was focused on him and only him and that was all that he cared about, really.

If he drove a bit slower on the trip home, he'd never tell Phainon because he still hated him.

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That night, the emails seemed more mellow.

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>10:30PM
to me▼

My radiant Mydei,

Dinner was amazing! You should really consider opening a restaurant or something. I'll be your first customer. Of course, I expect to get first dibs on the food— free of charge.

Btw you're an asshole, my knuckles hurt from our boxing session earlier. I'll win next time and watch as you grovel. I think you on your knees would be a pretty sight.

Go fall in a ditch,

Phainon

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>10:32 PM
to Phainon ▼

The world's most obnoxious HKS,

I shall up charge you and only you on any and every meal. Be grateful I feed your sorry ass on the daily.

Try harder if you want to reduce me to my knees. We'll see who wins next time and I'll make sure it won't be you. You fight dirty, by the way. Your underhanded tactics would get you despised by the Kremnoans. You go against the culture of Castrum Kremnos.

Yours adoringly,

Mydei.

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>10:35PM
to me ▼

My adorable Mydei,

This is probably the first time you've talked about your culture and I shall immortalise this in formaldehyde and chuck it at your face.

I am interested in what other culture laws I'm breaking, though. Do tell me what they are so I can break even more.

Lovingly cannibalising you first in a plane crash scenario,

Phainon

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>10:37PM
to Phainon ▼

Darling Phainon,

I hope you realise that your very existence violates the culture. Congrats, here's your award for doing absolutely nothing and breaking the rules anyway.

What do you want for breakfast tomorrow?

Holding you at gunpoint as I push you off a cliff,

Mydei

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>10:35PM
to me ▼

Beloved, beautiful Mydei,

Anything's good, I'm not picky.

I'd be willingly pushed off a cliff any day while being held at gunpoint as long as it's you who's doing it.

Dragging you down with me,

Phainon

Mydei's stomach did weird little flips as he read that one sentence over and over, trying to commit it to memory.

As long as it's you

He then came to a horrifying realisation, a thought he had repeatedly forced out of his mind coming back to haunt him.

Mydei might be falling for the weird white haired man with the golden sun tattoo.

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One year ago

Eurypon had put up a hell of a fight, or at least, his guards did. The coward sat behind locked doors, sending his men to shield him as he laid in wait for his inevitable demise.

Mydei had lost count of how many times he had died and revived in battle, charging in as a one man army, his reinforcements on the way. The Kremnoan Detachment's leader was not one to let up— not even in the face of death. Death had no grip over Mydei— the immortal that he was. He would never know what caused his immortality, and that was something he was fine with.

Mydei was in a haze of adrenaline and pure, unfiltered rage. He shoved the doors of Kremnos Industries open— the thud reverberating through the room. Eurypon sat on the velvet recliner, as if he was expecting Mydei.

"You." Mydei snarled

"Come to kill me, my son?" Eurypon's sickly sweet voice made Mydei want to throw up.

"As if I'd come here for anything else."

"You hate me, don't you? For what I did to your beloved mother." Eurypon taunted, holding up a gun.

Mydei lunged forward and grabbed Eurypon's collar, pulling him off his seat. He kicked the gun Eurypon held away and wrapped a hand around his throat.

"I don't hate you. *I want you dead*. I want your corpse's eyes to be staring into mine instead of that disgusting beady glare. I want you to feel the pain she did and relive it over and over."

"Ha! Spoken like a true, bloodthirsty tyrant. You shall incur the wrath of the underworld, just like I shall."

"If I go to the underworld for this, then so be it. I'll drag you down with me and make you crack your skull open on the landing."

Eurypon's smirk curled into a venomous smile. Mydei wanted to knock each one of those gold capped teeth out of his mouth.

"How bold. The bloodline of Castrum Kremnos' dictators shall reign supreme after all. Perhaps I should have accepted you and raised you to be even better." Eurypon cackled, like the madman he was.

"You're mistaken. I will abdicate the seat as the next leader. Kremnos shall henceforth be under the protection of Okhema's government."

Eurypon was livid. "Mydeimos, you take that *back*" Mydei's name felt poisonous from his mouth.He tried to break himself free of Mydei's grip, but Mydei's hold was too firm.It was strange. The man who had seemed so large and powerful felt so weak in that moment. The nightmare had lost its fangs and claws and was now trying desperately to escape. Mydei should have felt euphoric that moment— indestructible and infallible. He swallowed, pulling out his own gun.

"Goodbye. I hope that death is crueler to you than you ever were." was the last thing Mydei said before he shot his father dead.

He didn't know how long he stayed in that office with Eurypon's corpse turning cold.

"I did it, mother." He whispered, "Are you proud of me?"

Mydei felt stupid saying that. She was dead and would never know that her son went and avenged her death. He imagined her telling him that she was proud of him and that he was just as strong as she was. He missed her terribly, unable to erase the memory of her corpse in his arms or the finality of her being gone forever.

"Mydeimos, I know it must be hard to lose your mother, but you have a detachment to lead. Please pull yourself together and tell us what to do."

Krateros stood by the door of what used to be Gorgo's room. Mydei was seated at her desk, reading over every last letter she wrote to document the progress of the Detachment. He had already memorised the contents of the letters— but he read them over and over again as if doing so would bring her back to life.

"Patience, Krateros. Her funeral rites haven't been carried out yet and you still expect me to move on from her death like it never happened?"

"No. You have every right to mourn her, but you have hundreds to lead. They've begun to seek counsel from you."

"So you're telling me to put duty above my mother? Duty above being human?" Mydei hated how his voice cracked at that last bit. He's felt this white hot rage when he found out that she was poisoned by Eurypon. Mydei was prepared to rip Eurypon from limb to limb if he had to. Now, any semblance of fight had dissipated from his system, leaving behind jagged, broken pieces he wasn't sure he could ever put back together.

"I'm telling you to step forward and lead."

"…Give me a day. A day to peacefully mourn Kremnos' greatest warrior."

"A day? People have lost entire bloodlines overnight and have had to stand up and fight when the sun rose. You are a Kremnoan— to fight back is in your nature." Krateros paused, taking a deep breath "Please weigh the well being of your people with your selfish desires. You are young— barely fifteen— but you have a nation to eventually conquer"

With that, Krateros closed the doors behind him and left.

Was it really selfish to want to mourn his mother? Was he being selfish because he wanted to act like a child and cry in someone's arms until he shattered?

Yes.

He would be selfish if he were to dedicate himself to something that wasn't his people.

But why couldn't he just be a normal person, just once?

How would he react, Mydei wondered long after his tears ran dry, if he told Krateros that he truly didn't want to reclaim Castrum Kremnos.

Now, years later, he knew the answer.

Krateros paled, going through a catalogue of emotions ranging from horror to rage before settling to incredulous.

"Would you repeat that?" He asked, voice strangled.

"I'm placing Castrum Kremnos under the protection of Okhema's government." Mydei repeated. He was older and surer of himself, no longer the child nursing the pain of losing his mother all alone. "There is no guarantee that I won't become like Eurypon. Kremnos will be better protected from the Black Tide."

"Please reconsider—"

"—no. Kremnos' legacy of patricide and bloodshed ends here and now. That is my first and last order."

Krateros went silent for a long time, grieving the loss of all that he knew, believed in and lived for. When he spoke, his voice was resigned.

"What of you?"

"I will assist my people in settling in. Once that's done, I'll enroll in CHRYSOS so I can get the qualifications needed to eliminate the Black Tide."

"You.. really have this planned out, don't you?"

"Yes."

For the first time, Mydei couldn't bring himself to care if people thought he was being selfish.

✶⋆.˚⋆✫˚.⋆ ✦ ˙✦˙✶⋆.˚⋆✫˚.⋆

Present day

It had been a little more than a week since Mydei realised his feelings for a certain douche bag named Phainon. Said douche wasn't making it any easier on him. Mydei would get flash banged by Phainon's smile at every turn and even in the privacy of his own home. That man burned with the brightness of a million suns.

Sometimes, Mydei wondered how long it would be until the sun died out or got eclipsed.

Phainon seemed to be growing progressively more anxious about something. He would sometimes stare off into space during their daily gym visits and wake up and pace around the house in the odd hours of the night. Mydei had almost jumped out of his skin when he first bumped into Phainon pacing in the hallway in the dark, his eyes wide and haunted. That was an incident neither of them mentioned again. Even then, the bite in his emails never lessened.

Phainon physically dragged Mydei to the test results board the minute they set foot in the CHRYSOS facility.

"HKS, your palm is sweaty. Let go of my hand." Mydei complained, trying not to overthink the contact.

"Sorry, sorry" Phainon mumbled, letting go of his hand.

Mydei found that he missed the feeling of Phainon's hand in his. Phainon scrutinised the board before sighing in defeat, tapping his foot against the floor in an infuriating rhythm. The results still weren't out yet.

"Deliverer, is this was you've been anxious about all week?" Mydei asked, bemused.

"No— I was just anxious to beat you in this test. Yes. That's all." Phainon had the subtlety of a brick to the head.

"Did you think you did bad in this written test?"

"I *might* have messed up with the formulae."

"…I'm not the greatest at numbers."Mydei had no idea why he was trying to comfort his academic rival, but here he was anyway.

Phainon's eyes widened "You're bad at math." His face lit up and he let out a soft, disbelieving laugh.

Mydei clenched his teeth. That was exactly what he was trying to convey, but *upon the wrath of Nikador*, Phainon did *not* have to phrase it so directly.

"Shut up." Mydei restrained himself from reacting harshly. They were in public. The other recruits were going to stare and point at them if he caused a scene.

"Oh. My. Titans. You're bad at math." Phainon repeated, tasting the words on his tongue.

"It's not like I got that many opportunities to learn math while training to be a warrior."

"Makes sense, but even then— hey! Where are you going, Mydei?"

Mydei stopped in his tracks and turned around to respond.

"I have a counseling session with Professor Anaxa." Sure, the session wouldn't start for the next ten minutes, but he needed any excuse he could get.

"Oh, alright then. Shame I won't be able to see the expression on your face when you find out that I've beaten you in the test." Phainon paused, the gears in his head turning. A devilish grin replaced the sweet smile he usually wore "But you'll know when I win."

"I don't want to be privy to the thoughts in your head, so I'll make my exit." Mydei deadpanned.

It was Mydei's fault for finding even that cursed grin hot.

He entered the counseling room before Professor Anaxagoras did. Warm rays of sunlight streamed into the room, making it glow in the morning light.

"Oh. You're quite early." Anaxagoras' voice sounded from behind him.

"Yes."

"Good. Let us begin the session. Since you've kept up with the course relatively well and—"

Professor Anaxagoras' words were cut off with a 'ding' from Mydei's phone

"Sorry" Mydei muttered

"As I was saying—"

He was cut off yet again with another 'ding'

Mydei pursed his lips into a thin line.

Then, all hell broke loose.

Mydei's phone buzzed repeatedly, the notifications flowing like a raging waterfall. He knew exactly whose fault this was. Mydei had given up on the notion of silencing his phone and the damage was already done. Why not go the full hundred miles and let the messages pile up?

"You gonna answer that?"

"Leave it."

"… are you sure?"

"Yes."

Phainon was beyond dead the minute Mydei got out of this situation.

Mydei stormed out of the counseling room as soon as the session ended. He was a man with a mission. Phainon was nowhere to be seen— not by the vending machine or training room or lecture rooms. After sprinting through the facility and covering every possible room, Mydei took a seat at a cafeteria bench and decided to go through the messages.

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>11:55 AM
to me▼

HAHAHAAAA I WINNN I GOT MORE THAN YOU IN THE TEST

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>11:55 AM
to me▼

IMAGINE LOSING COULDN'T BE ME

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>11:55 AM
to me▼

LMAOOO YOU SHOULD SEE THE SCORES I WISH I WAS THERE TO RECORD YOUR REACTIONN

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>11:56 AM
to me▼

Did you see the scores yet?? Did you see?

The rest of the emails were just about the same. Mydei groaned, putting his head in his hands and questioning everything that led him to this point.

Why he still found himself attracted to this dolt was beyond him.

Out of the corner of his eye, he noticed two girls walk into the cafeteria. The purple haired girl seemed to recognise him and nudge the bubblegum haired girl.

The bubblegum haired girl greeted him first "Hi! You must be Mydei. I'm Hyacine— I work in the med bay. This is Castorice." She gestured to the other girl , who bowed her head slightly as greeting. This must be the Castorice Phainon spoke so affectionately about. No, Mydei was not jealous. He was a stronger man than that.

"We've heard so much about you from Phainon" Hyacine chirped as she and Castorice joined Mydei's table. He didn't recall offering them seats there. Mydei's eyes caught onto the fat white horse keychain hanging off Hyacine's bag. He'd seen the same overweight horse everywhere around Okhema— advertising Okhema Pharmaceuticals co.

"Hold on, is that Ica?" Mydei asked, pointing to the keychain.

"Yep! It's my family business' mascot."

So Hyacine was the heiress to a prestigious corporation. Now he was starting to understand why Phainon seemed nonplussed by Mydei being the son of a dictator. No, he still didn't fully understand why Phainon actively sought out the presence of the son of a war criminal. Even then, Phainon must have gotten used to the glamour of the title and learned to see the person underneath it.

"Interesting. If I may ask, why this horse?"

"Oh, little Ica's actually been with us for years, so my parents put them as the mascot. Honestly, having a cute horse helps with the brand image and better yet, I get to see Ica on the big screen."

"I see."

Mydei reverted back to silence. He wasn't, by any means, the most tactful in holding up a conversation.

"So…How have things been with Phainon?" Castorice questioned in a soft voice, determination overtaking her shyness.

"What do you mean?"

"You know, your *boyfriend.*" Hyacine stressed on the last syllable.

Mydei choked on air.

"My— *what?* I can assure you, there is nothing going on between us. Where did you even get that idea from? "Mydei sputtered

Castorice and Hyacine exchanged a knowing glance.

"Oh, just from the way he talks about you." Hyacine shrugged, trying to play it off.

Mydei wished his heart would stop thudding in his throat, restricting his words."He talks about me?"

"For the past few months, you've been a common topic." Castorice nodded, typing something on her laptop.

"Oh."

"We haven't been able to talk to you thus far because of a certain someone begging us to never interact with you. But he isn't here right now, so it's free real estate." Hyacine said as she pulled out her notebook and pens.

"What exactly does he say about me?"

Castorice looked up from her laptop, briefly pausing her typing,"Well, first it was about how much he hated you. Now.. it's kinda hard to tell because he still complains about you, but it's significantly less hostile."

Mydei raised his eyebrows "He still complains about me? Let me guess, it's because I nagged him for forgetting to do the laundry last week. Or maybe it's because I drive too fast. Well, tell him that I have a bone to pick with him for the stream of messages I just received." He paused, "Tell me, is he always this annoying?"

Castorice shook her head " He acts this way only around you."

"Yep. He never struck me as the petty or childish type. Matter of fact, it took forever for me to even think he considered me a friend and not a friendly acquaintance." Hyacine added, tapping her pen against the desk.

Mydei wondered if Phainon thought of him as a friend. Well, he made Phainon food and went to the gym with him. Even better, they found a system for cohabitation and they worked together quite well. Yeah, that should count as gestures of friendship.

Truth be told, Mydei didn't exactly make appetising meals for Phainon when he did something particularly stupid— which was most days. The dolt somehow didn't notice, savouring Mydei's cooking like it was ambrosia and staring at him, doe eyed from behind the counter as he awaited his meal.

They also got into fights and sent death threats via email.

Never mind, then.

"You two seem to have known him for a while now. How long have you been in the CHRYSOS training facility?" Mydei asked

"I joined here when I was nineteen. Cas has been here since she was seventeen. So it's been about four years since I first met Phainon."

"Say, what was he like back then?" Mydei couldn't help prying a little bit into Phainon's past.

Castorice patted her bangs down and answered, "About the same, honestly. He was so outgoing and popular that I didn't expect him to try to talk to me."

"Phainon's always been in the spotlight— you know, with the whole new 'hope' of Okhema thing. Someday, he'll take over the CHRYSOS facility and lead the efforts against the Black Tide. He's all over social media for that very reason." Hyacine said.

"Is he really?"

"You didn't know?"

"I don't really use social media."

"And he hasn't told you that he has multiple fan pages?"

"He has multiple what now?"

"He was just as surprised as you are when he learned about their existence."

"I had no idea he was this popular. I mean, I knew he was popular, but not to this extent." Mydei mused.

"You're plenty popular, too. I mean, you would've been the leader of a nation and that's no small feat. Most of the recruits are too scared to even approach you because you're so… Cas— help me here—"

"—accomplished." Castorice supplied

Hyacine's face brightened "Yeah. Accomplished."

Mydei didn't think the recruits avoided him because he was 'accomplished'. The people in Okhema hated him for being Kremnoan and for his not so stellar reputation. Therefore, the recruits either hated his guts or were terrified of him, but he decided to humor Hyacine and Castorice anyway.

"That makes sense."

Nobody talked for a while after that. Mydei pretended to be engrossed in reading something on his phone to feel a little less out of place among the scratch of pens and the clack of typing. Castorice giggled at her laptop and tilted it to show Hyacine something. They exchanged triumphant grins.

"We'll have to go now." Castorice announced in her soft voice, standing up. "It was a pleasure talking to you."

"You're quite unlike the rumors. Phainon was right when he said that you could be rather sweet." Hyacine smiled warmly at Mydei.

Phainon said he was sweet?

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Phainon wasn't a failure after all. The score board felt surreal. His bundled up nerves felt pointless now that he stared at the results.

20)Phainon— 60 points

21)Mydeimos— 58 points

He won.

He *won.*

"No way… Phainon didn't get first place?"

"Mydei didn't either. That's insane."

"I think the sun rose in the west today for that to happen"

"What could've happened for both of them to score this low?"

Forget the bewildered glances thrown his way. Reputation paled in comparison to winning against Mydei.

That was a statement Phainon never thought he would make.

With a giddy grin on his face, Phainon fired off email after to email to Mydei. If only he could see Mydei's expression right now. Probably murderous.

Good.

Phainon won and he would lord it over Mydei as much as he could and it wasn't because he was incredibly insecure and needed to feel like he was better than the man he declared as his rival.

✶⋆.˚⋆✯˚.⋆ ✦ ·✵· ✦ ·✶⋆.˚⋆✯˚.⋆

Castorice ʕ◌ᵔᴥᵔʔ

Guess who we're talking to rn

Phainon ⋆✳。

Who

Castorice ʕ◌ᵔᴥᵔʔ

Mydei. He's a pretty nice person

Phainon ⋆✳。

WHAT YOU GUYS NO YOURE NOT SUPPOSED TO TALK TO MY MORTAL ENEMY. HE'S MY RIVAL— WHOSE SIDE ARE YOU ON?? I DIDNT BEAT HIM IN THE TEST FOR NOTHING

Castorice ʕ ̯͡ ̯ʔ

Oh, lighten up

Phainon ⋆✳。

Pleasepleaseplease stop talking to him

Castorice ʕ ̯͡ ̯ʔ

Fiiiiinneeee. We told him how much you talk about him.

Phainon ⋆✳。

Please no I'm dying over here

No response for hours after that. Phainon may be regretting this.

"HKS!"

Mydei must've returned. And by the way he sounded, he was pissed.

Phainon rose from the sofa, prepared to make a run for it. Mydei's footsteps grew louder until there he was, dropping his bag and glaring daggers at Phainon.

"Where. Were. You." Mydei scowled, the pretty lines of his face creasing.

"Haha.. I was at the facility all day. So whatever do you mean, my dear Mydei?" Phainon drawled. True, he had been at the facility all day— just hiding out of Mydei's sight.

"You are so dead for sending me those messages." Mydei stalked to the couch.

"Oh come on, it was a wonderful joke." Phainon said, circling around the couch with Mydei.

Mydei cracked his knuckles.

Mydei climbed over the sofa and grabbed the front of Phainon's jacket, pulling him towards him. Phainon wriggled out of Mydei's grasp and dodged his next punch. Phainon laughed gleefully as he landed a hit on Mydei. Mydei lunged at Phainon again and he tried to dodge. Phainon's leg caught on the arm of the sofa as he moved back and he toppled backward onto the sofa— dragging Mydei down with him.

Mydei breathed heavily, his blonde hair falling over his face. His lips quirked into a victorious half smile as he pinned Phainon to the couch.

Phainon ascended to a higher plane of existence that very moment.

Shit. Why was Mydei so hot?

Phainon gaped up at Mydei, like all words failed him. His mind must have rebooted serval times, but to no avail. All he could think of was how pretty and gorgeous and hot and ethereal Mydei looked in that moment. Mydei huffed and got up. He ran a hand through his messy blonde hair — which was the single hottest thing he could possibly do. Phainon sat up slowly, his head reeling. His throat felt drier than sandpaper and he had a hard time focusing.

"Admitting defeat already? That's a new record." Mydei's voice broke through the cloud in his brain. Phainon's mind pinpointed on Mydei's voice and only his voice like all he wanted to focus on was Mydei.

What the hell was wrong with him?

Phainon opened and closed his mouth to retort, but no words came out. The gnawing feeling of embarrassment resurfaced and he averted his gaze.

Phainon coughed awkwardly, forcing words out of his mouth "That— that didn't count."

"Sure. I won this time, though. Me—11, You—9." Mydei stated, tilting his head to the side—making his hair braid cascade fully onto his shoulder.

"Unfair."

"What's unfair, Deliverer?"

"You."

"Uh huh. Keep saying that to yourself." Mydei snorted

Phainon's phone rang. It was Aglaea. He still wasn't over the embarrassment of the last call, but he knew better than to ignore the call.

"Hello?"

Aglaea wasted no time in getting straight to business. "Yes, good evening, Phainon. Two weeks from now, there will be a meeting with the Council of Elders. Our purpose is to make an appeal to keep the CHRYSOS facility running since they're trying to shut it down."

"Oh." Phainon thought back to the conversation he had overheard ages ago.

"Since you're the face of this operation, it would be ideal to have you present and make your own statements."

"I'm honored, Aglaea. I'll do it." Not agreeing was not an option. Aglaea wanted him there, so he would do it. End of story. His fear of public speaking be damned— this was his reputation and likeability on the line.

"That's good. You will have to argue against the Council's spokesperson and give an ending speech." She paused, "Also, I haven't heard from you since that call. Are you sure everything's fine?"

Phainon gulped, he did not need to be reminded of that— especially in front of Mydei. "Yes. That was a lapse in my judgment. For that, I apologise."

Aglaea stayed silent on the other end for a while.

"Alright then, thank you, Phainon."

Phainon put down the phone and ran a hand over his face. This was going to be like a big debate, right? He could do debates. He was good at debates. But a debate with high profile people who would probably look down on a simple country boy and could easily wipe him off the map?

Phainon had half a mind to ring up Aglaea and tell her he'd changed his mind.

"You look lost" Mydei commented after watching Phainon in silence.

"How am I supposed to go up there in a big fancy suit and argue with the literal government?"

"Not the government, it's a political party."

"They're equally intimidating, Mydei."

Mydei paused, considering something

"I'll help you figure out what to say."

"Yes, please."

"All right. First, do not show fear. Do everything to act like you belong there and let nobody question you." Mydei said, leaning over the couch as Phainon feverishly typed out everything Mydei said on his phone. He could feel Mydei's hair tickling his neck.

Phainon swallowed.

This was not going to be an easy two weeks.

Chapter End Notes

> That's the end of chapter 2, three to go. The next two chapters are the main reason why I put up the warnings so here's me letting you know before I post them. There is a happy ending, just with a bit of extra spice in the form of -¦- ˙ ˛ trauma.-¦- ˙ ˛

Chapter 3: Tough as nails and built for breaking

Chapter Notes

> Hi! I'm back with the third installment to a fic that was just supposed to be haha funny hate emails. Hope you enjoy!
>
> Cw: gore and descriptions of death so read at your own discretion

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon was convinced he had arrhythmia.

There was no other plausible reason for why his heart rate spiked to unnatural levels when Mydei was around. What's worse was that he found himself obsessively checking and reading through all of Mydei's emails.

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>8:16PM
to me▼

Deliverer,

This is to inform you that you didn't load the dishwasher. See to it as quickly as you can before I stuff you into the dishwasher as well.

Consider this your final warning.

Always yours,

Mydei.

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>8:18AM
to Mydei ▼

My annoying roommate who I wish I could throw into the trenches,

I apologise for my mistake, You Highness. Oh how scared I am because of your threat. Seriously, is watching me your new hobby? I must say, I'm flattered.

Your one and only sweetheart,

Phainon

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>8:25AM
to me ▼

To my one true Deliverer,

Whatever made you think that? Have you looked in the mirror lately? Because all you'd see is an annoying pest who disrupted my peace. Of course I have to watch you like a hawk to keep you from wrecking my house.

Here with a pin to pop your ego,(I am not obsessed I want you out of my fucking house)

Mydei.

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>8:25AM
to Mydei ▼

My beautiful, sweet, charming Mydei,

You're obsessed with me.

Hugs and kisses,

Phainon

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>8:25AM
to me▼

I am not.

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>8:26AM
to me▼

Also, you free rn to discuss your speech?

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>8:26AM
to Mydei▼

Yes.

He did not blush while reading through the emails, no, he absolutely did not. This was just how they texted each other all the time. It meant nothing.

But oh Kephale, the *"Always yours"* and "*To my one true Deliverer"* was bad for his heart.

On this particular day, Mydei was scrutinising the suit Phainon planned to wear for the meeting. Phainon felt weirdly exposed as Mydei observed him.

He stood there, fidgeting with the fraying collar, looking everywhere but directly at Mydei's golden eyes.

"You can't be serious. You are not wearing that." Mydei gestured to the perfectly fine suit Phainon wore.

"But it fits well?"

"Fits well, my foot. You look like a misshapen, mutated lump"

Phainon groaned "But this is all I have"

"Fine."

"*Fine*?" Phainon scoffed

"HKS, I'm buying you a better pair of formals"

"Wait— no— don't spend that much money on me. Trust me, it's not even worth it." Phainon scrambled to list off reasons why he didn't deserve a new pair of formals, but Mydei wasn't having any of that. Mydei physically dragged him to the mall, Phainon's excuses falling on deaf ears. But then

again, Phainon wasn't going to complain about being pulled along by *Mydei*.

"I. Will. Pay." Mydei rummaged through his wallet and pulled out a credit card.

"Stubborn asshole" Phainon muttered, imitating Mydei's habit of crossing his arms.

"What was that, HKS?"

"Nothing! Nothing."

The people in the store eyed Mydei warily, like he was a ticking time bomb. Phainon felt offended on Mydei's behalf. Only Phainon was allowed to call Mydei a brute and even then, he never meant it literally.

"Try this on" Mydei pointed to a black suit— neat, but nothing too fancy. Fine, maybe the old grey suit was so tasteless that it made this plain suit look so much better in comparison. He shoved Phainon in the direction of the changing room.

Phainon grimaced, the shirt fitting uncomfortably tight. Yep, this one was definitely not it. Nevertheless, he pushed back the curtains and jogged over to Mydei.

"So? On a scale of frog to dehydrated earthworm, how bad do I look?"

"I'd say brain eating amoeba, but—" Mydei looked up from the rack of suits he was analysing and stopped short. Wide- eyed, he stared at Phainon.

"Hello? Mydei, is everything good?" Phainon waved a hand in front of Mydei's face

Mydei exhaled shakily. "Try another one" He thrust another suit at Phainon and muttered some excuse of finding a better one to try on.

Weird.

A fellow customer stopped him on his way to the changing room. Phainon assumed it was probably to ask for a picture or something along those lines — what people normally asked him for.

"Mr Phainon? Um, are you here with Mydeimos on purpose? Is he forcing you into this?"

"What? No" Phainon had to stop himself from bursting into fits of laughed because that was the most absurd thing he had ever heard.

The customer looked concerned, pressing on,"If you're being threatened, please say so"

"While I appreciate the concern, I can assure you that I am not being threatened. Why did you think that in first place? "

"He is— no, was, the leader of the Kremnoans. You know how they are."

Clenching his fist, Phainon tried his best to stay calm. "So you assume every Kremnoan is out to harm you? "

"No, of course not, I— They're not the best people and you never know—"

"—never know what?" Phainon asked icily, "Are we not all from Amphoreus? Are we not all the same? Doesn't it make you a bad person for judging them?"

The customer fell silent, before muttering rushed apologies and walking away.

How Mydei dealt with hatred was impressive, Phainon thought to himself, unbuttoning the shirt. It had taken everything in him to not start a scene

right in the middle of the changing room. Even then, he should have said something more biting in defense of Mydei.

But then the customer would feel bad. No, why does Phainon care so much about the feelings of a stranger who so clearly insulted Mydei and, by extension, Phainon himself? Damn him and his incapability of being anything but a people pleaser.

"Let's go with this one." Mydei said after Phainon trudged back to him for the sixth time.

"Finally." Phainon sighed, his weariness dissipating. "I thought I was going to be stuck here forever."

"It's not that bad. it's just shopping."

"Yes, shopping, which includes having to put up with your impossible standards."

"Standards? Deliverer, why don't we address yours? You almost picked a purple and yellow polka dotted tie."

"It was cute, okay?"

"If by cute, you mean 'needs to be burnt at the stake', then yes. Very cute."

Mydei paid for the suit. Phainon nearly melted into the floor when Mydei's fingers brushed against his as he handed Phainon the bag. He was definitely going to check with Hyacine about his arrhythmia because his heart never beat this fast, not even after training.

"Also, why have you been looking at me with those sad puppy eyes? It's annoying me."

Phainon didn't realise he was doing that. He still felt bad for being unable to properly defend Mydei and for the treatment Mydei's had to endure.

"No reason." Phainon was suddenly very interested in the escalator.

"Is the escalator really that intriguing?"

"Uh— Yes! Wow, look at the mechanisms, very interesting. Truly a miracle of human innovation. Look at how it goes up and down!"

Phainon wanted to slap himself— 'it goes up and down'? Really, Phainon?

Mydei blinked "Astute observation, Deliverer. The escalator goes up and down. Who knew?"

Phainon wanted to jump off the elevator and never show his face to Mydei again.

"I— uh—"

"Never took you for an escalator enthusiast."

Phainon closed his eyes and let out a groan. Rookie move, because he didn't notice that he was at the foot of the elevator. He stumbled, but felt Mydei grab his hand.

If Phainon could collapse on the spot, he would.

Noticing a pair of white shoes near him, Phainon looked up.

It was Castorice. She looked at Mydei, then at him, then back at Mydei again. She mouthed the words *Oh. My. Titans.* Phainon mouthed back, *This isn't what it looks like.* Castorice didn't stop goggling at them— clearly, they needed to work on their wordless communication.

Mydei let go of his hand like it was contaminated and looked away.

"Um— do you want to go to the food court?" Castorice asked, trying to diffuse the tension in the air.

"Sounds good" Phainon nodded weakly

"Yeah." Mydei strode past them.

Castorice and Phainon fell behind him, furtively whispering.

"You're on a date, aren't you?" Castorice whispered, her mouth hanging open in disbelieving joy. She laughed incredulously "I called it!"

"No! No, absolutely not." Phainon hissed "This is not a date! He just dragged me to the mall and bought me a suit for the meeting, that's all."

"… Sounds like a date to me."

"Cas, I swear upon every titan out there, this is not a date. We are not dating."

"*Right.*"

"… You don't believe me, do you?"

"Not one bit."

Mydei was already standing by a table, his arms crossed, when Phainon and Castorice caught up. He unfolded his arms and sat down.

Phainon felt like his throat may seize up and stop working from how much he had to talk to compensate for the two introverts at his table. He was no stranger to keeping the conversation going, so he pushed through, praying for Mydei or Castorice to prolong the conversation.

"So, that's how we accidentally robbed a laundromat. I haven't been able to bring myself to go within five feet of that place ever since." Phainon recounted.

"How on brand for you, Deliverer."

"I'll take that as a compliment, my dear Mydei." Phainon did an exaggerated wink at Mydei. Mydei exhaled, shooting him a dirty look.

Castorice's foot kicked his under the table. Phainon winced, kicking her foot back. She shook her head disappointingly, mouthing '*and you say you're not dating*.'

He was going to ignore that.

They were not dating. Phainon felt something akin to friendship with Mydei, unless he was completely deluding himself. There was a very high probability of Mydei despising him, judging by how he let go of Phainon's hand like it was scalding hot earlier. So, for appearance's sake, he hated Mydei and Mydei hated him too.

But did rivals *really* sit at a food court, sharing a pack of fries?

"Say, where's Cinny? It's the weekend— everyone should be free." Phainon asked, attempting to distance himself from that train of thought.

Castorice took a sip of water,"She's needed at home. Something about a marketing campaign with Ica."

"Speaking of Ica, how are they?" Mydei asked, leaning forward on the table

"Oh, they're doing great! Apparently, Ica housed an entire barrel of wheat and grains."

"That's quite impressive."

Was this what Mydei, Hyacine and Castorice were talking about that one time when Phainon was hiding from Mydei?

It did seem like Mydei and Castorice grew closer— at the expense of Phainon's dignity.

"Have you two perhaps bonded over little Ica?" Phainon asked.

Castorice shrugged "Ica is a suitable interest to bond over. Should we bring carrots or apples next time we see them?"

"Ica will eat anything, so I think the amount matters more"

"True, but if you were a pony, what would you like to eat?"

Phainon contemplated for a bit before answering,"I think I'd like wheat and apples."

"Good choice."

Even as he talked, Phainon's eyes were drawn towards Mydei like they were always meant to be on him.

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A few days later, after a particularly grueling mission and an even more exhausting gym session—fitness was a non negotiable, according to Mydei — Phainon lounged on the couch. His laptop on his lap, he scrolled through a list of what could possibly be the cause for his arrhythmia. The World Wound Web was not doing him any favours— so far, his symptoms may lead to heart failure or hint at underlying heart conditions. Apparently, he would die in two days if untreated. How reassuring.

This was stupid.

He went to his history to delete any evidence of him spiraling

"Deliverer? What's this?"

Phainon felt something in him wither into dust.

"*Do I have arrhythmia? Help my heart's beating really fast and I think its because I'm angry*. *Am I going to die?*" The hell have you been

researching?"

"Um. It's nothing."

"Are you okay?"

No, and it's your fault, is what he wanted to say. Instead, Phainon exulted "Yep! Totally fine! One thing led to another and I ended up down this rabbit hole."

"Alright then." Mydei said, uncertain. He sat on the other side of the couch, facing Phainon.He was probably researching a recipe for dinner.

Phainon had a brilliant idea.

He could just consult strangers online— sure, the advice may be dubious, but at least they wouldn't assume he was going to die within the next 48 hours.

Anonymous user 33,550,336

Do I have a heart problem?

I(22M), have been living with my rival(22M) as roommates for a while now. I find myself staring at him for way too long because you don't get it

this man is so attractive and reliable and he's so so kind and has the most ridiculously hot physique and appearance— but I digress. I think it's normal to admire your rival turned roommate a normal amount, right? I don't know why, but when I'm near him, my heart rate spikes to unnatural levels. Like hook me up to an ECG and you would get abnormal results. We argue most of the time, but it's just our way of communication so I don't think this is because of blood pressure. Do I have arrhythmia or some other heart related issues? Should I go see a doctor?

There. Sent.

May the internet gods give him a rational, reasonable explanation.

Bored, Phainon looked up from his laptop,"Mydei, I've been thinking— is HKS and a series of grunts and sighs the entirety of the Kremnoan language?" He asked, setting the laptop down on the table.

Silence

"That's it. You're getting soggy fish for dinner."

Shit

"No no no, Mydei— I take that back—"

"—too late—"

"—damn it. I'm sorry?"

"Apology not accepted. You will eat what you are given and you will not complain." Mydei got up, tying on an apron.

Phainon deflated, hanging his head in defeat. He refreshed the page multiple times, waiting for an answer. Answers flooded in like an unrelenting tide.

Conspiracytheorist_blob: YO IS THIS GUY FR???

Mashed_potato : Worst case of hopelessly oblivious gay I have ever seen.

Ica_fan459 :You do know that it's legal, right? Someone tell him it's legal.

Anonymous_user19034: I'm going to explain this clearly to you, okay? You are down horrendous for your roommate. You do not have any heart issues, the only issue here is you being as dense as a steel rod. Someone could hit you with it and you'd still not realise it. YOU LIKE THIS GUY ROMANTICALLY. (see, I spelled it out for you.) How you've avoided realising your feelings like it's an Olympic sport is beyond me.

Jellycat_98: Someone make a movie out of this is is gold.

…

What?

Him? Like Mydei romantically?

That's ridiculous. Maybe his words came out wrong and led people to assume things. Because there was no way in hell he would like Mydei.

Liking Mydei would mean wanting to kiss his stupid face and hold his hand and do romantic things with him— wait, that didn't sound too bad, actually. Actually, that sounded pretty nice.

This cannot be happening right now.

Looking up like a startled deer, his eyes fell on Mydei frying fish over the stove.

He forced himself to analyse this situation with as much rationality as possible. Yes, Mydei was attractive. Phainon had internalised that the second he first saw Mydei. But why did he look so ethereal? The red tattoos that wrapped around his body and his muscles made Phainon's cheeks overheat and his heart do multiple flips, like a fish on dry land.

And why did his focused expression when he cooked look so enthralling?

Oh, this is definitely happening.

This was bad. No, this was catastrophic. A dam had broken and all coherent, rational thoughts in his brain were replaced by Mydei. He felt like he was being punched in the face by his feelings over and over again. Hell, it laughed at him when he was already on the floor in agony.

But Mydei could punch him and laugh at him when he was on the ground and Phainon would still say thank you.

Mydei placed dinner on the table and looked at Phainon expectantly. Phainon would usually spring up and run to the table, but this time, he was lost in a trance.

"Dinner's ready?" Mydei was at slight unease because of Phainon's reaction — or rather, lack of reaction.

Phainon made a weak sound.

"What was that?"

Mydei had no right to look that cute when confused.

"Nothingeverythingisfine." Phainon said in one breath. He stood up— fast enough to give him severe whiplash— and sat at the table with Mydei, picking up a spoon "This is really good"

"You didn't even taste it yet."

Phainon shoveled a spoonful of food into his mouth "Now I did and I can say, it's amazing!"

"Don't talk when you chew, HKS."

"What are you, my mother?" Phainon said midway through another bite, waving his spoon at Mydei accusingly.

Mydei was decidedly very unimpressed as Phainon choked on a morsel and coughed violently. He thumped his chest a few times before sheepishly avoiding eye contact with Mydei. Mydei sighed and pinched his temple.

"I heard you have fan pages." Mydei said. Phainon nearly choked on his food for the second time that night. Mydei was like an octogenarian when it came to social media— he wasn't supposed to know any of this.

"Who told you this?" Phainon asked delicately.

"Your friends, Castorice and Hyacine told me."

"And when was that?"

"That day with the annoying stream of messages during my counseling session."

Phainon was regretting hiding from Mydei on that day more and more as time passed. It seemed like everything that could've gone wrong went wrong because of that fateful encounter with his friends. Phainon took a few deep breaths.

"It's quite interesting how there are so many people who adore their Deliverer to such an extent." Mydei's intense gaze made Phainon want to simultaneously bask in it and combust. "Perhaps, I should check the posts made about you online."

Phainon shot up and slammed his hands on the table,"NO! Please, don't— I don't want my reputation to be dragged through the mud."

"Does my opinion really matter that much to you?"

Yes, yes it does. It matters more than what I thought the public's opinion did.

"No. It doesn't."

Mydei pursed his lips "Then? What's the problem?"

"I'll wash the dishes." Phainon excused himself from the table and scooped up his and Mydei's dishes. He didn't think he could survive the embarrassment from Mydei scrolling through his fan pages. Phainon was rather flattered that people liked him enough to make the fan pages, and maybe he did read through them some nights to remind himself he was doing a good job. Years of being forgotten and overlooked left him with an insatiable hunger for validation and each time he sought it out, he returned feeling even hungrier for it.

But Mydei didn't have to know that.

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>8:50PM
to Mydei ▼

Dearest, loveliest Mydei,

The silence that washes over your brash countenance like a warm breeze is annoying. Also, did you see the weekly rankings? I'm first place. Ha.

Yours in every manner of the word,

Phainon

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>8:55PM
to me ▼

Deliverer,

Why is our treasured deliverer so crabby today? Your brilliant mind mustn't invest itself in such matters like the all important world wound web search. Seriously though, how on earth does one convince themself they have arrhythmia?

Ps. I don't care about the rankings. I just want to pass. But next time, I'll beat you and knock off your superiority complex.

With all the world's love and care,

Mydei.

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>8:56PM
to Mydei ▼

Radiant, supremely annoying Mydei,

Ha. Says you— I saw you practise for the evals. You definitely wanted to win, bastard. And you'll lose next time too, I'll make sure of it.

Your thinly veiled insults are annoying too.

You're just annoying.

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>8:56PM
to me ▼

You've repeated the word annoying three times.Have you run out of words for once? Never thought that mouth could shut up.

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>8:57PM
to Mydei ▼

Of course it can. I bet it can shut yours up too.

Phainon cringed, wanting to unsend that message. He didn't want to come off like that—

Too late.

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>8:57PM
to me ▼

A ridiculous notion.

Phainon didn't know whether he should feel disappointed or relieved. Mydei didn't seem to have any problem with his flirting— was that a good sign? Or maybe they both just got accustomed to it and it was only Phainon who began to care about what the messages sounded like to a normal person.

That was when Phainon made the highly educated decision to lock up these strange feelings and hope they never saw the light of day. Yeah, Phainon always thought of himself as a person who let go easily— deliberately

glossing over the weeks he spent grieving his family and spending every waking moment by their graves until he had no choice but to leave.

Besides, this would work.

One hundred percent.

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This was not working.

Trying to keep a tally of how many times he tripped over his two feet and stumbled through his words around a certain blonde haired man was near impossible. Phainon's cause of death would either be Mydei's very existence or the dread he felt on the morning of the debate.

Phainon composed his fraying nerves by taking several deep breaths. This was it. Two weeks of preparing a speech to prove to everyone he would protect Okhema. The news of the debate had spread like wildfire through social media. Support came flooding in with posts cheering them on.

It was still five in the morning when he had to head out, so Mydei was probably asleep He spotted a small bag placed on the dining table— on it was a sticky note.

HKS, I packed you food. You better appreciate it.

Phainon could hear a choir of angels singing in the background. He could fall to his knees right then and there. All his anxiety evaporated as he held the bag like it was made out of diamonds. Mydei must've made this for him last night.

He hummed a happy tune as he got into Aglaea's car.

"I take it as something good happened?" She asked, starting the engine.

"Yes" Phainon sighed dreamily, clutching the bag close to his heart,"The best thing ever."

Aglaea side eyed him.

"Have you got your statement prepared?"

"Yes— Mydei helped me with it."

"I see." Aglaea smiled knowingly.

The car pulled up to a big building— one of those flashy ones covered with glass from head to toe and shot so high you'd wonder if the builders knew when to stop adding floors. Weeks ago, Phainon would have been amazed, but Mydei's apartment had pretty much desensitised him to extravagance.

"Oh, that was fast." Phainon said amiably, squinting up at the building to try to count the number of floors it had.

"Phainon, you were gazing at the bag the entire time. I doubt you paid much attention to anything else."

"…"

"You can sit in the lobby until I call you as support. You will be called as the face of the organisation. Got it?"

"Yes, Aglaea." Phainon climbed out of the car and waved at the reporters that had camped outside the building. Looking nervous wasn't something he could afford to do— any slight uncertainty would lead to doubt in the public eye.

Taking a seat in the lounge, Phainon kept one hand on the bag as if it would disappear the second he let go. Nobody was allowed to judge him and his emotional support lunch bag. Tapping his foot against the floor anxiously,

he scrolled though his phone to distract himself from the feeling of his stomach churning.

A message popped up on his phone— it was from Mydei.

Mydei, his brain sang, like a sweet melody on a record.

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>7:07AM
to me ▼

You're not on TV. Don't tell me you're hiding in a corner. I did not spend this long helping you prepare your speech for nothing.

The record screeched to a halt. *That jerk.*

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>7:07PM
to Mydei ▼

I'll be called out later, you arse.

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>7:08AM
to me ▼

Good. Don't screw this up too badly.

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>7:08PM
to Mydei ▼

Of course I won't mess up— hell, I'll win this thing.

Keep watching, and I'll prove it. Victory kiss maybe?

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>7:08AM
to me ▼

In your fucking dreams.

The debate took place in a huge auditorium lined with plush red seats— where a huge audience sat in wait. Two podiums were at the center, cameras and microphones pointing straight at them. Aglaea was on one of them— the light making her glow like an ethereal being. Mydei was more ethereal than her, but that was a thought privy to Phainon's mind alone.

"I call upon Phainon's testimonial." Aglaea said, gesturing to Phainon. Phainon bowed his head and walked up to the stage. Reminding himself where to put his feet and clenching and unclenching his sweaty palms, Phainon climbed onto the stage and waved at the onlookers.

He recognised the grey haired woman on the other side. Elder Caenis— the Council of Elders' leader. She struck Phainon as a rather unpleasant person, even if he never talked to her. Something about that carefully engineered smile and soulless eyes seemed off putting.

Maybe like recognises like, because Phainon feared he behaved exactly like her.

Caenis cleared her throat, peering at Phainon with beady eyes, "Your head of operations, Aglaea has made her stance very clear. She refuses to back down and give up the organisation. Since you're young and your mind hasn't clouded over like hers has, tell me— is this operation worth it? Wouldn't, say, a Council operated effort be far more reliable?"

"If you were really that keen on the protection of Okhema, the Council would have stepped up to fight the Black Tide earlier." Phainon asserted.

That's a win, he thought to himself as Caenis pursed her lips.

When she spoke, her voice was strained, "We did not find a need to venture beyond Okhema's safe walls. Okhema would have stood tall regardless of your actions. But now, we recognise that there is a need for protection around the perimeter."

"With all due respect, Elder Caenis, CHRYSOS knows what it's doing."

"We can be better— more efficient, trustworthy and influential. We have offered Aglaea the opportunity to merge CHRYSOS with the Council. Is that not a good thing for you?"

"No."

"No?" Caenis asked mockingly— like Phainon was gum stuck to the sole of her shoe. "So you claim that CHRYSOS alone is enough for Okhema's protection?"

"Yes. CHRYSOS doesn't just protect the walls of Okhema from the Black Tide creatures, but it also serves as a beacon of hope."

"But does Okhema really need CHRYSOS? Or is this an unnecessary investment?"

"I don't see how protecting the lives of people can be considered an investment— it's a necessity We stepped up to fulfill that need."

Caenis sneered at Phainon, the corners of her mouth curling up into an unpleasant smile. "We will consider dropping our statement if and only if you swear to uphold your duty. Do you think you can protect the people of Okhema, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae?"

How did she know where he was from? His breath caught in his throat— it was only Aglaea who knew of his origins. Reacting would make this situation worse— so he swallowed the panic that rose up in his throat. This was just a way for the Council of Elders to trip him up.

Hoping his voice wasn't shaky, Phainon responded,"Yes, yes I can."

"Do you think you can shoulder the hopes, dreams and trust of an entire city? Can you ensure the complete and utter safety of its citizens?"

Everyone's eyes were on him. Expectant. Some ready to tear him down if he messed up.

He was Phainon. He was capable. He would never crack— never shatter. And even if he did, he would piece together the broken pieces of his heart each time and get back up.

"Just watch me." Phainon smiled triumphantly, right at the camera pointed at his face.

The onlookers burst into applause. They chanted his name, the sound crescendoing until all he could hear was his name reverberating through the huge room.

Confidence unlike anything else he had ever felt surged through his veins. *This was it*. This was what it was like to be the center of everyone's attention. This was what it meant to have all the attention in the world focused on you and you alone. The cheers paled in comparison to the one person whose appreciation mattered to most.

Mydei, are you seeing this? Are you proud of me? Please tell me you are.

Phainon maintained eye contact with the camera, hoping that Mydei knew that Phainon's gaze and words were meant for him and only him.

He didn't miss Caenis' glare as he walked off the stage. Making his way to Aglaea, pushing past the crowds of reporters that swarmed him, he looked to her for approval. She offered an approving smile and a nod.

"Good job, Phainon." She said, leading him through the crowd, back to her car.

"Thank you."

As Aglaea drove him back, he saw his face on the huge screens that lined Okhema's buildings. Confident. Sure of himself in a way he never thought he could be.

It was official now, Phainon was the poster boy of CHRYSOS and a figure all of Okhema could look up to.

No big deal.

That was when the dread set in.

He couldn't properly enjoy the food Mydei packed for him because he felt physically sick. His forehead felt clammy— he was starting to regret being so headstrong. What if he wasn't cut out for this?

If only he could go back to his old life and live an insignificant, forgettable existence— his memory only known to the ones closest to him. But then again, he was told that someday, he would be someone this important.

He did this to himself. The circumstances that led Phainon to this point were far from ideal, but he dare not complain. Something about this fame felt unsteady— tentative.

A tall figure waited by the gate of the apartment, looking up from his phone when he saw Aglaea's car pull up.

"Good job." Mydei said, standing by the door of the car as Phainon got out.

It was like the stars had aligned when Mydei validated him. Screw everyone else's opinions, Mydei's validation alone was enough for sustenance.

"Phainon!"

"Cinny? You're here too?"

"Mydei called to tell me you were returning, so I had to come congratulate you." She thrust a box of chocolates into his arms "Here's my present."

"Thank you" Phainon said, a bit breathless.

Hyacine laughed. "Don't mention it! It's what friends do."

Phainon hugged Hyacine tightly. She patted his shoulder. "Good job, Phainon. Cas is busy right now, but she would like to say the same thing. We're all proud of you, Phainon."

Looking up, he made eye contact with Mydei, whose expression remained steadfast. But that was the kindest expression Phainon had ever known.

He called Hyacine here.

Phainon may have accepted falling for Mydei in that moment, but that's a secret only Phainon himself was privy to.

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"Phainon, you have the entirety of Okhema captivated by you. Tell us how you feel about it."

Phainon laughed an airy, effortless laugh. "Attention is normal for me. With these looks and this reputation, why wouldn't I be used to this?"

The interviewer laughed heartily "This one's got some sass. So you acknowledge your looks?"

"Well, I'm hot and I know it" Phainon winked dramatically at the camera."But let's not present me as narcissistic here."

"Social media's been blowing up with your speech— I watched it myself, and I must say, you were impressive."

"Why thank you, kind miss"

"Flatterer." The interviewer straightened her tie "Why did you decide to shoulder all this responsibility in the first place?"

"The people need hope and it's time I stepped up to fulfill the promises I made when I began this journey."

"Noble words from our noble Deliverer. What have you been up to these days?"

"Oh, lots. Since I've been given authority to plan out my own missions, I've been taking on as many as I can. Other than that, I've been making frequent appearances online. Hope you guys don't get too bored of my face!"

"The public would never. They can't get enough of you." The interviewer added, "You're working really hard for this, aren't you?"

"Of course I am, but I'll have to credit the entirety of CHRYSOS for their painstaking efforts in making such promises even possible."

"You're humble too? Okhema, meet the man who shall one day tear down the walls that bar us from the outside world and rid us of the Black Tide creatures that have plagued Amphoreus for generations." The interviewer said, "And that's all we have for today's broadcast. Have a pleasant rest of your day, Okhema!"

Phainon stood up with the interviewer and waved goodbye, the very picture of perfection and strength.

"Cut!" The interviewer called out. The cameras stopped rolling.

Phainon politely declined the crew's offers of refreshments and the lounge, choosing to head out. He had an errand to run.

Even the most popular people in the city needed to go grocery shopping for their hot grumpy roommates. Phainon didn't make the rules. Mydei did. The shelves were laden with condiments Phainon usually never bought because he just didn't have the time or energy. Posters titled "Okhema's hope" were plastered on the window of the store. Phainon felt a wave of embarrassment when he first laid eyes on one of those posters.

People had always noticed him— at least, half the city did. But this was different. *Everyone's* eyes were now on him.

"Carrots… check. Onions— now where did they put the onions?"

Phainon bent over the crates, trying to locate the onions. At tap on his shoulder made him jolt.

He pulled his mask back up and spun around to face some of his classmates. Not the press or the general public. Good. He's had to be extremely careful recently to avoid being swarmed.

A blonde haired girl spoke up."Do you want to go to the party we're hosting tonight?"

"I— " He paused.

Phainon had to get back to Mydei.

"No, I'm sorry. I can't do that today. Have fun!"

Normally, he would have agreed to spare the person's feelings. But why should he? He had important things to get home to.

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Four days later

Miss Tribios had informed them earlier that day that they were partnered up for yet another mission— this time, to no resistance.

Mydei took off his helmet and removed his leather jacket. Phainon turned around and squinted up at the wall, the glare of the sun burning his eyes. He would rather burn his eyes and bleach his brain than ogle at Mydei's muscular arms.

"What're you trying to do, staring up at the sun like that?" Mydei questioned

"Burning my eyes." Phainon responded simply.

"…"

"…"

"Why?"

Without even looking at him,Phainon could tell Mydei was beyond perplexed. He was probably cocking his head to the side and trying to understand Phainon's actions. Phainon's heart squeezed a little at that mental image.

"No reason." Phainon chirped in a voice too upbeat and high to be his own.

He then scaled the wall and stood at the top, grinning down at Mydei. "What do you think, Mydei? I practised."

Mydei seemed lost in thought, gazing at Phainon with an indescribable look on his face. He climbed up the wall too, his hair fluttering in the wind.

"Not bad." Mydei said after they descended onto the soft grass.

Phainon scanned the area for Black Tide creatures. The breeze was rather strong that day and grey clouds were already sweeping in. He could hear soft rustling but he couldn't find the source of that sound. He nearly jumped out of his skin when Mydei's hand tapped his shoulder.

"There are two groups— there." Mydei pointed to the right "And there" Mydei pointed straight ahead at the dense foliage.

Phainon sputtered, still calming his rapidly beating heart— the reason definitely not being Mydei's proximity, "How did you—"

"I didn't train for wars by playing board games and chatting over coffee, HKS"

"Alright, I'll go straight ahead and you go right. Shout my name if you need help."

Mydei quirked an eyebrow "I don't recall you being the team leader. As far as I'm concerned, I was the one who pointed out the creatures." He held up both hands, as if in resignation "But fine, I'll do as you say, just this once. Try not to get yourself killed out there, Deliverer."

"You too."

Phainon took a deep breath before heading in the direction Mydei pointed out. A shrill screech cut through the air.

Phainon points Dawnmaker in the direction of the sound. A Black Tide creature lunged at him. He deflected the hit and stabbed it in the chest. Letting one last guttural screech, it fell silent.

It was like the rest of the forest came alive, Black Tide creatures swarming him in hordes. Phainon hacked his way through them with ease. *It's strange*, he thought to himself as he sidestepped a rolling severed limb, *how the number of creatures have grown exponentially.*

The Black Tide had stopped its erosion by now, so where did so many Black Tide monsters even come from?

He did a quick headcount of the creatures he'd killed— fifty five. Phainon was pretty sure he finished his job.

A laboured gasp came from behind a tree. Phainon approached it cautiously, Dawnmaker at the ready. A woman lay on the floor, coughing weakly. Phainon paled— citizens of Okhema don't ever wander outside the walls. So this woman must be a refugee. Her eyes darted up at Phainon and swiveled about frantically, like a cornered animal.

"Hello? I'm going to be bringing you back to Okhema, okay?" Phainon attempted to pacify her, placing Dawnmaker on the grass and holding both of his arms up to show that he meant no harm.

Her ragged breathing didn't cease. In fact, it didn't look like she understood what Phainon said.

Phainon fired off a quick email to Mydei.

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>10:57AM
to Mydei ▼

Go to the facility and arrange medical help for a person in the outskirts. Go without me, I'll get back on my own with her.

Phainon kneeled to the ground, his heart twisting painfully when the woman flinched. She reminded him too much of himself when he was younger. He had promised to never let anyone have to suffer the way he did — so he became someone who promised hope and safety.

But it felt like he failed her.

What was the point of trying to protect everyone if he failed to protect a single person?

Phainon didn't know how long it took, but he eventually coaxed her into trusting him enough to let him escort her to safety. As the woman stood up shakily, Phainon spotted a small building in the distance. Must be one of the watch towers stationed around the perimeter. The woman stumbled and Phainon rushed to help her.

"What's your name?" Phainon prodded gently, offering her a bottle of water.

The woman said nothing, guzzling down the water like it was the first and last time she's ever had water.

It wasn't much, but it was a start.

She gawked at the sight of the facility when they finally approached it. He led her into the med bay, braving his way past the curious stares. Hyacine wasn't on shift, but the other nurses instantly snapped up to help the woman.

After ensuring her safety, Phainon headed off in search of Mydei. He poked his head into possible rooms where Mydei could be. When his search started feeling fruitless, Phainon considered the possibility of Mydei getting back to the apartment. He aimlessly wandered through the garage before he heard a familiar voice.

"I'm right behind you"

There he was, in all his radiant glory— hair like spun gold, its ends dipped crimson. Phainon's face broke into a huge grin.

"So, how many did you kill?" He asked, practically skipping over to Mydei. If he seemed desperate, so be it.

"So we're not addressing the email you sent me?"

"Oh, right, there was this woman beyond Okhema's borders. She's probably a refugee or got lost. I decided to bring her back with me and arrange a medical examination. If she's all clear, she can live in the refugee camp until she can get back on her feet."

"As expected of the Deliverer."

There was no bite to Mydei's words, rather, a warmth that made Phainon's head spin.

"Ah, I'll go check in on the lady— the preliminary medical test results should be out soon. See you in the apartment?" Phainon asked.

"Yes, see you." Mydei hopped on his bike and drove away.

Phainon was heading up the stairs when a shrill screech cut through the air. Screams followed— the sound making Phainon's blood run cold. Red flooded his peripheral vision as alarms blared. Fear coiled in his gut as he sprinted towards the source of the sound. His mind raced through the possibility of what could've happened. His footfalls felt slowed, weighed down by apprehension. His lungs couldn't take in enough oxygen to sustain his panic. Others in the facility ran the other way, trying to flee the building as fast as they could. Phainon just ran towards the destruction.

And if the fire killed him, then so be it.

He felt sick to his very being when he heard yet another scream erupt from the closed door of the med bay. Slamming himself against the door, he staggered into the room and froze when he saw the pool of red gather at his feet.

Blood.

There was so much blood.

Blood splattered the pristine white shelves of the med bay, cascaded down the walls and pooled onto the ground. The room was bathed in crimson.

Tears pricked his eyes when he registered the desecrated corpses littering the room. A body was flung at him and weakly thumped against the wall before falling to the ground like a swallow shot out of the sky. Ribs

protruded from the nurse's body as he made a gurgling sound, blood and froth escaping his mouth before his eyes rolled up and turned glassy.

A Black Tide creature stood at the center of it, ripping off someone's arm and gnawing the bone. Sickening crunches filled the room as it shattered the bone and chewed it. Its eyes roved around the room before focusing on Phainon. Those eyes had the same disoriented, terrified quality the woman he'd escorted had.

Oh.

Oh.

The monster advanced on him and all he could do in that moment was remain frozen in his spot. He was catatonic as it neared him.

This was it. This was the end.

Finally, his survival instincts— honed after years of surviving in Styxia— finally kicked in.

He moved out of the way as it attacked and cut it down with Dawnmaker.

The monster that paraded as human breathed its last, just like its victims had. It was just him, standing in the middle of a scene he never wanted to be a part of again. He did exactly what he did when he was younger, standing in a room with his family's dead bodies. He left.

Like the coward he was.

Phainon felt like he was in a grainy slow motion horror film as he watched the ambulances pull up to the building.Something curled in his insides, making him want to rip them out— tear his lungs open and let the pain flow freely. Throat constricting so hard he thought he might choke, the grief swelled in his body like a surging tide with no way out. That tide burnt him from the inside, it existed in every breath.

He didn't register much, just the bodies being carried out and the panic that followed. Wrapped in white, the flesh and bone encasing of what used to be their consciousness was all that was left of the victims; their life's story reduced to the way they died.

He could only hope that death was kind.

Phainon felt too numb to cry at the funeral.

The drones that reported the incident flew above the attendees. Huge screens placed all over the city reported the incident for all to see.

"*Incident.. at the CHRYSOS institute… three found dead… suspected Black Tide monster attack..*" The screens blared.

"Okhema is no longer safe! Look! Even the safest institute— our protectors — got attacked, so what about us?" A reporter cried out

He stood among the sea of mourners, the crowd suffocating like a thick blanket on a hot summer's day. The families of the deceased stood at the forefront, sobbing uncontrollably over their graves. The grief of their families must be unfathomable, a pain beyond what Phainon felt.

A sound similar to the siren blared before all the screens in Okhema were taken over by an emergency broadcast. *The Council of Elders' emergency report*, the screens displayed before a spokesperson sat before a table, adjusting the her glasses.

"We have received intel about the tragedy at CHRYSOS institute. Video footage of a certain recruit has surfaced, where he leads a Black Tide creature in disguise into the facility."

Phainon saw his face on the big screen, where he guided the woman into the facility. It cut to a video of him rushing further into the building as everyone else ran out. Finally, a grainy picture of him leaving the scene, covered in blood.

"If this is the person you entrust your lives and futures to, I implore you to reconsider. First, he led three people to their deaths. Second, he didn't take

accountability for the incident. Your so called Deliverer has failed you. Tell me again, what is the CHRYSOS institute supposed to stand for? Hope? Is this really hope? Is there even any use keeping it up and running?"

They knew.

Everyone knew.

Everything Phainon worked so hard to build— the reputation, the trust, the sense of safety— came tumbling down that very moment.

Eyes swiveled around to focus on him, their glares of contempt burned holes into his skin as he stood rooted in place. His heart felt like it could sink no more out of the sheer panic dragging it down. The next thing he registered was the crowd parting to give way to a woman with pure rage in her eyes. She grabbed the front of his shirt and shook him.

"*YOU KILLED MY SON!*" She screamed in a raw, broken voice

Phainon wanted to protest— he had enough strength to break free, but he felt too weak to try. She was right, he killed her son. The crowd shifted around him, craning their heads at the scene. Yet, they maintained a distance from him, creating what felt like a black hole of space around him. Nobody dared cross the invisible circle. He was something to watch, to gawk at and to hate.

"HOW COULD YOU TAKE HIM AWAY FROM US? *HOW DARE YOU!"* She cried, her hands snaking around his throat like a vine. Phainon let out a choked sound as her hands pressed down. He bit the inside of his mouth, trying to dampen his reaction. He didn't want anyone to think he was begging for pity if he looked wretched enough.

Crying would only garner more revulsion, for he was a vile thing beyond redemption.

"I'm sorry" Was all he could say.

"SORRY? Is that all you have to say to me?"

Phainon flinched, squeezing his eyes shut and preparing himself for the full force of her rage.

He slowly opened his eyes as he felt her jolt and retract her hands. She looked horrified at what she'd just done— staggering back. The crowd murmured and shifted, but he couldn't catch a word they were saying. He numbly lifted a hand to his throat. Someone was near his leg. Phainon glanced down.

A little boy looked up at him, eyes red rimmed and implored in a quiet voice, "Can you bring my sister back?"

Phainon's heart shattered. How could he not feel such a deep sense of connect to the little boy— Phainon himself was in his shoes once, clinging to every hope that his family would magically be alive. He cursed the Black Tide, swore that when he grew up, he'd avenge their deaths.

Phainon was just as bad as the Tide's monsters in the child's eyes.

"No." Phainon finally murmured.

"She's really gone, isn't she?" The kid asked in a wavering voice.

Phainon took a sharp breath, because *yes, of course she was and he was to blame for it.*

The boy's parents whisked him out of Phainon's line of sight, like Phainon was a radioactive substance that nobody wanted to get near to or touch. They glared at him— the message clear in their eyes— *it should've been you, not her.*

Phainon found himself agreeing wholeheartedly. It felt like he aged a million years in those few seconds. Some people talked to him, but their words flew over Phainon's head. He just wanted out. To where, he did not know, but he wanted to leave. The hum of people eventually surged to close in on him. Heavy footfalls approached him as Danae, one of his acquaintances, strode to him.

"*What did you do,* Phainon of Aedes Elysiae?" Her voice sounded defeated; broken beyond repair. Wrath would've been easier for Phainon to sustain.

He took away her lover.

He truly was repulsive.

"What would you rather I say?" A voice that wasn't his, yet sounded unmistakeably his and coming from his own mouth, responded.

"Say that you regret it. Defend yourself— give me a reason to want you dead."

Phainon gave up.

What was all this for? First, his family. Next, all those lives he couldn't save in Styxia. Now this?

Trying was futile if all the outcomes led to the death of everyone but him.

"I suggest you leave." An icy voice broke through the crowd. It wasn't a suggestion, it was a command. The crowd parted to give way to a tall, imposing figure. Mydei had a feral look on his face. That was a look

Phainon had never seen before. The people surrounding Phainon backed away. Mydei placed himself between Phainon and the families. The intent was clear— *you have to get through me to get to him.*

"Come on." He turned to Phainon, grabbing his hand and leading him away.

Once they were out of the crowd, Phainon wrenched his hand away and locked eyes with Mydei, a calm indifference settling over him.

"I don't need your help." He said coldly.

"*Phainon*— "

"Hate me all you want, just don't try to reason with me. Don't try to side with me or ask me for an explanation. Please."

"Please listen to what I have to say." Mydei argued, firm in his resolve.

Phainon took a few steps back, shaking his head. "No. This would be so much easier if you didn't pity me."

"But I don't pity you."

"Lies." Phainon smiled sweetly before he fled.

Phainon didn't want people to look at him in the pitying way they did when he was in Styxia. *The wretched child, so young and afraid,* they'd think. Phainon despised sympathy and as much as he felt like a horrible person for lashing out, he'd rather face anger than pity.

It was as he left the funeral that he realised that was the first time Mydei had called him by his name. Unnoticed, he went up to his old dorm room.

The room was almost fully repaired— the leaky pipe and sagging roof gone. Phainon remembered leaving behind some clothes and snacks that wouldn't fit into his suitcase. Yes, those would suffice. He could hide away from the rest of the world for as long as he wanted to.

In the mirror, he noticed red marks on his neck. His fingers brushed over them and rested on the sun tattoo. He had gotten that tattoo when he decided to commit to the role of Deliverer. Now, looking at the angry red marks that surrounded it, that dream felt more like naivety.

Phainon heard shouts from outside, so he pushed up the glass of his windows and looked down. There stood a mob of people, angrily shouting curses at him. They must've figured out where he went.

"Send him out! Let him live with the monsters!"

"Murderer!"

Security reached them, escorting them out. Their hatred lingered in the air long after they left. He could only imagine the disgust and regret Hyacine, Castorice, Aglaea, Tribios and Anaxa felt at having the misfortune of knowing him. Worst of all, Mydei— *Kephale*, he didn't even want to think about what Mydei wanted to tell him earlier.

Too numb to feel anything, he stared at the empty patch of grass.

He shut the window closed with a loud bang and let the tears he'd been holding back fall.

The skies wept along with him.

Rain pattered on the window, drowning out his sobs.

"I'm sorry" He told the empty room.

"I'm so sorry." He repeated to his revolting reflection in the mirror.

"Please forgive me." He said to no one at all, choking on his sobs.

Chapter End Notes

Uh haha well that was fun.

See yall next week!

Chapter 4: You were just a kid when they told you; you'd been born to bleed, little soldier

Chapter Notes

> Hi there! I'm back this week with the fourth and longest chapter (it's 13k words wow I did not expect to write that much). Not much else to say here, but MAN reading through what I wrote this chapter has me cringing so hard, to the point where I literally debated posting this the entire day, but I shall persist and post this anyways. Godspeed.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Fifteen years ago

Cyrene drew up a card.

"The Chariot" She said. "It means determination and willpower" She smiled, baring her teeth, wild and carefree. Cyrene was happy, so he was too. He clapped and laughed with her.

"Phainon, some day you will be someone strong and powerful. You will fight for the sake of so many others." She ruffled his hair.

"Really?"

"Yep! Trust me, you'll do great!"

That naive child believed that he was capable of becoming something great.

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Six years ago

Sometimes, he liked to sneak into the remnants of a school in Styxia. He'd flip through the pages of the textbooks and read yellowed notes students used to pass to each other. Phainon would fantasise about continuing his schooling in Aedes Elysiae. He'd go to school in the mornings with Cyrene and run through the wheat fields to reach the only school in their tiny village. They'd sit under the big maple tree for some lessons or inside the building if it got too hot outside.

Phainon liked sitting outside better. It felt liberating to have the soft breeze tickle you.

Classes would be temporarily suspended in the harvesting seasons so the students could help their parents catch fish or harvest crops. Not many children lived there; more than half of them moved out to the big city when they became adults. There was only one teacher, Miss Pythias. She would let them out to play once school was done. That was the highlight of Phainon's day.

And then, reality would wash over him like a bucket of ice cold water.

Aedes Elysiae and everyone in it were long gone. Yes, Aedes Elysiae itself wasn't fully lost to the Black Tide because there wasn't much of it to be destroyed. But the people? The ones who made that place home?

They were dead— Phainon being the bearer of their memory, the only one left to tell their stories.

He would sneak back out of the school and chastise himself for being so out of it because now the rations for dinner are probably gone.

Phainon kicked a pebble down the streets of Styxia aimlessly. On his back was a sharp chunk of metal he'd broken off a crumbling structure— he used it to fight. He wore clothes he scavenged from bags that belonged to people who didn't live to see another sunrise. Morally questionable, yes, but morals? In this wasteland? Perish that thought.

He reached his makeshift home— the location changed every few weeks because stagnation killed. Bidding goodbye to his new pebble friend, he pushed up the window and climbed into the building. The door to the building and several other rooms were completely destroyed, but there were a few fully intact.

Structural integrity be damned.

He knelt onto the sheets of a makeshift bed and took off his bag. Inside it was the rations he'd secured for himself. Phainon broke off a piece of stale bread and opened a can of olives far beyond its expiration date. Not the most appetising meal, but it would do. Midway through his meal, a sharp rap hit the window.

His stomach lurched.

Stuffing the rest of his meal into his mouth, he scrambled to his feet. If that was a Black Tide monster, he was ready to face it. The knock sounded again. Black Tide creatures didn't have manners, so this must be a human. Most of the others in Styxia minded their own business and only swooped in to scavenge through the belongings of the deceased.

This person might be dangerous.

"Hello? Is anyone there?" A dignified voice that sounded like it belonged to a noble lady came from the other side.

"I can see your shadow, no point in hiding" A younger, cheekier female voice teased.

These people weren't from here. It wouldn't end well if he ignored them and Phainon knew how to escape and fight back. He would be fine.

"Uh— Yes. Hi." He responded, wincing at how coarse his voice sounded.

"See? I told you he went in here."

Had they been following him?

The noble lady cleared her throat. "Can we come in?"

Phainon couldn't talk to those people dressed the way he was. He didn't want them to think of him as some poor soul who lived a life of suffering— a project for them to take back home and show off like a trophy. Deciding that he needed to look more presentable, he pulled out a wrinkled button up shirt he found the other day.

"One minute" He called out, changing into the shirt. "Okay, yes, you can come in now."

He stepped back cautiously as a grey haired girl with a cat eared hoodie climbed in first. A golden haired woman with the strangest pair of green eyes he had ever seen followed her. The noble lady looked exactly what her voice sounded like— regal in every way and terribly out of place in this wasteland.

"My name is Aglaea." She introduced herself

"Neat place you have there, little guy." The grey haired girl commented, whizzing through the room, prodding at wires and cobwebbed furniture.

"That's Cipher" Aglaea gestured to the girl, who busied herself with upturning her jacket and counting the little trinkets she'd collected.

Phainon shifted awkwardly "Hello, I'm Phainon. It's not really my place, I'm just here for a while."

"Do you live here with anyone else? Like a parent or a friend or a sibling?"

"No. It's just me."

"… I see. And how long have you been here for?"

Phainon counted the number of years he'd spent here on his fingers, holding up a finger for each year he remembered.

He held up three fingers."I'm guessing three."

"And you are currently?"

"Sixteen or seventeen."

"Hm."

Phainon felt his cheeks burn. Sure, he wasn't the healthiest teenager, but he was pretty tall— taller than most people around here. So surely, he looked old enough.

"Nice shirt." Cipher giggled from behind him.

Great. Now, what was wrong with his shirt?

Sensing his exasperation, she pointed to the back of the shirt and snorted "I'm sure you didn't want 'kick me' written on the back of it. Permanent marker, I think. Bold choice."

Mortification washed over him. He squeezed his eyes shut, trying to pretend like this encounter wasn't real and nothing ever happened. When he opened his eyes again and saw the same two people, he gave up on that fleeting hope.

"Why are you two even here? This isn't exactly a tourist destination. Most people want out." He asked, tugging at the fraying threads of the linen shirt.

"I've founded an institute— CHRYSOS. We aim to eliminate the Black Tide that plagues Amphoreus. Currently, we're bringing refugees from all over Amphoreus to Okhema for safety."

"And I happened to be the first guinea pig you laid eyes on?"

"Actually, you're the last."

"Huh?"

No wonder the streets felt so empty. There weren't many other people in Styxia to begin with, and the numbers kept dwindling as more and more people dropped dead. Phainon used to think that it was inevitable that he would be the last man standing.

Aglaea nodded and explained,"We heard about this white haired teenager who fought against Black Tide creatures and protected the people here. You're a truly selfless and noble person, Phainon"

Noble? Selfless? No, that was stretching it. He just didn't want people to die to the creatures, maybe give them one less thing to worry about. That was what his Ma taught him. He was just trying to be less of a bad son to her.

"You were a tricky one to find, I'll give you that" Cipher said, resuming her position at Aglaea's side.

"Uh, thanks?"

Phainon was getting distracted, so he dragged his mind back to his original train of thought "Wait, is this some elaborate recruitment scheme to get me into your program? If so, I refuse to be your toy."

"No. We're bringing you back to Okhema like everyone else in Styxia because safety is a human's basic right. If you choose to join our program, that decision would be yours to make." Aglaea said firmly.

"Oh. Um—" Phainon stared at the ground.

"What're you waiting for, little guy? Come on!" Cipher picked up Phainon's bag and tossed it to him.

Phainon fumbled with the bag before following them out.

As he took a seat in the train that led them to Okhema, Phainon realised that this was really happening. He was really getting out of Styxia. There was a weight that settled in his heart that pushed down the hope— just how much he owed Aglaea for saving him.

"I'll join your program." He said after much deliberation.

Aglaea was pleasantly surprised "That's great. You'll be enrolled once we reach Okhema." She offered him a small smile.

Perhaps this was a chance to prove himself invaluable, he mused, admiring the forests the train sped by. He could protect other people— properly, this time.

Nobody would have their futures stolen from them, not if he could help it.

Years later, that last ember of childish hope was snuffed out. Once reality truly set in and glamour wore off, a bone deep exhaustion settled.

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Present day

The next few days were a nightmare playing on loop and Phainon didn't have a remote to pause it. He stayed locked up in his room, sleeping fitfully most of the time and devouring snacks nearing their expiration date when he was awake. The rage he felt at himself for being so *disgusting* never left.

It looked back at him when he looked into the mirror. It terrorised him when he was asleep.

But he was fine. He was always fine— and never anything but. Even as his life burned down, he sat and watched because he didn't deserve anything else.

He ignored the calls that began to pile up and eventually, blocked everyone's contacts. Phainon didn't have the heart to block Mydei's email, so he did see the notifications, but never read them. Sometimes, he scrolled through social media through an anonymous account and read through the online discussions about him. He deliberately avoided the excessively aggressive ones— his self hatred was more than enough, thank you very much.

"Black Tide creature in disguise"

As if.

"We have been played as fools by this charming charlatan"

Charming? Him?

"DieDieDieDieDieDieDie Phainon you monster"

…

That one slipped through the cracks. Next.

"I heard he lived in Styxia, you know, with all the monsters around him. Maybe that's where he got his liking for murder."

How did they even figure out about his past? He thought he hid it pretty well. But when you're Okhema's most hated person, people are bound to dig up dirt on you.

"CHRYSOS is probably gonna shut down because of him. I mean, everyone's lost faith in them bc of how badly he screwed up. I mean, killing three people? That's wild."

Yep, that's enough depressing posts for one day.

Phainon fell back onto the bed, sprawling out on the sheets. The sharp, stabbing pain of his blunder had turned into a dull ache. His eyes were rimmed with red permanently now and his eyes stung when he cried.

Checking his phone again, he saw yet another email from Mydei. Maybe it was morbid curiosity or pure loneliness, he read through the emails Mydei

sent.

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>5:55 PM
to me▼

Phainon, where did you go? Please, I just want to talk.

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>5:57 PM
to me▼

I heard you're in your dorm room, is that true?

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>6:15 PM
to me▼

I know you don't want to talk to anyone right now, but trust me when I say, none of this is your fault.

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>7:01 AM
to me▼

HKS, are you okay?

I don't pity you and I never will, but even the strongest people need support.

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>7:00 PM
to me▼

Aglaea has made sure nobody approaches your dorm room. Castorice and Hyacine say you've blocked their numbers— they're worried sick about you. You haven't blocked my email yet, so I will keep sending you messages in hopes of you replying.

If you still want to talk, you know where to find me.

.

.

.

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>10:50 AM
to me▼

You still won't answer my emails, huh? It's been five days, HKS.

Please tell me you're alright.

My offer still stands.

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>3:30PM
to me▼

You asshole, I am tired of letting you suffer on your own.

Look. Look at this.

Attachment

The link Mydei sent led him to a website full of messages written by anonymous people.

"Phainon, don't give up! "

"We think you've been wrongfully accused— nobody would give that much of themself to hurt others."

"Okhema needs its Deliverer!"

"Phainon, if you're reading this, you should know that there are people that know you're innocent. We trust you."

Phainon swallowed the lump in his throat. There would always be people who believed in his innocence. Like that little girl in the cafe, there would be people relying on him to protect them.

If there was even one person who relied on him, Phainon was willing to repair the pieces of his shattered heart as many times as he needed to.

In a burst of adrenaline, he donned a black hoodie and mask. He paced around the room, trying to formulate an escape plan before his eyes landed on the window. Nobody would expect him to exit through the window, he was sure of it. Pocketing his phone, he ran to the window and flung it open, breathing in a lungful of fresh air . The fall was two stories high, with a bush at the bottom.

Phainon clambered onto the windowsill and jumped. He let out a yelp as his shoe caught onto the windowsill and he tumbled down into the bushes.

The sun felt like it was mocking him as he lay sprawled on the bushes in an undignified heap. He brushed himself off and checked if anyone else saw his fall.

It was just him, the bird in the tree and the sun as witnesses. Good.

Ignoring the side eyes he got from one or two passers by as he walked by in a black hoodie and mask under the burning sun, he finally reached Mydei's apartment. Carefully, he snuck past the security guards and crept into the gym.

Was Mydei even going to be there? Phainon felt stupid for not considering that earlier.

But there he was, the red tattoos that resembled fire lining his arms and the braid resting on his right shoulder.

Mydei.

Something akin to relief washed over Mydei's face when he locked eyes with Phainon.

"How did you know I'd come here today?" Phainon asked, trying to stop his stupid heart from beating out of his ribcage.

"I didn't."

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A past long since erased by time

"Mother?" A blonde haired child climbed into Gorgo's lap, his wide golden eyes shimmering like the stars he so admired.

"Yes, my little lion?" Gorgo pet his hair as she read through the army's monthly report that Krateros had handed to her.

"Can we leave this place? I don't need the crown. I want to play with kids my age and you and I can live in a big house and build a library. You told me that you wanted to run a library one day."

Gorgo wanted nothing more than to wrap her child in warmth and love and never let him set foot on the battlefield. But he was destined to bear the weight of the crown— thorns and all. He was in far greater danger if he

wasn't in the army. She despised herself for not being able to protect her one and only child.

She hated herself even more as she shook her head. "No, my child, your duty and future lies with the people of Kremnos."

"Oh." Her son whispered, his dreams of a better future shattered.

He still asked her if they could run away to a better life every now and then — hoping her answer would change one day.

It never did.

One day, he stopped asking altogether.

Years later, she lay dying on the floor after being poisoned by Eurypon. Mydei kneeled before her, crying like a child and begging her not to go.

"Mother…" He choked out. Her son was not one to cry often, let alone be this distraught.

Gorgo used the last of her strength to pet his hair. "It's okay. Go claim the position that was rightfully yours."

Furiously wiping away the tears that streamed down his cheeks, he asked,"Who did this?"

"Eurypon."

He went silent, looking ready to rip heaven and hell apart.

"I'll kill him." The calm iciness in his tone was uncharacteristic. But he meant every word.

"Mydei, do not let rage be the only thing that drives you."

"But mother—"

"No. I want you to claim what is rightfully yours and then do with it what you see fit. I believe that whatever choice you make will be the right one. Go live your life as you wanted to when you were a child." She could feel her eyes closing, her vision darkening. Death was coming to her, at last.

Mydei's lips moved, forming words, but she couldn't hear what he was saying.

"Goodbye, my son" That was the last thing Gorgo said before her vision blackened and she breathed her last.

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Six days ago

Mydei wished he had never left the building. He had let down his guard down. He wasn't vigilant enough.

He drove back to CHRYSOS, towards the sirens blaring and the gates shutting closed. Pushing his way past the crowd that had formed outside the building, he made his way into the building, ready to fight if needed. It felt like his days on the battlefield, where every breath could be your last and the sharp iron smell of blood permeated the air. As a child, he wanted to run away from it all, begged his mother to reconsider and take him far, far away from the battlefield. He didn't understand the pain in her eyes when she shook her head. Now, as an adult, Mydei knew she had to crush his hopes because there was never any hope in his life.

It occurred to him that Phainon said he was heading to the med bay— and fear unlike any other coursed through his veins. Losing another person he cared for would break him.

Bodies covered in blood surrounded the slain Black Tide creature. The pinkish red lump protruding from a nasty gash on a corpse looked eerily like intestines. Someone's bloodstained shoe prints traveled out of the scene. At the very least, Phainon wasn't there.

Mydei felt unsettled not because of the scene— for he had grown up around bloodshed— but because of the horrible familiarity of it. It was glory to be slain on the battlefield and have your body, or what remains of it, be carried back to be wreathed in flowers by your loved ones.

He kneeled to the floor, closing the eyes of the victims one final time.

The police entered shortly after.

At the funeral, he did not miss the wary glances thrown his way— suspecting him of the murder.

The screens along Okhema city showed footage of Phainon. *The real culprit,* they said.

Mydei's blood ran cold.

It would never be Phainon.

It *will* never be Phainon.

Oh, how he wished they suspected him of being the murderer instead. He tore his eyes away from the screen, frantically searching for Phainon. A crowd had begun to gather around a certain point and that was when Mydei knew exactly what was going on.

He didn't know what he expected when he saw Phainon standing in the middle of the crowd, but he certainly didn't expect to see Phainon look so unafraid. No, it wasn't a lack of fear— rather, a complete shut down of the Phainon he knew. Phainon didn't shrink back, instead, he had this indescribable blank expression on his face.

It was the red markings around Phainon's neck that made Mydei see red.

"I suggest you leave." Mydei said in the voice he used to command armies back then. Phainon didn't protest when Mydei dragged him out of the crowd.

It was like Phainon had built walls so high Mydei couldn't possibly reach the person behind— no reasoning would make Phainon listen.

He had to pretend like it didn't break his heart when Phainon left.

"They should just kill him or something, why are we even near a serial killer?" A voice came from somewhere behind Mydei.

Mydei didn't think twice before punching the man. The man sputtered, reeling back. He held his cheek in indignation, but cowered once he got a better look at Mydei.

"Kremnoans, such brutes— especially their leader." muttered the man as he walked away. Mydei only wished he had hurt the man more.

Mydei knew Phainon. He was annoyingly helpful and would bend over backwards for another person. He didn't know how to say no. It was obvious that the smiles were practised— although, the real ones sometimes shined through. But Phainon would never want to hurt another person.

He only ever wanted to help.

But how Mydei wished Phainon would let him help in return.

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To watch the brilliant sun that was Phainon die out was the hardest thing Mydei has ever had to watch.

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Three days ago

Castorice and Hyacine were outside the facility, sitting on a park bench. Hyacine flipped through pages of records— possibly medical ones. Castorice was sewing together a small Chimera plushie. Looking up when she heard Mydei's footfalls, she nodded in greeting.

"Any news on what's going to happen to CHRYSOS?" Mydei asked.

"The motion for it to be shut down will be passed by the end of this week." Hyacine squeezed her eyes shut. To become so attached to a place, only to have it ripped away from you was painful. She opened her eyes again, "Although, I'm more concerned about Phainon. He's not responded to Castorice and I's calls or messages. And now, well, he's blocked us."

Mydei didn't know why he hoped that Phainon would respond to anyone, even if it wasn't him.

Castorice looked up, "He's not responding to you either?"

"Well, it doesn't look like he's blocked me."

Castorice smiled wryly "That would be so much sweeter if it weren't for the situation we're currently in."

"What part of this is sweet?"

"You don't even hate him, Mydei. You wouldn't jump in to protect his image at every turn if you hated him." Hyacine shook her head.

"And if I think that my rival deserves an equal footing and social standing as I?"

"If anything, both of you are hated by the public— so it's clear there's nothing for you to gain from him." Hyacine was too stressed out to laugh, but this was the closest she would get.

"Yeah. I guess that idiot grew on me." Mydei was never overtly sentimental, so it surprised him that he was even admitting it to someone other than himself.

"Phainon does that. You don't realise how much he's cemented himself into every aspect of your life until he's gone." Castorice paused, bushing off bits of fuzz that stuck themselves to her project, "I miss him already."

She was right. Phainon was such a constant— a certainty, almost. But now that Mydei no longer had a person to argue with over scores and go to the gym with, he felt a gaping void in his life that Phainon wormed his way into.

"You've seen the horrible stuff they've been saying about him online, haven't you? I hope he doesn't read any of those." Hyacine chewed her lip anxiously.

They were what?

Mydei went stock still. How dare they? Sorely wishing he could put a name to those cowards who hid behind a mask, Mydei clenched his fists. Initially, he wanted to find every last person who hated his people when he first got to Okhema. Time proved to be futile against the judgment and he had no choice but to hold his head high and deal with the stares. He could stand for hate against himself.

Just not against Phainon.

By then, Castorice and Hyacine were scrolling through social media, reporting malicious comments about Phainon. Mydei could tell that this was not their first time doing it.

Castorice frowned and pointed at a comment on Hyacine's screen.

Deliverer, you sleazy liar. You fooled us all with your innocent act.

"Report that bitch."

"On it." Hyacine aggressively tapped on the report button.

"I'll help." Mydei stepped in, hastily attempting to open an account. "Once I figure out how this thing works."

The next few minutes were spent in cleaning out all the malicious comments and death threats the three of them could find about Phainon.

His throat felt dry when he saw the best edit he'd ever seen of Phainon on one of the fan pages. It wasn't like he had a solid parameter to go by, but it was a start.

Focus, Mydei.

Somehow, leading the Kremnoan Detachment was easier than trying not to get distracted by incredibly well edited clips of Phainon at the meeting with the Council of Elders.

"And that's the last one I could find" Hyacine sighed, slumping back onto the chair. Castorice scrolled through her phone a bit longer before picking up her needle and thread again.

"I wish we could do more for him" Castorice sighed.

Hyacine consoled Castorice, patting her shoulder, "None of us know much about Phainon. We know he's not from Okhema, but he doesn't say much else."

Of course. All Mydei had ever seen of Phainon was the perfected smile and obnoxious cheer. It was only when they fought that Phainon let his guard down and let himself be imperfect. Perhaps it was that imperfection and humanity that made Mydei fall so hard. Mydei was far from being the most open person. but Phainon had built walls unnaturally high."That stupid enigma."

"Enigma is right. Phainon was somewhat different when I first met him when we were both new to CHRYSOS all those years ago— ready to fight — bloodthirsty, even, when he thought nobody was looking. I wanted to try to figure out what was wrong, but I never did." Castorice ruminated.

"Bloodthirsty?"

"More like he was waiting for everything to fall apart and something to go wrong."

"What could have caused that?"

"That's the thing. We don't know."

"…"

Stupid, idiotic HKS. why didn't you trust us enough to tell us anything at all? Why didn't you trust me?

Mydei was being petty. He shouldn't expect Phainon to explain his entire life's story— but Mydei felt like the months past made them closer. Or maybe he was just being idiotic. Yeah, that sounded about right. All rational thought was not applicable around Phainon.

Castorice snapped him out of his daze."Mydei.. regardless of what you may or may not know about Phainon, will you still be on his side?"

"Yes. Yes, I will defend him regardless of the consequence. I'll defend him however hard it may be. He's… he's Phainon. Its hard not to care this much." Silence followed Mydei's impassioned speech. Castorice looked like she was having an epiphany.

"You.. like him, don't you?" Hyacine asked slowly.

Of course I have. It's hard not to. Phainon is brilliant like no other.

"No. That's ridiculous." Mydei didn't know why he was trying to defend himself.

"Uh huh."

Both Castorice and Hyacine stared at him expectantly, but Mydei stayed resolute. "Let's move on to another topic."

Judging by the looks they gave him when he packed up his stuff and hopped on his bike, they most certainly saw through his lie.

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Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>7:00 PM
to Phainon▼

Aglaea has made sure nobody approaches your dorm room. Castorice and Hyacine say you've blocked their numbers— they're worried sick about you. You haven't blocked my email yet, so I will keep sending you messages in hopes of you replying.

If you still want to talk, you know where to find me.

Mydei fired off that email and sat in a corner of the gym's waiting room.

Even if it took Phainon months to come around, Mydei would wait.

Each day, Mydei would wake up early in the morning and head to the gym, where he would wait for any sign of Phainon. The other patrons eyed him curiously, but none dared approach. Not that there were many others around — most of Okhema had gone into panic. CHRYSOS was trying its best to ensure the safety of Okhema before it got shut down, but most citizens stayed hidden in their homes. For the first time in the few months Mydei had been here, the bustling, vibrant city of Okhema had been stripped of its colours.

Finally, *finally,* when Mydei saw the familiar flash of white hair and golden sun tattoo, he felt like he could breathe again.

"How did you know I'd come here today?", asked the only sun that mattered to him.

"I didn't"

It was stupid to wait for someone for days with no guarantee they'd ever show up.

It was stupid to be this in love with someone.

Mydei found that he didn't really care.

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Mydei motioned to the ring, handing Phainon a pair of boxing gloves. Feeling grateful that Mydei didn't prod or ask questions, Phainon stretched and put the gloves on. The message was— all things were when they came to Mydei— straightforward.

Fight me.

And Phainon— like the weak, weak man he was when it came to Mydei— agreed.

Mydei ,in his absurdly well fitting tank top, beckoned Phainon over. Phainon raised his hands aa he entered the ring, ready to fight.

However close they may have gotten, Mydei didn't hold back. He never did. And Phainon didn't plan on going easy on Mydei either. Fighting was so much easier than speaking.

The punches hurt and Phainon's arms throbbed with exertion. He poured every ounce of self loathing and grief he felt into each punch. For the first time, he felt like he was screaming the emotions that threatened to drown him. Mydei didn't budge, instead, he fought harder.

Mydei knew exactly how to make everything in Phainon's life feel less like a death sentence.

Titans, how Phainon loved Mydei.

What.

WHAT.

Was he in love with Mydei?

Every last cell in his body screamed *yes.*

He was so doomed

Phainon dimly registered the fist hitting his face. He staggered back, reeling from the shock. Strong arms steadied him and Mydei looked at him in concern. "What happened? You look like you lost focus."

"Uh huh." Phainon was too busy admiring the concerned furrow of Mydei's brows.

"Sit down, your cheek is swollen. I'll get an ice pack."

Phainon mutely nodded and flopped onto the floor. *He was in love with Mydei. It wasn't just a crush.* Sure, he'd briefly dated a person or two back then, but none of them compared to whatever this was with Mydei. His heart never threatened to seize and stop working and he most certainly did not make a fool of himself. Mydei returned with an ice pack and held it to Phainon's cheek. Phainon sucked in a breath when his skin met the blistering cold. Trying to look anywhere but at Mydei, Phainon fixated on the floor. He felt incredibly self conscious— was his heart beating too loud? Did his face look too unkempt? Oh Kephale, his outfit looked ugly as hell.

"Glad to see you're still up and fighting, Deliverer."

"That name."

"What name? Deliverer?"

"Is that not a nickname of contempt?"

"It was at first, but now I truly do see it. You embody hope, Phainon. You burn with the righteousness and fury of the sun."

Phainon squeezed his eyes shut, trying to dampen the surge of bittersweet joy. Mydei, of all people, saw him that way. "Do you really think so?"

"Yes. I know so."

Phainon felt breathless— Mydei had that effect on him.

"You didn't have to send me all those messages— or get this ice pack, or offer to fight me. You didn't have to care."

Mydei snorted. "Shut up. I care for my friends."

"You think I'm your friend?" Phainon asked softly. Tentative. Not sure if he could believe it.

"Unfortunately, yes."

I'm Mydei's friend. He's my friend. Phainon could sing to the clouds and the birds and to anyone who would listen. If only he wasn't so broken right now, he would be crying happy tears. Mydei would probably tell him to shut up and stop crying and Phainon would laugh at the absurdity of the situation.

But that was not reality.

Reality hurt like a knife being stabbed into his heart over and over. Reality was a vine strangling him— condemning him for his sins. If there was some sort of divine judgment by Thanatos after death, would they understand that Phainon's actions only came from a place of self preservation? Would they forgive the child who fought tooth and nail to survive the Black Tide in Aedes Elysiae; forgive his fear- driven actions for survival; forgive him for felling some of those he loved for they were too far gone to be saved?

"Deliverer? You're zoning out again."

Even if his whole life was a mistake, Mydei was someone Phainon would repeatedly sin for just for a chance to be close to him.

Love was a strange feeling, but not an unwelcome one.

It did not bandage up the cracks of his soul or repair him, but it gave him a reason to be *human* and that was enough for him. The shock was not of falling in love— no, that was inevitable and had always lingered in the back of his mind— but of his acceptance.

"Don't tell me I hit you that hard." Mydei frowned, hand tilting Phainon's cheek to the side to observe the blooming redness.

"No, no" Phainon squeaked out, standing up abruptly. Just because he had come to terms with his feelings did not mean that he was magically invulnerable to Mydei. He shifted in place and coughed out," Um. So can I go back to your apartment? I'm kinda hungry and miss the big place."

Mydei's sigh was that of relief, not annoyance. "Yes."

Phainon's room was exactly as he had left it the morning of that mission. The bedsheets strewn about, curtains shut— letting only a faint sliver of light into the room.

"You didn't move a thing, huh? Were you really waiting on me to return for that long?"

"Yes."

Phainon's breath caught in his throat and he felt like he was falling all over again.

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Later, Phainon opened up his laptop and played the news broadcast for that day. He kept up with the updates, wondering when he would be arrested for charges of murder.

It was Professor Anaxa on live television.

"Idiotic."

"Pardon?" The anchor sputtered, trying to gain his bearings.

"Your lot spread, baseless, idiotic claims. Have you fact checked? Have you any substance?" His gaze seemed to bore through the screen. "Why does no one look at the bigger picture? How conveniently placed this attack was? How convenient it would be to have Phainon as a scapegoat? For answers, I would look to none other than—"

The broadcast stopped and played something else.

"CHRYSOS to permanently close by the end of the week. Phainon has not been brought in for questioning or contacted by the authorities due to CHRYSOS' refusal"

He clicked another video on this recommended feed— skimming over the clickbait title : *New evidence of golden boy's nefarious plans.* Phainon wasn't a villain.

At least, he hoped he didn't look like one.

Newly captured footage from Phainon and Mydei's mission at the borders of Okhema had resurfaced. He could see a tiny pixelated figure that looked like him sprint towards the forest. As it turns out, there were cameras placed in the trees. He ignored the figure fighting off Black Tide creatures because his eyes caught onto something else. In the far distance, there was the small building. A watch tower, he had reasoned to himself. But watch towers were *towers*, not small, suspicious looking buildings.

It was a stupid thought, but what if the woman was linked to the small building? Out of sheer desperation to prove to himself that this gut feeling was right, Phainon rapped on Mydei's door.

"What is it, HKS?" came Mydei's voice from behind the door.

"Mydei, get your keys. We're going to Okhema's border."

The door slammed open. "I beg your finest fucking pardon?"

"Yep!" Phainon cracked his best imitation of a bright smile "Now get your bike's keys and helmet and take me there."

"What am I, your personal chauffer?"

"You're the only one between us who knows how to drive a bike."

"… I should teach you how to drive so you don't have to bother me like this." Mydei grumbled, but grabbed his keys and stormed past Phainon.

"I don't hear a no" Phainon gleefully trailed after Mydei "Don't tell me you've gone soft on me, Mydei."

"Go walk to the border yourself for all I care."

"Aww, you really have gone soft on me. Months ago, you would've hurled me out the window."

"And who says I won't do it right now?"

Phainon held both arms up in feigned defeat. "Alright, alright. You win."

He hummed a happy tune, knowing it was incredibly unsettling for him to be this upbeat after killing three people. By then, he had repressed his grief and regret so well that all he felt was numbness.

Watch enough people die and death no longer affects you the same, he supposed.

Nobody can be happy all the time and joy doesn't need to be felt entirely to act like one is happy. Most of what Phainon knew of joy was just a performance. He was the perfect actor on the stage— smiling so everyone else felt reassured. If he didn't smile, then who would?

"What're you staring out into space for? Get on." Mydei tapped the front of his bike.

"Yep! Coming!"

The streets of Okhema were sparse— TV broadcasts about the incident playing on every screen possible. Phainon wanted to shrink back and hide, but he didn't want to appear as weak as he was in front of Mydei.

"There! Park there!" Phainon yelled over the thrashing wind. It was a miracle that Mydei heard him. Mydei's bike skidded to a halt and Phainon leaped off, sprinting to the gate. They were being surveilled, so Phainon had to make this quick before anyone else was called to the scene. The sound of footsteps behind him made him know that Mydei was following him. He felt safe, somehow, having Mydei at his back.

"Damn— locked." Phainon cursed at the lock. To be fair, Okhema was essentially under lock down at this point. "Time to scale the wall like a spider without four limbs."

"Are you insulting the way I climbed over the wall the first time? In which case, you did the same recently." Mydei scoffed, crossing his arms.

"That doesn't make it any less embarrassing. I just wanted to prove a point to you."

"Prove what?"

"Prove to you that I was a worthy rival."

"There has never been a rival more worthy than you."

Phainon hoped Mydei didn't notice the blush on his face as he clambered up the wall. That was probably the most romantic thing anyone has ever said to him— however that may have sounded.

The forest remained eerily quiet, like no catastrophe had ever befallen it.

"So you mean to tell me that you're wandering into the outlands of Okhema without a weapon? Brilliant choice, leading us into our deaths." said Mydei. Stupid, rational, attractive Mydei. It hadn't even occurred to Phainon that he was marching straight to who knows where without Dawnmaker.

"You could have just let me come here alone and waited or something."

"That's not an option." Mydei strode past Phainon.

"What? How is that not an—"

"—Where are we even going?" Mydei interrupted him.

"Just follow me."

Phainon entered the forest and got to the spot where he met the woman. He squinted at the distance and spotted the small building. He pointed to the building."There."

"Huh. That's… an odd choice." Mydei was used to his spontaneous actions by now, but this was probably out of pocket, even for Phainon.

Something about the building felt wrong. So horribly wrong. His stomach churned as he took in the metal walls with rust caked on them— but he was not fearful of the place.

Phainon was afraid for so long that normal fear no longer applied to him.

Fear was his natural state of being. It clung to him as he laughed and joked with Castorice and Hyacine, it permeated every fiber of his being and it

coexisted with him. At some point, he no longer knew what it was like to not be afraid.

Phainon entered the building through a small metal door standing ajar on the side. Mydei insisted on going in first, just to scope out the area. He walked through a dimly lit corridor, covered with steel. This small building resembled a bunker more than anything else. His breaths felt way too loud and his footsteps echoed off the walls.

"Wait. I think I see something." Phainon whispered, grabbing Mydei's sleeve and yanking him his way. Mydei stumbled and glared at Phainon. Phainon pointed to a door with light leaking from the cracks. He inched towards the door tentatively. He had no idea what to expect going in, but he certainly didn't expect a stairwell.

At least he wasn't seeing any bloodied corpses. Those corpse still haunted him in his nightmares, begging him to save them before it was too late. He couldn't. He didn't. They screamed in agony as their ribs broke and punctured their lungs. They clawed at his skin and ripped chunks off. He'd wake up, his nails digging into his own skin, leaving red marks there.

Phainon padded down the stairs, Mydei at his heels. An acrid smell, similar to burnt flesh hit his nostrils before his eyes adjusted to the light. Before him stood rows and rows of containers, each containing silhouettes of Black Tide creatures suspended in some sort of liquid. Upon closer inspection, the figures were at varying stages of decay— but they looked partly human, judging by some parts

Phainon's blood ran cold.

It was like something in his brain clicked. The eyes of that one creature, the woman turning out to be a Black Tide creature in disguise and the mutation Aglaea had mentioned. Those were never mutations or anomalies.

They were humans being turned into Black Tide creatures.

Mydei moved toward the container, somehow keeping his cool. He gingerly placed a hand on one of them. A man— with half his body morphed into armor. A clatter from behind them made them whirl around and come face to face with a man in a lab coat.

Before the man could make a run for it, Mydei and Phainon sprinted towards him. Mydei restrained his hands as Phainon grabbed rope off the floor.

They hauled him into an empty room with a desk and a chair. The man struggled against the rope restraining his hands. Phainon looked to Mydei, who nodded as if to say '*go ahead— I'll make sure nothing goes wrong.*'

Phainon placed his right foot onto the table with a loud *thump,* looking down at the man. He lifted the rope over the man's mouth. "Speak."

"What— what do you want to know?" The man coughed, knowing that there was no way of escape.

Phainon laughed derisively. "What's going on. All of it."

"We are fulfilling our purpose"

"Purpose?"

"To save Okhema, of course!" This man wasn't lucid. His eyes were bloodshot and he looked way too out of it. "It's our sacred duty! The Black Tide monsters must persist for the sake of Amphoreus' safety."

"Safety? Do you mean to say that you turn people into these— these *monsters* for Amphoreus' *safety?"* Phainon tried to keep his voice level, stop it from breaking.

The man continued on his delirium induced tirade,"We must carry on the duty of the Black Tide. It may have ended fifteen years ago, but Amphoreus needs the Black Tide to survive." He paused, defiant now. "You are talking to the most important person on the field. I am the one who's been creating these, so show me more respect! "

Phainon droned out the part about respect, fixating on something else.

Fifteen years ago.

The Black Tide couldn't have reached Aedes Elysiae, but the creatures sure did.

Phainon's numbness was replaced by rage. Pure, unadulterated rage that seeped into every broken crevice of his heart—a rage he didn't even know he was capable of feeling. It burned him from the inside.

They killed his family.

They killed his *family.*

They killed his family.

The man bit back a scream after seeing Phainon's expression.

Phainon wanted to kill that man. That man and every other person who created these creatures. He wanted to make them feel the pain they had inflicted on others— no, feel it tenfold. They deserved so much worse than death.

He would die with them if that's what it took to make them suffer.

Phainon didn't need Dawnmaker to kill.

He grabbed a piece of rope and moved toward the man, each step deliberate.

"You will tell me who your leader is." He said, undoing the knots on the rope.

The man's breath came in staggered pants. "The Council of Elders."

"All of them?" Phainon asked, bringing the rope to the man's neck.

"The high ranking members!"

"The name of the person who thought of this idea is?" He tied the rope around the man's neck.

"Caenis! Caenis is! Please, let me go! Don't— don't kill me!" The man begged.

"Do you recognise what you've done? Do you regret it?"

The man dropped all pretenses of trying to earn Phainon's sympathy. Instead, he laughed, throwing his head back "Regret it? Why would I?"

Phainon pulled the rope.

The man's head lolled to the side.

Phainon had killed people before. To put people out of their misery Aedes Elysiae, to protect himself in Styxia— and recently, out of his own foolishness.

The shock that came after his actions was something he never got used to. Unmoving, he was rooted to the ground, like his mind was some place outside the confines of his body. No amount of oxygen felt enough, his throat constricting almost as painfully as his fist clenched around the rope. His vision blurred and steadied over and over again. Slowly, his surroundings became clear and with a horrible, final lurch of his stomach, he realised Mydei stood behind him.

Phainon didn't want to turn around and face Mydei.

"I-" Phainon croaked, the words sticking in his throat like gum.

A hand rested on his shoulder. No words were exchanged.

Phainon took a deep breath. The moment of confusion was replaced by a rage rekindled. The Council of Elders was behind this. *Caenis* was.

And he would be damned if he didn't end Caenis' life.

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Mydei saw his past self in Phainon. He recognised that rage that had finally honed in on its target— the dead eyed stare as all his mind was consumed by revenge. For Phainon to truly crack, the man must have said something that poured acid on old wounds.

How he wished he could take all of Phainon's pain away from him.

"We can't save the people sacrificed here." Mydei saw through Phainon's actions. He would want to save the people being turned into Black Tide monsters. "They are far too gone. Perhaps death would be kinder to them than salvation."

Phainon swallowed, knowing his actions would be futile. "… That man. He was out of it. Something wasn't right about him. If this is a base for creating

Black Tide creatures, then why is there only one person in here? "

It was then that Mydei recalled one of Eurypon's strategies that made it near impossible to track him down.

"A sacrificial lamb."

"What?"

"He was put up in this— frankly, obvious—place as a decoy. He was used to divert attention away from the Council. Nobody would have thought that we would resort to such measures to get the information out of him."

Phainon's lips parted in realisation. "Let's go back to the facility."He said in a tight voice.

"The facility?" Mydei repeated.

"Yes. I'll message everyone to gather at CHRYSOS for an emergency meeting. We need a plan— the Council of Elders' headquarters won't be easy to break into."

Mydei cast a sidelong glance at the man lying next to them. Phainon caught his gaze.

"Right. The dead body." said Phainon, impassive.

They made a perfectly inconspicuous duo, the two of them, lugging a dead body out to the secluded forest outside the building. As stupid as it may have sounded, there was no other person Mydei would rather help bury a body.

Phainon used scrap metal to dig out a grave and Mydei unceremoniously dumped the corpse into the shallow pit. Once covered with mud, that was where they left the man to rot, under the canopy of trees, the dried leaves being the only visitors of his grave.

Unplugging the supply of oxygen to the people suspended in varying states of transformation was yet another form of killing Mydei had not yet accustomed himself to. *It's like drifting off to sleep*, he reasoned to his child self—buried deep in his subconscious— who sobbed and begged him to *save them*.

The people Phainon had called over to CHRYSOS were dazed, disoriented and confused. Night missions were fairly common, but none expected a mission now that CHRYSOS was to shut down. Anaxa looked ready to snap at anyone who would dare approach him. Mydei suspected that Aglaea had been pulling all nighters, trying to salvage CHRYSOS , just like everyone else was. And yet, she somehow still looked immaculate and unruffled, her

hair pinned up in a neat bun. Aglaea possessed powers beyond Mydei's understanding.

"What's going on?" Hyacine asked Mydei as she walked up to the doors of the meeting room. Worry laced her voice."We got a text from Phainon, saying it was an emergency and we needed to get to CHRYSOS . He wouldn't elaborate or tell us anything else even after we tried texting and calling him."

"We discovered something about the Black Tide creatures. This is to form a plan of action. We can't just storm into the Council of Elders' headquarters."

"The Council of Elders?" Hyacine's face morphed from confusion to a gut sinking realisation. "They… They have something to do with this, don't they?"

Mydei nodded solemnly and tilted his head in the direction of the door.

Phainon got to the front of the meeting room. Clearing his throat, he slid his phone to Aglaea.

That was the closest expression to panic Mydei had ever seen on Aglaea. The doll like features of her face returned to neutrality after her brief lapse.

"The Council of Elders is artificially creating Black Tide monsters out of humans. I assume it's for control over Okhema and its people. The head of this operation is Caenis." Phainon paused, "Aglaea, please let me lead one last mission."

"We'll need to get this mission done tonight. I assume you've been caught on the security cameras in Okhema's border and action will be taken by morning." Aglaea set the phone down. "You have my permission"

"I knew they had something to do with this. Turning humans into Black Tide creatures— that's beyond vile." Professor Anaxa scoffed. "And could you save any of them?"

"They were far beyond saving." Mydei replied.

"… I see."

Castorice spoke up."Look, Phainon—"

Guilt crossed Phainon's face and he averted eyes from Castorice.

Somehow, Phainon had formulated a detailed plan to take down the Council's headquarters from the inside out over the time it took for them to get from the border to the emergency meeting. Phainon never struck Mydei as a scheming person— more overexcited big white dog than a schemer.

But the man who stood before him was not Phainon— his one and only friend and rival— rather, he was the Deliverer. The ray of light, Okhema's hope— the Deliverer in every shape and form.

Just like that day at the meeting, Phainon was the only person in the room that mattered. The one everyone looked to. It was almost familiar, the reliance people had on Phainon, but so different because of all that had transpired. Nothing would be the same again, but the dependence on Phainon would never cease.

Mydei offered to help oversee the preparation of weapons. Following Castorice down the hall, matching his strides to hers, he asked, "No luck?"

"None." Castorice sighed. "I tried talking to him, but he just turned the other way and kept talking about the plan. I think he hates me now."

"Phainon would never hate you."

"Phainon has so many other people to fall back on— I don't think my presence matters much. I have probably overstayed my welcome" Castorice's voice wavered," Was it stupid of me to think I had a best friend even if he never thought so?"

"That's untrue and you know it. You and Hyacine are the only ones he actually sees as best friends."

Castorice searched his face for any signs of a lie. Mydei only said what he truly knew: Phainon was closest to his true overexcitable, bright self when he was around them.

If anything, Phainon was probably too scared to face his closest friends again.

"But he has fans. Yes, the public isn't entirely in his favour, but I found all those supportive messages too. He will forever be adored."

"From a pedestal, that is. They love the Deliverer. They do not care for Phainon.'

Castorice went silent for a few seconds, before chuckling ruefully "You give solid advice. Thank you."

By then, Castorice had already reached her lab. She disappeared into the lab, hurriedly opening cardboard boxes of her beloved poisons and unpacking those she needed.

Mydei continued down the hall, stepping out into the darkness. This night was still, the gentle breeze abated.

He dialed up a number he hadn't sought to contact in a long, long time.

Krateros' voice came from the other end."Hello?"

"I'm going to need your assistance."

"Mydeimos, what is it that you need?"

"Just Mydei."

Mydeimos was what his father named him. Any traces of what his father left, he burnt. His name, his legacy, his sparse memories— gone. Mydei tried to use up all the wealth his father had accumulated for the betterment of his Kremnoans, but he still ended up with a large sum of it. *One day,* he had reasoned with himself, *one day,* he would open a library in his mother's name. That day felt like a distant star, one whose light could be obscured with your hand.

"Right, my prince."

That was a nickname they called him back at the Kremnoan Detachment. Mydei was never a prince. He was the son of a vile man.

"I'll need you to send reinforcements right now. We're taking down the Council of Elders tonight. You will stand outside and make sure nobody else can enter. We need to get to the 40th floor. Ensure nobody reaches there."

To Krateros' credit, he didn't question Mydei. Or maybe he just yearned for the feel of battle, one last time.

"Yes, that will be done."

The arrangements at the institute were made in record time. Mydei had never had to be called in for an emergency in his time there, but CHRYSOS must have always functioned with such efficiency for the years it was active. CHRYSOS was a well oiled machine that had served Okhema well.

Phainon was nowhere to be seen after the briefing.

Phainon and Mydei would sneak into the building ahead of everyone. If needed, they would knock out guards in night patrol. Caenis was well known to have the biggest office on the 40th floor. They would search for evidence of her crimes and report it. The others would incapacitate the guards and find the other people responsible.

Phainon never mentioned what they would do if Caenis happened to be working overnight.

He only reappeared as he and Mydei were to leave for the first stage, the hilt of Dawnmaker clutched in his hand like a vice. His face was pale and strained, but his steps felt powerful.

Phainon was jumpy as they reached the headquarters— like he was waiting for someone to leap out of the darkness and recognise him. Sneaking past and knocking out the guards at the entrance was the easiest thing they'd done all night. The inside of the building smelled like a hospital— it felt cold and uninhabitable.

"Wait." Mydei hissed, grabbing Phainon's hand as he tried to call the elevator. "What do you think you're doing? What if there's someone already in there and what if someone gets in?"

Phainon blinked.

"Right. That."

I any other situation, Phainon would have argued back. Mydei wanted him to argue back. He wanted the old Phainon— *his* Phainon— back. There was a weight tot he silence as they walked up the flights of stairs.

Upon reaching the door of Caenis' office, Phainon held up Dawnmaker as he slowly pushed the door open.

Nobody was there.

Mydei heaved a sigh of relief. This made things a lot easier.

Caenis' office was much the same. Sterile. Each corner was meticulously scrubbed clean. *Dust would probably have to pay exorbitant amounts of rent to live in here—* was probably what Phainon would say.

"I'll check the desk." Phainon crouched, skimming through the documents in the drawer. He straightened himself, holding up a document. "This is a ledger of expenses."

Mydei heard a faint click in the distance. He whipped his head around to see a glint of metal illuminated by the dim moonlight. It was pointed right at Phainon.

A loud *bang* echoed.

Mydei put himself between Phainon and the gun.

As the bullet ripped through his abdomen, Mydei bit his tongue to sustain the excruciating pain as his organs ruptured. He fell to his knees, gasping heavily and clutching his abdomen. This would be slow death. Bowing his head, he took out a dagger and aimed it at his heart— yanking it out of the hands that tried to pull it away from him. He needed to die quickly.

Plunging the knife into his heart and twisting it, Mydei didn't shed a single tear.

He could hear a thud at the door. The person aiming the gun must've been taken down.

Good. At least Phainon would be safe, he thought to himself as he died.

The cold, wet darkness that welcomed him was not an unfamiliar sight.

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Phainon felt like he was the one dying instead of Mydei.

When he lost his home, he had screamed until his throat felt like it was bleeding and then let out horrible, broken sobs.

When he lost his Mydei, he couldn't even react. He sank to the floor and cradled Mydei's dead body like any amount of wishing it was him instead would solve anything. Mydei's face was scrunched in pain, his skin turning ashy. His red tattoos lost their vibrancy.

Through dry, gasping breaths, Phainon repeated Mydei's name over and over again."Mydei, Mydei, *Mydei, Mydei, Mydei. Wake up.* Don't leave me. Please, wake up. Who's going to go to the gym with me? Who's going to cook me subpar food when I make you mad? Who's going to nag me about my laundry? Who's going to compete with me over the smallest of missions and tests? Who's going to make me feel whole again?" In a quieter voice, he added, "How am I supposed to live after the one person I go and fall in love with dies?"

His shoulders shook as he placed his head on Mydei's chest, desperately willing for him to not leave Phainon too.

If Mydei was still alive, Phainon would tell him just how much he meant to him. Was Phainon too standoffish? Was he too much? Too little? Did he do something wrong?

If only he could get another chance, he would make it all right. He would be the best friend Mydei could ever ask for. He would be whatever Mydei wanted him to be if only he would just *wake up.*

"Wake up, Mydei" He whispered.

Silence. How can a dead man even respond?

And then, a weak thudding of Mydei's heart.

Phainon's breath caught in his throat, hope surging in his chest.

"Hope you didn't miss me too much." Mydei croaked, coughing and wiping the blood off his hands.

If Phainon had more guts, he would have kissed Mydei on the spot.

"You— You're alive" Phainon breathed, still unable to believe it.

"Of course I am." It was then that Phainon remembered that he was holding Mydei. Before Phainon could mess this up and say something stupid, Mydei got up like he hadn't just died. The skin and muscle around the wounds patched themselves up.

Phainon's legs felt weak.

"Did you find it?" Mydei asked

"Find what?" A cold, cutting voice came from the entrance.

Caenis.

All Phainon could think of was the hundreds of ways he would make her *pay.*

"Caenis." Phainon spat out.

"Looks like you didn't die or rot away alone. Shame."

"It's a shame *you* aren't dead yet."

"What's this? The precious, perfect Phainon, acting vile now that his reputation and glory is gone?" Caenis mocked.

"I'll make you regret you ever said those words, you criminal."

"I have my guards ready to kill you. You cannot reach me"

"What if I told you your guards are dead or knocked out by now?" Mydei asked, stepping forward. "My people have already taken care of them."

Caenis faltered for the first time. Mydei shut the door behind her.

"Your brutes?" She couldn't hide the unease in her voice. "Savages like you don't deserve to enter this city."

That was what prompted Phainon to hold his greatsword to her neck. Nobody was allowed to talk about Mydei like that. *Nobody.*

"Explain." said Phainon.

"You have no proof."

"I never asked for proof of something. That must mean that you are indeed guilty." Phainon flashed a threatening smile. "Now tell me, why did you create Black Tide creatures long after the Black Tide ceased?"

"As if I'd tell—"

Phainon brought Dawnmaker closer to her neck, the blade a hair's width away from her skin.

"I said, why did you sacrifice innocent souls? Nobody deserves to have their lives taken away from them so cruelly." He could barely contain his rage— it laced every fiber of his being, fueled his words and actions. It was the only thing keeping him from breaking down.

Caenis placed her hand on the sword, trying to push it away from herself. "Cruel? Hardly. No sacrifice is big enough if it's for Okhema's sanctity. We must protect Okhema from the outside world."

She was unbelievable.

"So you thought killing nearly every other civilisation outside Okhema would protect its people? You *destroyed* millions of people's lives, *for. some. stupid. project*?" Phainon emphasised each word with a jab of Dawnmaker. " You are an unforgivable psychopath. Do you hear me? You are revolting, horrifying sociopath who deserves pain much worse than what you did unto others."

Caenis scoffed "Bold words coming from a pathetic excuse for a saviour."

"There is nothing you could call me that I haven't already called myself. So go on, take your shot. See if it sticks."

"A bit insane, aren't you?"

"Nobody can survive Styxia by being a normal person."

Caenis tried to back away, plotting her escape, but Mydei blocked her.

"Eyes on me, Elder." Phainon demanded. "How did you know about my past? Do you know the name of my village because you destroyed it?" Venom leaked into his words.

"Aedes Elysiae, was it? Hm, yes. One of our first. My Cleaners had to test the effectiveness of the newly modified creatures." Caenis spoke with a practised ease, like this was something she'd done a hundred times over. "Poor thing, you should've died with them. That would be one less thorn on my side."

Phainon wanted nothing more than to plunge the sword into her neck and slice it clean, but he held himself back; he need to get more information out of her.

"Who are these people you've been using?" Mydei questioned— no, ordered—, his eyes narrowed like a lion's before it struck. Even someone as brazen as Caenis cowered before him. Phainon had gotten so accustomed to Mydei that he forgot Mydei was raised to be a leader in his own right. Someone who commanded respect and compliance of the highest order.

"Cleaners. The ones who seek our counsel or shelter from us. They have a debt to repay us. There's no such thing as free kindness."

If Phainon thought Caenis couldn't get any worse, he was sorely mistaken.

"You take advantage of them is what you're saying. Yes?" Mydei said, disdain evident in his voice.

"Like I said, it's for—"

"Spare me the theatrics. "

Mydei looked ready to kill.

The doors flew open. Aglaea walked in, signaling to Phainon and Mydei to bring Caenis to the desk. Following her was a Goldweaver, an assistant she created. "You've done enough, I'll take care of this."

"No. Let me see this through. I *need* to see this through." Phainon passed his beloved Dawnmaker to the only person he would trust with it. Mydei kept the greatsword pointed at Caenis as Phainon questioned the seated coward. The Garmentmaker hovered behind him.

"You set a woman who was a Black Tide creature in disguise out to the forest to get me to bring her in and wreak havoc on the city. You take people that owe you something and give them a life worse than death. You create Black Tide creatures to kill civilisations. Your misconstrued ideals of Okhema have trapped its residents in perpetual fear within those huge walls. This is something you do on purpose. You want control over all of Okhema." Phainon's hands yearned to take her life, but he still had to finish this."Do you confess to your crimes, Caenis?"

Pride never leaving her, Caenis responded, "Yes."

"Very good." Phainon pointed outside, at Okhema's huge screens. One by one, they began to play the video of Caenis' confession. Caenis' face paled. The city woke up as a result of the broadcast, lights flickering on in apartments. Now, they knew. Everyone knew.

Garmentmaker stopped recording.

"Caenis, your subordinates will be taken in for questioning. The Council of Elders will be shut for good." Aglaea said, "You will be very sorry for attempting to take CHRYSOS down."

Before she left, Aglaea turned back to Caenis, "And don't think I forgot about the time you tried to have me killed."

"You knew." Caenis stated plainly.

"Of course." That was the first and only time Phainon saw Aglaea smile with her teeth. She looked beyond unsettling.

"Will you be fine doing this by yourself?" Mydei asked. He must have understood Phainon's motive. He handed Dawnmaker back to Phainon's hand. The handle was was comfortingly warm.

"Of course."

Mydei shot a contemptuous glare at Caenis, before turning back to Phainon "Don't you dare get yourself hurt."

"You know I won't." Phainon tried to smile reassuringly.

Mydei left the room too. Silence was the only thing left in the room besides Phainon and Caenis.

"You exposed us, doomed Okhema and you still didn't get your precious family back." Caenis taunted. "Are you satisfied now?"

Phainon finally snapped.

He burst into a fit of laughter, his broken laughs echoing off the walls of the room. Caenis looked bewildered.

"SATISFIED?" He asked between his laughs, "*SATISFIED?* You ask me if I'm satisfied?"

"What is wrong with you?" Caenis' voice wavered.

"No, nothing. I just think it's so funny how you don't understand the gravity of what you did. Allow me to detail exactly what. YOU TOOK THEM AWAY FROM ME!" Phainon's voice cracked, his bitter laugh unceasing, "You killed my *family*. Cyrene smiled through her dying moments because I was *scared.* She was a child too; she was scared too and she should have let herself be scared if not for me. You made her suffer. You robbed her of her dreams. DO YOU HEAR ME? SHE WANTED TO BE A FORTUNE TELLER! YOU. TOOK. THAT. AWAY. FROM .HER."

Phainon bent over, clutching his sides as he laughed some more.

"I'll kill you, Caenis. I'LL KILL YOU!" He looked up, fingers digging into his side. "Your guard killed Mydei. Your guard *killed him. How. Dare. You. Kill. Mydei*."

"And yet he still stands. How strange."

"And yet *you* still made him feel unbearable pain." Phainon knew he looked insane, his eyes bulging and a half smile, half snarl on his face. "Do you not feel remorse? Is it such a foreign concept to you?"

"Human empathy is secondary to Okhema's sanctity."

"From a threat *your* delusions created for you. Prepare to *die*, Caenis."

"What will they think of their precious Deliverer murdering someone?"

His maniacal laughs subsided. Phainon scoffed."They see me as one already."

"Your reputation is quite dear to you. I hope it destroyed you when they hated you, *Deliverer."*

"Shut *up*. I have killed enough to accept it as a part of me. The murderer who stands in front of you now to end your life is one you created."

"Monster." She hissed.

If Phainon had the emotional bandwidth to cry, he would. He never wanted any of this. He wanted to live a normal life and be a good person. Not this fucked up monster.

"You are far, *far* worse than I will ever be." Phainon's voice was a whisper, a mere fragment of his previous yells.

Phainon had decided on the way he would end Caenis' life by now.

At the very least, Caenis had the decency to look afraid of death. As powerful as a human may claim to be, they would always cower in the face of death.

He sliced her throat cleanly. She fell silent, her erratic breathing turning to none.

It was strange, really, how all it took for her to die was to slice her neck. Phainon didn't know what he expected to feel after doing that. Happy? Complete? He didn't know anymore. Revenge didn't feel like anything. It just felt bitter. His life didn't miraculously brighten up and the scars he bore couldn't be peeled off.

Just like how the world didn't stop turning and the sun kept rising after his own life reached a stagnation after everyone was gone, revenge didn't make anything change.

The only person he wanted to see stood outside the door. Implicitly, he knew that Mydei would be waiting outside the door for him— ready to jump in if anything went wrong. He flung open the doors of the office.

"Let's go outside." Phainon said, not caring that there were blood splatters all over him. His reputation couldn't get much worse than this.

Mydei led the way to the elevator.

Phainon watched the floor number decrease for a while. "How were are you still alive?"

"HKS, did you prefer me dead?"

"What? No, Mydei, no—"

Phainon scrambled out of the elevator, trailing after Mydei. The lobby was dead silent; the rest of CHRYSOS probably doing damage control elsewhere.

Mydei turned around."That was a joke."

"Oh."

"I'm immortal. That's why I revived."

"*What*. How is that even a thing?"

"It's something I've been born with. I consider it a good thing." Mydei stepped out into the back exit. Screens played the recording of Caenis' confession on loop. Phainon could hear the faint hum of crowds.

"So why didn't you tell me about it?"

"… It may have slipped my mind, given that I didn't die for a year."

"A *year* is enough time to *forget* that you can't be *killed*?" Phainon asked, incredulous.

"Oh, please. It's plenty of time"

"Is your own life really that insignificant to you? How many times must you have died to stop keeping count? How many lives of yours have been lost just like that?"

"Several." Mydei exhaled. "But you don't have to think of it as a big deal."

"*A big deal?* Do you hear yourself? I thought I *lost* you, Mydei. *I THOUGHT I LOST YOU!*" Phainon shook Mydei's shoulders. He knew how he looked right then— desperate and afraid.

Mydei blinked, taken aback by Phainon's outburst.

"I was so scared when I saw you take that bullet for me. You— I can't stand losing anyone ever again. Cyrene, Ma, Pa, my old friends and neighbours, I don't want you to join them. Never join them, Mydei. Please."

"I won't." Mydei placed his hands over Phainon's. That gesture to comfort Phainon was the sweetest thing Mydei could have done.

"Huh?"

"I won't leave you alone.You will have my promise and that's that. "

Phainon knew it was pointless to argue. Nodding mutely, he retracted his hands from Mydei's shoulders as a wave of embarrassment hit him. He pretended to look into the distance. The moon was a quarter moon— waxing or waning, he couldn't tell. He really should have listened properly to Cyrene's explanations about the phases of the moon. He should have committed every word she said and every moment she spent with him to his memory.

Mydei broke the silence. "If you don't mind me asking— is Cyrene your sister?"

"Yes." Phainon said. "Cyrene had pink hair and blue eyes and—"

Phainon paused.

"What happened?"

"— I don't remember."

Phainon was in mute shock, cold dread wrapping its fingers around his throat and slowly strangling him.

He didn't remember what Cyrene looked or sounded like anymore.

Or his Ma and Pa, or the villagers of Aedes Elysiae. Or even Aedes Elysiae itself.

Phainon was now alive for longer than he had known them and that destroyed him.

He was holding on to wisps of his memories, time eroding the faces of the ones he loved. Living off of delusion, thinking he remembered everyone and everything, was the only thing keeping him going. It kept him alive in Styxia. It kept him fighting for Okhema. Everyone he loved was preserved perfectly in glass within his memories and his memories alone— at least, that what he thought.

All he had now was the idea of them.

And all they were now was a festering wound that he had learned to live with.

It was Mydei's words that brought him out of his spiral. "I don't remember what my mother looked like or sounded like either. All I recall are the memories of her and the things she told me. People remain stuck in the past once they die and it's only their fading memory that you can carry forward. That's thing about loss— loss isn't just the person, it's your memories of them too."

"To me, losing their memories feels like moving on." Phainon's voice was strained as he said his next words." I don't want to move on from them. I can't move on from them; not after how they were taken from me and how bad things got once they were gone."

He instantly regretting spilling his guts out to Mydei. It felt so wrong to have someone else be privy to your innermost thoughts.

"You don't have to move on. You could try to accept that they're gone and you're alive right now. You're not in the wrong for wanting a good future for yourself."

Phainon didn't know that was an option. He swallowed the lump in his throat.

"So what now?" He asked, "CHRYSOS will never have to function as a facility and the people have no need for a disgraced saviour."

"You could live your own life. Do whatever you want to do. I'm sure you once had dreams beyond sacrificing every part of yourself to the public."

Phainon couldn't remember what he had wanted for himself.

"Your mother" Phainon said, trying to change the topic."What did she tell you, Mydei?"

Mydei looked up at the stars. "To not let rage be the only thing that drives me forward."

"She.. sounds like a knowledgeable woman."

Mydei wore a soft, nostalgic smile— a rare sight. "Indeed. she was the most remarkable person I have ever known."

From the way Mydei spoke of her, he clearly loved her. Whoever his mother was, she would be so proud of the boy she raised. Phainon was sure of it.

"Castorice and Hyacine want to talk to you, Phainon."

"And if they hate me now? "

"They don't. Talk to them. They care for you— they even made that collection of supportive comments for you. If that doesn't mean that you are valued, then I don't know what does."

"Okay, okay. I can do this. I can do—"

"—don't tell me you have cold feet now, HKS."

Phainon scoffed, lying through his teeth. "Absolutely not. I'm going now and I will resolve this. You'll see, Mydei." He stalked off.

Phainon walked through the pitch black hall of of unconscious guards— his phones' flashlight being the only thing he could use to brave his way through. He had asked the Kremnoan reinforcements Mydei called called in about the whereabouts of either a purple haired girl or a pink haired medic. They said the pink haired medic was with a quote "unhinged teal guy with an eye patch" on the fifth floor.

Good enough.

He shone the flashlight at a flurry of movement to his left and shrieked when it landed on someone's face. Professor Anaxa was decidedly very unimpressed at having a bright light shone into his eye.

"Hyacine's finishing up gathering the documents down the hall." Anaxa grumbled "Go and get that light out of my eye unless you want to blind me."

"Sorry, Prof A." Phainon said his apologies and hightailed it out of there before Anaxa decided to turn him into his next research subject out of spite.

"Hyacine?" Phainon said to the darkness. Damn the power in this building. They could've waited a bit longer to shut off the power.

He let out another high pitched shriek when someone tapped his shoulder, nearly dropping his phone.

"Sorry, I thought you were Professor Anaxa here to chew me out—" He explained sheepishly before all words failed him as he came face to face with Hyacine. All the excuses he had concocted seemed wrong.

"We need to talk. Now." said Hyacine

Phainon nodded mutely. It occurred to him that the blood was still on him. As if he needed yet another reason for Hyacine to hate him.

"Did you find him?" Castorice walked out of a door, carrying a torch. Her expression steeled when she saw Phainon. She looked to Hyacine, who nodded.

Hyacine too a deep breath."Phainon. You keep everyone at arm's length. You're there for us whenever we text you, but we know nothing and I mean nothing about you. When you got into that fight and had to move out of your dorm room, did you tell us a thing? Did you tell us when you were struggling or when you were grieving or sad? Did you let us help? "

Phainon hung his head. "I'm sorry. You guys mean a lot to me and I just didn't want to burden you with my problems. "

"You are not a burden. You need to learn how to trust other people."

As if anything's ever that simple. He can't just go and undo the distrustfulness that kept him alive and sane all these years. It would be like ripping away a part of himself.

"Or at least, try to believe that we care about you. Can you do that much?"

"First, ouch, I'm not a child. And second— fine. I will." Phainon knew he looked pathetic, asking them this, "Do you hate me now?"

Castorice shook her head. "Hate you? Phainon, we don't hate you and never will. Just tell us if something's wrong. Nothing you say would make us see you any differently."

"So is this you guys forgiving me?" Phainon asked.

"Yes." Hyacine confirmed.

Phainon sighed in relief and held his arms open. Castorice and Hyacine hugged him without protest.

"Thank you for dealing with me for all these years "

"Don't mention it." Castorice smiled. "Glad to have you back."

Normalcy was something Phainon had never known, but this was the closest he felt to it.

Chapter End Notes

> We're finally down to one more chapter!!! Writing this has been a journey, I'll tell you that. I started this months ago(like in July) and it's only now that I'm nearly done with it.

Chapter 5: You're the one way out and I'm your dark horse clown

Chapter Notes

> It's finally time for the final chapter!!!
>
> Looking back on it, I cannot believe I actually had it in me to write this much because I keep looking at the word count and going girl what have you done how did you do this??

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Two weeks later

The outrage that followed the revelation was massive. CHRYSOS made a public statement that Caenis was dead, but made no further comments on why. Aglaea had mentioned plans of CHRYSOS becoming a proper academy.

Now that the Black Tide creatures were gone for good, Phainon didn't really know what to do with himself. Before, it was all about the recognition he earned, the admiration he got. But admiration was fleeting and recognition didn't have the glow it used to. Image and kindness be damned— he found it hard to pretend like he cared much for the people who spewed venom about him trying to make it up to him.

To ignore the black void of his overcomplicated feelings, he spent every spare moment with Mydei. He didn't care if he was bothering him, but as far he could tell, Mydei didn't seem to mind too much. Castorice and Hyacine got increasingly busy with helping CHRYSOS get back to normal.

Only Phainon was given time off— despite his protests. He missed Mydei terribly when he was gone and meandered about the apartment, waiting for Mydei to get back.

His dorm room was fully renovated by then, but neither of them addressed that fact and life continued as it always did—by the parameters of whatever 'normal' was, anyway.

Professor Anaxa cleared his throat.

Phainon blinked, startled. "One second, Prof— I have a new message—"

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>8:00AM
to me▼

The one and only HKS I am seconds away from steam frying, grilling and broiling all in that order,

Get your pathetic ass over to the gym right this very moment or else.

Much love and concern (not),

Mydei

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>8:03AM
to Mydei▼

The light to my soul, mind and heart Mydei,

How I would love to sustain your temper tantrums, but how unfortunate it is that I am in a meeting with Professor Anaxa. I would rather get chewed out by you than him.

I don't think I would make a very appetising dish, though. But with your cooking skills, I might just be one!

Love, Phainon

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>8:03AM
to me▼

The Deliverer of my heart and biggest pain in my ass,

First, no , you would be a very unpleasant dish. I regret bringing up that topic of conversation.

Second, Consider this revenge for that one time then. Hope you have your notifications switched on like you always do.

Emails from Mydei flooded his inbox.

Touche, Mydei. Touche.

"Tell your boyfriend to stop messaging you repeatedly, Phainon." Professor Anaxa had given up on their antics by now.

Phainon nearly fell off his chair. "He's not my—"

"None of my business. "

"Sorry."

Professor Anaxa cleared his throat "Aglaea has been incredibly busy these past few days, so I have been given the unfortunate task of carrying out some of her duties. She would like to know how you've been holding up recently."

"Fine."

Anaxa closed his laptop and looked Phainon dead in the eye. "Phainon, you have had unimaginably traumatic events take place recently. Saying you're fine only makes it sound like you're not fine."

"I—"

Anaxa raised an eyebrow, daring Phainon to protest. Once Phainon fell into silence, he continued, "We've sent out agents to neutralise the remaining Black Tide creatures, so the regions outside Okhema are no longer dangerous. Aglaea is sponsoring a trip for you. You are free to go wherever you please."

"Really?" Phainon perked up.

"Yes. She encourages you to go somewhere outside Okhema to recuperate."

Phainon hated being addressed as something fragile and in need of protection. He had fended for himself perfectly fine. He knew how to fight back, heal his own wounds and sustain pain. He didn't need someone to protect him.

Mydei by his side wouldn't be too bad, though.

Phainon swallowed his pride. "Thank you."

"You did good." Anaxa said, albeit incredibly awkwardly.

"*Did you just praise me?*"

"No."

"I heard it— you praised me!"

"*Out.*"

Phainon practically skipped out of Prof. A's office.

He was going to see Mydei again— which was stupid, because he had hung out with Mydei the night before.

"Mydei!" Phainon couldn't run towards Mydei fast enough. "Pack your bags, we're going to Aedes Elysiae!"

"Huh?"

"I got paid vacation time!"

"So you think that I'm not busy? Go bother Castorice or Hyacine."

Phainon rolled his eyes. "Oh come on, you're not *that* busy. Plus, Cas and Cinny are really busy. Please?"

"No."

"Please?"

"No."

"How many more times must I say please before you agree?"

"Go on, then. Try convincing me."

Phainon took a deep breath "Pleasepleasepleaseplease—"

"—pleasepleaseplease—" His voice grew louder.

Mydei winced, clenching his fist.

"—pleasepleaseplease—"

People around them craned their heads, trying to get a better look at the scene.

Upon noticing the scrutiny they were under, Mydei held a hand up, signaling him to stop; probably trying to stop the embarrassment. "When

are we leaving?"

Phainon grinned.

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"When you said we were going to Aedes Elysiae, I didn't think it would be on the same day"

Phainon paid no heed to him, instead admiring the view as the train rattled past countrysides. Greens blurred with the soft pastel blue of the sky, the multicoloured settlements whizzing by. Life was strange in its resilience, towns holding up through the advent and the retreat of the Black Tide. Phainon was tense; Mydei could sense it in his gait and cloudy eyes. He steadied the obnoxiously large backpack he'd packed; it threatened to topple over with every lurch of the train.

Phainon leaped up as soon as the train screeched to a halt. "This is an outpost near Aedes Elysiae. We'll have to travel on foot from here."

Mydei had to strain his ears to hear what Phainon was saying over the chaos of the train.

The air felt different here. Crisp.

Black marks eroded patches of soil, but there was a peace Mydei had yet to see anywhere else. Life in Okhema ran by too fast and the places his detachment visited were either abandoned or infested with creatures. Life felt strange now that yet another one of his goals was gone. First it was to kill his father, then it as to settle his people into Okhema. Now, the Black Tide too.

Phainon got off the train first, starting the walk. Mydei walked behind him, taking in the scenery. Fields stretched endlessly into the horizon. The sun was high up in. Mydei himself had no idea where they were headed to, but Phainon seemed to know, effortlessly navigating through the wheat fields.

"I brought a tent so we could have a place to sleep if the village has fallen into disrepair. Plus some supplies if there aren't any places nearby for us to get food." Phainon explained, holding out a hand to skim the wheat that rose to their knees.

"I brought supplies too. No tents, though." Mydei said. The poles of his tent made a slight tinkling sound as they clinked against each other in his backpack.

Phainon inspected the wheat. "Someone cultivates these."

Mydei looked around, trying to find some form of settlement beyond the fields bathed in gold.

Phainon was bathed in a golden halo too. His white hair looked iridescent as it swayed with the breeze and caught the sunlight. His eyes a shade of sapphire blue that even the sky would be jealous of. In the midst of the endless acres of gold, Phainon fit right in. Like he was born to be made of light . *Phaenon*, the brightest star in the sky.

Phaenon, of endless light.

"Mydei!" Phainon jabbed Mydei's side.

"Son of a— what was that for?"Mydei frowned heavily.

"You didn't listen to me the first few times I called your name."

"So you thought that jabbing my side was the best way to catch my attention?"

"I just wanted to see your reaction." Phainon said blithely

"Hmph. Foolhardy pest."

"Speaking of pests, there are a bunch of aphids and armyworms around here. Hope you don't hate bugs."

"The only bug I hate is you."

"You wound me, my darling Mydei. And here I thought you loved me"

That Mydei did.

"Found it!" Phainon exclaimed. Realisation washed over his face as he squinted to get a better look. "Let's uh, go somewhere else."

"Why?"

"No reason." Phainon croaked.

"Are you trying to avoid that house? Or perhaps the person who lives in that house?"

Phainon's expression was pained, a cross between reluctance and frustration. "Damn you." He muttered.

"But seriously though, why do you care so much about this particular house?"

"I don't. I don't care." Phainon protested.

"Oh yeah? Then why do I have to physically haul you there?" Mydei tugged on the strap of Phainon's backpack to continue their slow procession to the small house.

"Look me dead in the eye and try to figure out how many fucks I give about this place." Without giving Mydei a chance to respond, Phainon replied, "Zero. That's right. Zero."

It was when Mydei's hand hovered over the doorbell that Phainon cracked.

"No, Mydei. Please, reconsider. We can uh— go there! Look! Wheat! I wanna go there—"

"HKS, what is up with you?"

Phainon would have made a run for it when the door of the house creaked open if it wasn't for Mydei's firm grip on his backpack.

A middle aged lady stood at the door, squinting to see the visitors. Her eyes widened in shock upon noticing Phainon. Her circular glasses dropped from the bridge of her nose as she stared at Phainon like she was seeing a ghost.

"Child, is that you?"

"I—" Phainon looked helplessly at Mydei, pleading him to save him. "Yes."

"You're alive." The woman's owlish face broke into a warm smile. "I always knew you would be."

"Why don't you two come in?"

"Oh, no—We wouldn't want to intrude—"

"Nonsense. There's hardly anyone nearby. I'm elated to have guests."

Her house was small. A single dining table sat in the center, with seats for two. Pictures and memorabilia lined the walls. A small room with a bed was connected to the main hall. The house smelled like sandalwood and incense.

Phainon trailed after her, offering to help her serve tea and snacks. When Mydei offered to do the same, he was met with fierce resistance so he sat on a pile of baskets at the dining table. Phainon eventually joined him— Mydei suspected that he was turned away from the kitchen too.

Phainon shifted guiltily, his long limbs jutting out of place in the small seat. He looked like he would rather be anywhere than here. He threw nervous glances at the old lady, like he was waiting for all hell to break loose again.

"But I thought they closed all rail lines from Okhema?" She asked, emerging from the kitchen with a cracked porcelain tray.

"They reopened them last night. Everyone's trying to visit their old homes or graves of their loved ones." Mydei explained.

The old woman placed a cup of tea in front of Mydei."So Okhema's finally open to the outside world, huh?"

"Yes. The creatures are gone.""

The woman sighed , like a heavy burden was finally off her shoulders.

"You're not going to ask any more questions?"

"And what good will the answers to those questions be to me? You, on the other hand, look like you have a plethora of them."

"Say, how did you survive out here?" Mydei asked ,"From Styxia to parts of Kremnos, The Black Tide creatures were everywhere."

"They receded in the outskirts of Okhema a long time ago. Probably thought they killed every person out there." She chuckled wryly. "A few of us were at the farmers' market a few towns over when the creatures struck Aedes Elysiae. We were told that we couldn't return since Aedes Elysiae had fallen. I couldn't accept my family's death, so I made the journey back. "

"I'm sorry."

"Don't be. Someone had dug graves for the deceased— it's off in the outcropping. At the very least, they were honoured in their deaths."

Phainon looked as though he might shatter like fine china.

The words came tumbling out, like Phainon was reliving them all over again.

I'm sorry I couldn't save your daughter." Phainon hung his head. Mydei knew he would never understand how deep the regret must have embedded itself into Phainon. He would never understand most of what made Phainon — the persistence, the sense of justice, the unhinged rage.

"You were a child. Be kinder to yourself, Phainon." She said gently.

"But, even then—"

"No. You have nothing to be sorry about."

Mydei watched Phainon's fingers whiten as they curled into fists.

"Be honest. Years ago, would you have blamed me for not saving your daughter had you found out I got out as the only one unscathed?"

Without missing a beat, she nodded. "Yes. I would have. I would have wondered why she didn't survive in your place."

Somehow, Phainon seemed to find comfort in that. Words that should have stung like daggers were what he willingly embraced. He smiled, light and free. Was he… comfortable around scathing words? No, not comfortable, but used to it. Like this was where he was supposed to be and nothing more.

"But time is a funny thing, isn't it?" She said. "Now, I can't imagine why I could hate the sweetest kid I've ever known. I hope my words didn't offend you."

Phainon waved his hand dismissively. "No offense taken!"

Mydei may never understand Phainon, but he would forever think of him as the strongest person he's ever met. After all, it takes a strong person to be so gentle after all this pain.

Phainon sprung up, muttering something vague.

"It feels like just yesterday when he was a little boy who couldn't wait to save the world because of a prophecy his older sister gave him. A little prediction. Most people would have thought of it as a momentary fascination, but this one thought differently. He'd go out of his way to help us with mundane jobs, keep the younger ones entertained and run around playing hero. Those actions— they weren't childish, they were honest. He wanted to save the world." The woman said, once Phainon had disappeared out of sight.

"That he did. He was— and still is— a hero to Okhema."

Her face softened into a small smile. "So he did it after all."

"Yes." Mydei found himself missing Phainon's presence next to him.

"He's a good man, Mydei. Treat him well."

Mydei choked on air.

"We aren't— like *that"*

"It didn't look that way to me."

When Phainon returned, his eyes looked more red rimmed than usual. His annoyingly perfect smile was perfectly intact.

The house reverberated with Phainon's excited chatter— something about Okhema and reminiscing the past— Mydei was too busy admiring Phainon to pay proper attention. The sun was back, bright and cheerful as ever. Unbothered and glorious, he laughed. Like nothing had ever hurt him before.

He will never mention that he found Phainon holding Dawnmaker to his forehead the night after he killed Caenis, begging for mercy or for salvation, he would never know.

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Nostalgia was a bittersweet thing, it creeped up into your heart and tugged at it like a vine. Nostalgia was the rustling of the wheat fields, the chirping

of the cicadas in the summer, the lemon drops a kind old lady gave the kids as they traipsed into her house to rest after playing.

Relief was a tide.

It would never wash away the jagged lines of hurt, but it would at least make them feel less painful.

Auntie Adara, that was her name, managed the sprawling wheat fields. She had the same brown eyes that crinkled at the corners and the blunt honesty Phainon remembered. He had offered to help her with her wheat fields, even if it was for a week or two. She called him dutiful and kind; he called himself selfish for wanting to relive his past.

Mydei and Phainon set up camp outside her small house. Phainon's tent should have been enough accommodate two normal people, but things got a bit dicey with two tall men who'd been trained to fight their entire lives.

The next morning was a much needed reprieve from the excruciating

"Come on!" Phainon yelled to Mydei, who loitered around the outskirts of the wheat fields. Phainon held a scythe in one hand, another hand holding down his straw hat, keeping it from flying away with the billowing winds.

"Yes, yes, on my way." Mydei trudged to Phainon, stalking through the wheat.

"Auntie Adara told us to harvest that patch of land first." Phainon leaned toward Mydei, pointing it out. Mydei stiffened, but didn't pull away. "Think you can handle that, princey?"

"Never call me that."

"I've called you darling on emails. I'm sure you can handle the nickname *princey*."

Mydei sputtered "Don't say that out loud—"

"Oh? Why not?" Phainon chuckled, clearing his throat before yelling to no one at all— "I CALL MYDEI DARLING! HA!"

Mydei's fists curled up into balls, like he was ready to throw hands right then and there.

"No one heard. Shame." Phainon sighed.

"Shame? As if you have any of that."

"Ouch, Mydei. Low blow." He shook his head dramatically.

"Just— just do *something*." Mydei sniffed.

"You mean harvest?"

"Yes. That."

"Your wish is my command, princey."

"Knock it off or I knock off your head."

"Realistically, though" said Phainon as he gathered a bundle of wheat in his arms" *Can* you punch someone's head off?"

"Why are we talking about this right now?"

"Shush. Answer the question."

"Want me to test it out on you?" Mydei heaved a bundle of wheat onto his shoulder. That had no right being that hot. And distracting.

Scratch that, it was Mydei's very existence that was distracting.

They headed to the granary.

"Want to go to the nearby town?" Phainon asked, dusting his overalls, "Auntie told me that there's a small town nearby with a bar and a market."

"All right. But you're paying"

"Cheapskate, but it was my offer. So fine, I'll be gracious and pay for you."

"My hero" Mydei scoffed. The world 'hero' should have felt like poison after all this, but he found himself surprisingly okay.

From the open window, Phainon could see *that* outcropping. The one that felt like a hot iron brand on his skin. He was too much of a coward to go there so he followed Mydei back out of the granary.

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Years ago

Small hands trembled as they scrambled to dig up the earth. Mud caked under them, coagulating with the blood. His blood or their blood, he didn't know anymore. The actions were automatic, like he'd spent a lifetime digging graves and burying the deceased. Like he wasn't a child who had spent all his short years alive adored by the people he now had to send off. Ten down, five to go. Each adult body was too big for a child to drag and yet he managed to carry them anyways.

It was burying Cyrene that broke him.

Her sweet smile lost to the past, pink hair dyed red at the ends. Eyes open, glassy and unknowing, her skin of a pallor and stiff like he'd only seen on dead animals in the fields. And yet, her voice and the life she once had was a recent memory he would claw at to keep afloat.

He hoped she would know what he would do to bring her back and how much he missed her. But dead people are dead and forever unaware of the living. They will never know who grieved them or laid by their graves for hours, trying to wring every last bit of warmth out of their presence before the air got too cold and so did their hearts and they had to leave.

This wasn't supposed to happen.

They were supposed to grow up and do everything together. They were supposed to celebrate more birthdays together, play make believe in the fields where Phainon was the hero and Cyrene was his trusted guide and—-

She was supposed to be alive. She was supposed to be right next to him— a permanent fixture in his life. Not six feet under. They should've grown up together.

Even if their jobs turn out to be soul crushing and lack the luster of childhood, they would still have each other. Life is made beautiful by the people in it, so everything he saw right then was horribly revolting to him.

That was where he stayed for a long time: hunched over, hands clasped, shoulders shaking, begging whatever Titan would listen for it *to please be him too.*

Nobody answered.

Had he been a believer of divinity, he would have lost all faith.

Yet here he stood, the unholy spawn that they forgot to kill.

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Present day

The sun dipped below the horizon as he and Mydei reached the town. Nobody knew who they were and nobody cared. Life was slow; the locals strolling leisurely as they went about their day. Children ran back home from the park for dinner.

At the bar, Mydei took a sip of the drink and his upper lip curled in disgust as he set the glass down.

"Ugh. This stings. How are you able to choke that down?"

"Oh, this? Quite easily, actually. My sense of taste, uh, let's just say that scavenging and eating scraps in Styxia did a number on it."

Realisation passed through Mydei's features.

"So… you couldn't taste anything I made for you?"

"Not exactly, but hey! I can still taste pretty good food, so it's still a win. Wait, no— are you mad at me for not being able to taste your food? I'm sorry, trust me, I loved it!"

"No, you fucking idiot. I don't cook for just *anyone*. I cook for you because I know you like my food. I just didn't know you couldn't taste it. "

Phainon couldn't stand looking at Mydei anymore, afraid of what he would see. "Well, now you know!"

He then busied himself with swirling the drink and watching the ice melt.

Mydei went silent for a long time. Silence was the norm with Mydei, but this silence was more pensive. Contemplative. He downed one glass of vodka. And then another. Truly, his resistance to alcohol was one to be reckoned with.

"I will never get to know everything about you, will I?" Mydei said, resigned. He placed yet another glass down on the counter.

"Is that… really that important to you? Knowing everything about me?" Phainon said slowly.

"It may not seem like much to you, but yes. I want to know all there is to know about you. That is the way I show that I care."

"Blunt as always, huh, Mydei?" Phainon hid the blush on his cheeks by looking down at the drink and letting his hair hide his face. "Whatever happened to you hating my guts?"

"I still think you're an asshole. But you're a mildly tolerable, self sacrificing one."

"That almost sounds like praise."

"If I knew how to praise you properly, I would."

The number of times Mydei had made Phainon's heart soar with hope that should never have been there needed to be studied. *This meant nothing. This had to mean nothing.* Mydei was tipsy and so was Phainon. Just a bout of drunk honesty, nothing more.

Phainon stumbled, giggling giddily as Mydei hauled him out. One of Mydei's hands were hooked under Phainon's arm to stabilise him.

"Be grateful I'm lugging your ass out of here."

"Ah, but you love me too much to leave me stranded in the drains." Phainon drawled, staring up at the sky. It looked a lot prettier without all the pollution fogging up the stars.

"Trust me, I absolutely would do that. A very tempting choice, if you ask me." Mydei kicked Phainon's shin as he stumbled "HKS! Don't trip on flat

land!"

"Ow" Phainon whined, leaning his head on Mydei's shoulder. "Comfort me for the emotional and physical damage you have inflicted upon me."

"What? You gonna sue me for that?" Mydei was suddenly trying very hard to not look at Phainon

"Yeah."

"I think not. Now walk straight or I'll leave you stranded here."

"Cruel, cruel bastard" Phainon shook his head, grinning.

And if Phainon was allowed to hold Mydei's face in his hands and admire the softened expression on Mydei's face, he would.

The effect of the alcohol wore off by the time they got back to what remained of Aedes Elysiae.

"I'm sure that's Orion and that's Sagittarius— or am I getting those mixed up?" Phainon scrutinised the little specks of stars. "Cyrene used to get me to

memorise constellations when we were kids. She said they were gorgeous. I think so too."

Mydei whispered something in what sounded like Kremnoan.

"What does that mean?"

Mydei's tender expression vanished so quickly it was like it was never there to begin with. Instead, he wore that infuriating half- smirk half- scowl reserved only for Phainon. "It means that you are annoying, like a mosquito that buzzes in your ear."

Phainon sighed in exasperation.

"Way to kill the mood, Mydei."

"You're welcome, HKS." Mydei unzipped the tent and started untying his laces.

When Phainon clambered into the tent to find Mydei taking up most of the space there, some part of him died inside.

"Move over." Phainon grumbled.

"Right. I would if there was *space* here."

He was not going to survive being in such close proximity to Mydei, was he? Phainon squeezed himself as close to the edge of the tent as he could, stubbornly facing the wall.

"What're you doing, Deliverer?" Mydei asked, stifling a snort.

"Trying to maintain my personal space."

"Personal space? Since when did that become your priority?"

"Since a minute ago."

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Phainon's joints felt creaky the next morning. He'd spent last night squeezing himself to one corner of the tent and now his body regretted it. The day's worth of helping around with the fields did nothing to his sore joints, either. Auntie took one look at Phainon's sorry state and told him to take a break and relax.

"I can still—"

"No. Take this lemon juice and go rest."

Phainon sat by the lake, watching Mydei flit in and out of the granary, assisting Auntie in his stead. There was no sugar in the drink, since sugar was a rare commodity around here. The juice was still nice— salty and sour in a way that felt comforting.

Mydei walked back to him, wiping off the sweat from his brow with a towel. Phainon stood up as he approached, offering him the other glass he'd place beside him. Mydei took it and the whole thing felt so horribly mundane and *normal* that Phainon wondered if he even deserved this.

Maybe he was shooting himself in the foot with this one, but he voiced what had been at the tip of his tongue. "Have you ever been in love before?"

Mydei didn't blink, wiping his mouth with the back of his hand. "There was this one man called Hephaestion."

"Your first love?" Phainon asked, the words feeling like poison.

"We never dated."

"So you admit that you were still in love with him?"

"Love is a strong word for those feelings, but had we got the time to be together, we might have fallen in love." Mydei answered honestly— because of course he did. There was no other option for Mydei than to be himself— blunt and upfront.

Phainon felt ill. If, in any other universe, had Hephaestion remained by Mydei's side, Phainon would never have been able to stand by Mydei. A voice in his head whispered to him, *Fool. Mydei would always choose him over you. He was the original. You're just the backup. The backup bold enough to assume Mydei has feelings for you.*

Phainon had learned to live off scraps of love, for that was all he deserved and nothing more. The people he had dated just wanted the fame of dating the one and only Phainon. They would be everything Phainon wanted for a while until they eventually let go. Then Mydei came along and Mydei's attention and love was all he wanted. He was pathetic, a dog who followed the ones who gave him a second glance.

Why was he like this?

A complete mess, emotions all over the place, too numb to be afraid, but too scared to let go?

Mydei would always be Phainon's first choice. Phainon would never be Mydei's first choice. The truth hurt so much more than Phainon was

prepared to admit. See, this is why he kept everyone at a distance— so he wouldn't get too hurt in the end.

He messed up this time.

Phainon smiled serenely. He didn't care. He *didn't. He didn't.* "I'm sorry that happened"

"He had bigger things to do. So, I don't think we'd have stayed together for long. I cared for my people. He wanted a different life."

"So do you miss him?"

"I miss him as my friend, but not as something more. Those feelings were fleeting."

"Oh." Phainon didn't care. Mydei could love whoever he wanted and miss whoever he wanted. If Phainon were to leave, would Mydei miss him too?

Jealousy stung and so did his eyes from the tears that threatened to spill.

"HKS, what's gotten into you? By now, you'd be making fun of my abysmal love life."

Right. Phainon was supposed to act normal. Whatever that meant. He bent over, laughing. "You don't have to tell me twice. Tell me, was the almighty Mydei too afraid to confess his feelings?"

Was that convincing enough for you Mydei? I'm not jealous of him. I am not.

Mydei only frowned at Phainon's exaggerated response. Great. Now even he saw through his act.

"What? I'm sorry? This is ridiculous!" Phainon snorted.

Ridiculous how hard I've fallen for you and how I considered that, even for a moment, you liked me back.

"Of course you'd think that" Mydei shot Phainon a disgruntled look."Don't know why I expected anything different."

Different? Would Mydei rather have him lay his heart out?

"Nah, It's my job to make fun of your failures. Why should I feel anything else?"

Mydei narrowed his eyes. "And you feel what exactly?"

"I feel fine?"

Lies.

Mydei nodded slowly, processing what Phainon said. Phainon just said what he could to salvage their friendship. Mydei must appreciate his reaction— surely he would.

Phainon wiped a tear from his eye— of laughter, he knew, but it felt more like a tear of sorrow. "Say, have you kissed him?"

"Why are you asking me this?"

Because I'm jealous and want to kiss you so bad it makes me look stupid.

"Mmm, curiosity, maybe?" Is what Phainon said instead.

Mydei pursed his lips and looked away. "No."

"Never?"

"Never."

"Is there anyone in particular you want to kiss?"

"You'll hold my answer over my head, won't you?" Mydei scoffed ,"But yes."

Titans, why couldn't it be Phainon he wanted to kiss? What did Phainon do wrong? Is there anything he could have done to change the outcome? Mydei already had his heart and more, but if only he could have a fraction of Mydei's own heart.

"Why don't you try it on me instead?"

Mydei looked at Phainon like it was the first time he was seeing him.

Phainon's gut coiled painfully. If Mydei reacted like *that* to the notion of kissing him, then he hated to think that he ever had a chance. "That was a jo—"

Phainon didn't get to finish that sentence.

Mydei grabbed him by his collar and, in one swift move, kissed him roughly. Phainon's lips parted in surprise.

This was really happening.

Oh holy mother of Titans, this was real.

And Phainon was out here, standing stock still, making a fool of himself. See, this is why he didn't deserve good things. But as Mydei placed a hand on the back of Phainon's neck to bring him closer, Phainon's panic and self restraint was thrown into the lake. Phainon's hands went straight to Mydei's hair as he kissed him like he needed it to survive— because he did. Mydei's lips felt *right* against his. After what felt like an eternity and still not enough time, Mydei pushed Phainon away, breathing heavily.

"Don't we need to breathe? Don't tell me that you've forgotten that cardinal detail."

"Oxygen's overrated." Phainon licked his lips, scanning for any trace of the taste of Mydei's lips. Mydei swallowed, seemingly in a trance.

"Are you trying to *kill* me?" Mydei groaned.

"Is it working?"

"Yes." Mydei's answer was hused, almost embarassed.

"Exactly as I hoped." Phainon grinned.

Mydei muttered something that sounded like *"Nikador, save my dignity"* before pulling Phainon back in. Phainon chuckled, leisurely savouring the feel of Mydei's lips. Mydei was not a gentle kisser, but that was exactly what Phainon needed.

So he smiled against the kiss— like he had all the time in the world and more.

He didn't think he actually did, though. This was going to be the first and last time Mydei would ever kiss him. Phainon savoured every last second of it.

They pulled away, Mydei breathing heavily. Were they still friends after this?

Did friends kiss each other like their lives depended on it?

Phainon didn't think so.

A beat.

Then two.

Phainon let go of Mydei like he'd been burned. And perhaps he was burnt by the flame he was drawn to.

This would be no different from all the others he had kissed. A pretty face to look at for a day or two before the magic wore off and Phainon no longer mattered. But maybe, just maybe, Mydei would keep him around for a bit longer than a day and Phainon would enjoy the feeling for as long as he was allowed.

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Mydei wanted to kiss Phainon. Hold his hand, maybe even hold him. So what made it so difficult for him to gather the courage to do that?

Mydei was not a coward.

He was *not* someone to chicken out that easily.

But Phainon made him think otherwise. Around him, the usual certainty in Mydei's actions became obsolete because of those blue eyes and that infuriatingly pretty smile. Perhaps Mydei wasn't being overly affectionate because every time he turned to Phainon, he found himself in awe of him.

At least they were dating now.

Mydei stood by the dock, watching the water shimmer under the setting sun. Aedes Elysiae was beautiful, golden hued and crisp. Phainon had taken him to all the places he used to play in as a child. Most of Aedes Elysiae was wrecked, rubble strewn around— but the structures remained, as decrepit as they were. Phainon seemed to be at home here. He would side step the darkened bloodstained and carry himself with the lightness of a man who had never known death.

It was funny how someone used to his own death fell for someone used to death surrounding him.

Phainon emerged from Miss Adara's house carrying a basket and two fishing poles, hoisting them over his head proudly.

"She found them in a closet" Phainon said, "Turns out they were still functional."

After handing Mydei one of the fishing lines, he turned to the water too. "Wanna see who can catch more fish?"

"Are we really doing this right now?"

"I don't hear a no"

"Tsk. Imbecile."

Phainon stuck his tongue out at Mydei and threw his fishing line into the water. Mydei watched in amusement as Phainon glared daggers at the surface of the water, no doubt impatient to reel in a fish.

"Glaring at the fishing line isn't going to attract more fish and you know it." Mydei remarked, lazily dropping his own fishing line into the water. He sat on the wooden dock, watching his line bob in the water.

"Shut up."

"Or what?"

"I'll shove a fish down your throat" An empty threat from Phainon, but that made Mydei bark out a laugh.

"That is, if you can catch one."

"You—" Phainon was stopped short by a tug at his fishing line. "Shit." He said, yanking the line back with more force than required. The fish went soaring in the air, flopping miserably. It landed on the ground behind them.

"Well, that was one way to reel a fish in." Mydei chortled.

"I swear, I've done this before! I'm just out of practise."

"Whatever you say, my dear Deliverer, whatever you say." Mydei shook his head fondly.

Phainon scoffed and looked away. He was doing a remarkably bad job at hiding his red tinged cheeks.

Cute.

Mydei was interrupted by a sharp tug at his fishing rod.

"Got anything?" Phainon asked, craning his head to get a better view.

"Would you look at that. Decent catch, no?" Mydei asked, holding up the fish.

Phainon could only gape at him in envy.

"Even I couldn't catch that— what in the holy city of Okhema? I didn't even know that Aedes Elysiae's waters housed such enormous fishes."

Mydei threw the fish back into the water, letting it swim about freely. The fish Phainon caught would be sufficient. "Hm."

"Unfair." Phainon muttered, shooting Mydei a dirty look.

"What was that? Say it louder; I couldn't hear you the last time"

"For the love of—"

"You're positively green with envy, Deliverer."

"No, I am not."

Mydei reached for Phainon's hand as they headed back. Phainon retracted his hand as Mydei made contact with it— reflex, almost. Phainon looked down at Mydei's hand, then at him and then tentatively reached for Mydei's hand.

"You cold or something?" Phainon murmured, interlacing his fingers with Mydei's.

"What?"

"Yeah, is the breeze too cold? I do tend to run hot after all." Phainon raised their entwined hands, as if to prove a point.

Did that brainless idiot think that Mydei wanted warmth?

Mydei should really re evaluate the choices he made that led him to this point.

"Oh, you're back! Just in time."

Miss Adara was tidying up the dining table, which had seeds scattered over it. She was preparing for the next harvest season. A small smile played on her lips as she spotted their interlocked hands.

"Got the guy, huh?"

"Yeah, I guess you could say that." Mydei nodded.

"Good on you, kid. Knew you two would figure it out."

If *figure it out* meant Phainon staring blankly at him every time Mydei tried to initiate affection , then so be it.

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They didn't talk about the kiss for a week.

Phainon found that he didn't really want to bring it up either, in fear of Mydei's response. Life went on as usual. Phainon waited in trepidation for Mydei to corner him and demand they forget their momentary lapse of judgment. That never came.

Mydei did try to hold his hand that one time, but Phainon tamped down any fluttery feelings from that gesture.

By now, the anxiety had chipped away at his feelings, so as he and Mydei sat by the lake as usual, he decided to throw all caution to the wind.

It was now or never.

"Mydei, I know you don't like me back, but I'm in love with you. I have been in for who knows how long now. I don't know if this will make you hate me, but I do. Go ahead then, reject me and get this over with as quickly as you can."

"Phainon."

"Yes?" Phainon cringed.

"I did not just kiss you for nothing. What did you *think* when we kissed?"

"That… uh—"

"Spit it out."

"That you wanted to have a fling with me or something? I know I'm attractive as hell and—"

Mydei had no right to look that offended.

"Is that all you thought I wanted?" His voice was quiet, dangerous.

Phainon took a second to consider it. "Yes. Because that's what everyone wants. I stand corrected, though. So tell me, what do you want with me?"

"You're unbelievable." Mydei scoffed, "I want to be yours. As simple as that. "

Those words felt foreign to Phainon's ears.

"You like me enough to want that with me?" Phainon asked slowly.

Mydei, bless his beautiful, beautiful soul, didn't flinch or rebuke his words."Yes. For a long time, ideally."

"I didn't realise." Phainon said, his voice faint.

"How did you think that any of this wasn't us dating? We kissed. Multiple times, might I add. We went on dates. We held hands and I told you that you

are more radiant than all the stars in the sky."

What

What. The. Fuck.

"You said *what*?" exclaimed Phainon, hardly believing it. "But— you compared me to a mosquito— not *this*."

Mydei said that to him. Mydei looked at his pathetic self and decided that that was worth thinking of as something radiant.

Mydei avoided Phainon's gaze and crossed his arms. "I did both. Now, what possessed you to think that we *weren't* dating? Did you need me to spell it out loud and underline it for it to register?"

"Well, maybe a confirmation would have been good, you obtuse asshole. Romance is supposed to be— I don't know, *romantic*?"

Mydei rolled his eyes."Please, we've been plenty romantic. Look at the emails you've been sending me."

"That was us fighting!" Phainon enunciated each word with his finger, pointed accusingly at Mydei's chest.

Mydei's hand wrapped around Phainon's finger, pushing it down. The feeling of Mydei's hand around his made Phainon feel lightheaded. "For someone so sharp, you're awfully obtuse when it comes to romance."

"Like you're any better at it. You called insulting me a love language."

"HKS, did you perhaps forget the food I cook for you?"

"I can cook too. I cook really well actually—"

"You're just lazy, but that's besides the point." Mydei snarked. "There is no word for romance in the Kremnoan language."

"What do you guys even have in the Kremnoan language then?"

"Plenty of words"

"And you still don't have one for romance?"

"I would invent a word for romance if that's what it took for me to be with you."

Phainon must have looked incredibly stupid with his face beet red.

"You look ridiculous. Shut your mouth, you'll attract flies." said Mydei, unimpressed.

"You can't just *say* things like that" Phainon accused, his voice hoarse. He wanted to wrench his heart out of his chest to get it to stop beating so loudly.

"I don't see any laws telling me not to. What's so unbelievable about me loving you too?"

"You like— no— *love me.* What the hell did I do to deserve that?"

"Plenty of people love you. So why shouldn't I?"

"They never love me, Mydei. I made the foolish mistake of thinking they did when I was younger and got my heart broken. I am not worth loving, I can assure you that."

"I'm still trying to figure out how anyone can look at you and decide you aren't worth loving."

"Aren't I annoying ?" Phainon asked slowly.

"Annoying, yes, but the most lovable person I have ever seen."

The butterflies in his stomach seemed to reach his throat. *Damn you, Mydei.*

Damn you for making me hope for something I had long since given up on.

How could Phainon ever live with himself if he tethered Mydei down to him? Mydei was an unrestrained, breathtaking fire and Phainon was a moth who would burn to death if only he got to bathe in the warmth of the flame one last time before he perished.

"Mydei. You deserve better than what I can offer you. You— you know what you deserve— and it's the entire fucking world. I could give you my still beating heart, straight from my ribcage and offer you all the time I have left and it still would amount to nothing of what you're worth."

Mydei glared at Phainon disbelievingly. He ran a hand through his hair, bewilderment written all over his face. "How do you not realise how much *you* deserve? The kind of person you are— titans, you are selfless and kind

unlike no other. You exude warmth. Are you blind so as to not notice any of that?"

"I— I don't—"

"Then tell me. What do you think you deserve,then?"

"I get more than what I deserve by just having you here."

"So you'll go your entire life off a few kisses and me holding your hand?"

"Yes. That itself was far too much for something like me."

"You don't even see yourself as a *person* at this point." It sounded like Mydei was the one in pain, not Phainon. The fight was drained out of Phainon, to the point at which meaningless reassurances would do nothing.

"True. It's hard to."

A long pause.

"Let me love you. It's embarrassing that I have to ask, but here it is anyways. Let me be the first one you look for when you're sad, even if it's over the smallest of things. Let me be witness to your raw, unfiltered emotions. Let me just be there for you."

Phainon let out a disbelieving huff. *This could not be happening right now.* No way would anyone look at him like *that.* Like he was more than just a person who happened to be useful at the right time. Like he was loved.

"Phainon. I love you, or so help myself—" Mydei grit his teeth. "You are the single most stubborn, infuriating, hardheaded fool and despite all that, I love you. That amounts to something, don't you think?"

"I'm not the easiest person to love."

"And I love you anyways."

Mydei's stare was as much a challenge as it was him revealing all his cards. The message was clear: *And there's nothing you can do about it.*

"I won't make you happy."

"Says who? Have I ever looked unhappy in your presence? You have no say in whether I stay or not. I chose to be here."

Phainon was running out of ideas to run away and hide. Mydei took a step forward, eyes steely and defiant. His voice was a snarl as he spoke."I led the Kremnoan Detachment. I was the leader of Kremnos. *I am Mydeimos, son of Gorgo*. I stick to my fucking promises and I refuse to let you go."

To have someone fight so fiercely for him, even against his own self destructive tendencies, was something Phainon never thought he would experience.

"Is this a confession of your love or a declaration of war? It sounds like a bit of both, honestly. " Phainon chuckled weakly.

"…HKS."

Phainon swallowed. "So… we're dating now?"

"I did not just spend this long trying to convince you that I loved you and wanted to be with you to have you question if I wanted to date you." Mydei scoffed, "How I fell for someone this stupid is beyond me."

Phainon lunged at Mydei, kissing him.

Mydei stumbled backward, catching Phainon. He sighed against Phainon's lips and kissed him back without protest.

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That night, Phainon sprawled freely over the sleeping bags. No more having to awkwardly stuff himself into a corner.

Phainon laid his head on Mydei's chest and closed his eyes. Mydei's arms wrapped around him as if on instinct and Phainon let out a content sigh. "You're warm."

"Am I your personal heater?" Mydei grumbled, but made no sign of wanting to move.

"Yes, now shut up and hold me."

Phainon shut his eyes, his arms snaking around Mydei's waist. Mydei felt like the closest thing to home. Mydei absentmindedly ran his fingers through Phainon's hair.

Phainon felt sleep pull him in and for once, he didn't have any nightmares.

Dawn broke through, light streaming in through the tent's walls. Bleary eyed, his eyes focused on Mydei asleep too, with his head tipped back against the sleeping bag. Phainon felt something tug at his hair. He reached up, feeling the little braids sticking up. Mydei snorted. He had woken up.

"What did you do to my hair?" Phainon scowled.

"You fell asleep first."

"I look ridiculous." Phainon complained, tugging at his hair.

"Yeah, you do." A fond smile played on Mydei's features. Phainon never wanted to take the stupid braids off. He flopped back down onto Mydei.

Mydei coughed upon the impact. "HKS!" He yelled.

"You're weaker than I thought, Mydei." Phainon teased

"And you're heavy as fuck."

Phainon coughed, "Weak."

"I'll show you who's weak, you—"

Mydei didn't finish that sentence. He stared at Phainon, amazed.

"What?"

"Your face."

"I've said it once and I will say it again. *What*?"

"You're not wearing that stupid manufactured smile. You look—"

"Horrid?"

"—happy. Finally fucking happy." Mydei smiled that smile that makes Phainon's heart somersault and seize up.

"I look *happy?* I thought that's how I always look."

"No, this time it's different." Mydei shook his head.

"Good or bad?"

"Good, obviously."

Phainon smiled contentedly.

"You two can have the day off. Relax a bit." Auntie said after breakfast. She turned to Phainon,"Have you visited them yet?"

Phainon shook his head. "I'll do it today."

"All right then, good luck." She patted Phainon's shoulder reassuringly.

"Come, Mydei. Let me show you my family." Phainon said once they stepped out of the house.

Mydei recognised what he meant instantly. "Should I bring flowers?"

"There aren't many flowers in this particular area. So don't. Just come with me."

As they approached the painfully familiar patch of land, Phainon's breath caught in his throat. Wildflowers had bloomed over the spot where he buried Cyrene. Yellow, purple, red and white decorated the ground above her, a wreath of flowers honouring the prettiest girl who had ever lived.

A lump in his throat formed at that sight and refused to budge.

"Would you look at that" Phainon breathed. "Turns out flowers do grow here."

Mydei carefully watched Phainon as he sat down in front of their graves. "Allow me to introduce you to Mydei. He's my boyfriend and he used to be the leader of Kremnos."

"Hello, Phainon's family. I would have liked to get to know you." Mydei sat down next to him.

"You do realise they can't hear us, right? I'm just being sentimental."

"Yeah, I know. I do that too— speaking to my mother."

"This world is a strange place, I think. They tell you that you have your whole life ahead of you and you never realise how… temporary it all is until you see someone else's future stolen from them. The one they, like

you, were sure they would have. It hits you that *you* could have been the one to die instead."

"That's true. Is that why you're so scared of losing other people?"

"… Yeah. It is."

"Well, if it means anything to you, I can promise you and your family that I will never leave you."

"Never?"

"Never. I will always be right here."

"And if I annoy you to no end?"

"I'll still be there."

"And if I'm stupidly oblivious and insecure?"

"Still there."

Phainon laughed breathlessly. He couldn't believe he finally had someone who wanted to stay.

"See?" Phainon said to his family's graves, "Mydei will be here for me. Mydei, tell your mom her son lucked out because he got himself a guy who'd kill for him."

"Don't be ridiculous."

"Mydei, I have killed for you before." Phainon said, levity evaporating in an instant.

To his credit, Mydei didn't look too surprised. "That time I—"

"Yeah. You died and I killed the person who killed you. I don't remember how I did it, but I killed him."

"How romantic of you, Deliverer."

Phainon snorted. "Yeah. The epitome of romance is indeed killing your lover's killer."

They lingered by the graves for a while longer.

"You buried them?" Mydei asked

"All of them."

Silence.

"That is honourable and you should know it." Mydei wiped the tears from Phainon's cheeks. He didn't even realise he was crying.

"…Yeah." Phainon let his head fall onto Mydei's shoulder as they walked away.

Phainon took a deep breath, the warm feeling in his chest being one that was hard to dislodge. Stretching, he sped up a bit to walk in front of Mydei because he didn't want to cry any more than he already had.

"Say, what's that sun tattoo for?" Mydei asked.

"Oh, this one? Got it when I decided to become the hero I was told I would be. Look at me now, useless to Okhema. They used to describe a hero as

someone strong enough to protect and save. So that's what I tried to do. That's what I've always tried to do."

Mydei just looked at him with something close to understanding."You should've had a childhood unburdened by all… this."

"So did you. You deserve a childhood more than me, for all you've known is battle. Mydei, do you realise how messed up war is? No child should have to go to war."

"Yes. I know. I had no choice. And I doubt you had a better childhood than I."

"I did have a good childhood, at least for a while. Then my home fell and I stayed in Styxia and then I realised that I ought to protect those that couldn't protect themselves. Styxia was… bad. Really bad." Phainon closed his eyes briefly, "What am I now? Now that Okhema no longer needs its Deliverer since it's seen the dawn?"

"You live."

The words were so rimple and straightforward that Phainon only blinked in confusion. "How?"

"Find your passion. It can take days or months or years or a lifetime, but it's *yours*."

"And what of you?"

"They used to tell me I was destined for great things. I didn't want those 'great things' to have to mean bloodshed and sacrifice." Mydei recounted,"I was born for the protection of my Kremnoans. When they no longer needed me as their leader, I joined CHRYSOS to continue protecting them. Okhema will take a long time to welcome them, but someday, they will. I've never known living for myself, I will admit. So maybe it's time I figure that out."

"You don't know what to do with yourself either, huh?"

"No." Mydei admitted, "But I'll find something."

"So we're in this together, then?"

"Yes."

Phainon smiled, tipping his head back to gaze at the sky. Breathing felt easier.

"Yeah, I think we'll be alright."

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CHRYSOS became one of the most reputable colleges in Okhema. Aglaea still ran CHRYSOS with every bit of her earlier conviction. Tribios remained as a teacher, her easy warmth and knowledge making her a beloved staff among the new students.

Hyacine continued working as Prof Anaxa's teaching assistant, helping cover up when he had wild ideas mid lecture and strode out of the class, cackling madly.

"Sorry!" She'd say, "He'll be back next week, folks!"

Castorice was working on her thesis— still researching poisons in the lab of CHRYSOS. She'd welcomed Phainon when he and Mydei got back from Aedes Elysiae.

"Phainon! You're back!"

"Guess what?" Phainon pulled out his phone, opening his gallery. He showed it to Castorice.

"Are you… kissing Mydei's cheek?"

"Yep!" Phainon grinned.

She gaped at him, laughing disbelievingly. "It happened."

"It did!! Mydei's my boyfriend now."

It felt like winning, finally being able to call Mydei his.

The two of them spent the next few minutes giggling giddily.

"Hey, little deliverer and princess homebody." Cipher strolled into the lab, probably done with her surveillance duty. "What's got you two so happy?"

"I don't think that matter should be of your concern, Cipher." Phainon said, waving his hand dismissively.

"What he means to say is—" Castorice began.

"Oh, that little prince? You've got taste, I'll give you that." She remarked, scrolling through Phainon's phone. He had an obnoxious number of pictures of Mydei in his camera roll and he had no intention of letting anyone ever see the folder dedicated to Mydei, least of all Cipher. Wait. Why did she have his phone? How did she get his phone? Phainon could have sworn he was just holding it.

"Looking for this?" Cipher giggled, tossing Phainon's phone back at him. "Don't worry, I won't steal it. Unless?"

One look at Phainon's scandalised expression and she burst into fits of laughter.

Mydei opened a library. His childhood dream with his mother, he'd said. Mydei would search for, recover old texts from Kremnos and translate them.

And Phainon himself? He was still looking. He spent most of his time in the Library of Garbaniphoro with Mydei. Mydei had brought in some old Kremnoan relics recently. At first, he let Phainon poke around them for fun to decide if they were genuine or fake, but Phainon had recently started finding antique appraisal interesting.

His day started later than Mydei's, so he woke up to an empty bed and breakfast already on the table. He hadn't bothered to move back into his old dorn. Mydei had once scowled and said Phainon was mooching off him, but he continued to peel Phainon's apple anyways.

Phainon strolled into the Library of Garbaniphoro in search of Mydei, carrying a take out bag with pomegranate milk in one hand and his own empty coffee cup in the other. As usual, Mydei sat at his desk, poring over a yellowed script. Damn, he looked good in that turtleneck. But when did Mydei ever not look hot?

"Hey Mydei" Phainon drawled as he sidled up to Mydei.

Mydei grunted in acknowledgement.

"Cold. Guess I won't be able to give you this." Phainon took out the pomegranate milk "It even has goat milk in it."

"HKS, I'm trying to focus. Go sit in your corner. And leave the drink over here."

Phainon groaned exaggeratedly before retreating to his usual place near Mydei.

"But I'm bored." Phainon whined.

"Then go examine the new artifacts I got in. You seem to enjoy doing that."

"Fine."

Phainon didn't leave for hours. He was perfectly content to stay there, right by Mydei's side. These days were quiet and slow and Phainon loved every second of it.

Before Phainon left to go meet with Hyacine at 5, Mydei got up to go help a patron find a book. Phainon tore off a page from his notebook and scribbled something in it. He'd been doing the same thing for months now and Mydei's reaction each time was priceless.

Hi, I just thought you look hot in that turtleneck and I wanna take you out on a date. Chimera cafe maybe? You like the chimeras there.

Call me!

xxx xxx xxxx

love, your one and only <3

(you're paying for the date don't be a miser)

Phainon slipped the note into Mydei's log book, cackling to himself.

Sure enough, the email came soon after.

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>4:45PM
to me ▼

HKS WHAT THE FUCK

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>4:46PM
to Mydei ▼

My beautiful, radiant, gorgeous, too sacred for words Mydei,

;)

Your fervent admirer,

Phainon

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>4:46PM
to me ▼

If you wanted to ask me out on a date that badly, you could've just walked up to me and not embarrassed me in front of visitors when I opened my log book.

When I catch you.

WHEN I CATCH YOU.

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>4:47PM
to Mydei ▼

My extremely hot boyfriend Mydei,

Sooooo should I be running or is this some sort of foreplay?

Your even hotter boyfriend (I'm better than you),

Phainon

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>4:48PM
to me▼

My darling ray of sunshine Phainon,

I'd say you have until six o clock until I track you down and dismember your organs one by one.

Armed with a knife,

Mydei.

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>4:48PM
to Mydei▼

My Mydei,

All right so it's a fear for your life type of situation. Got it. You using that knife to cut out my heart? When it's already yours? Rookie mistake

Just saying, I think you'd look hot when you rip out my organs so feel free.

Love, Phainon.

Mydei <mydei.389@email.com>4:49PM
to me▼

You're insane and I don't know why I put up with you.

I hate how much I love your stupid face.

Phainon <phainon.419@email.com>4:49PM
to Mydei ▼

Then come kiss it.

Chapter End Notes

> And cut! That's the end of the story I spent months on. I've seen a lot of mistakes and even more areas for improvement, but I'm still really happy I wrote my first ever longfic. The grind is never truly over and I will try to write more fics, albeit shorter than this monstrosity of a long fic.(I say this as I inevitably crank out another longfic someday) If you've made it this far, I am beyond elated. I never expected this fic to go this far, but I'm so glad it did.
>
> To my readers and commenters, thank you so so much for sticking around to see this through. Your comments are what I keep returning to because of just how much they mean to me. Thank you for having the patience to sit through my writing<333333

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!